

KT MORRISON

AWAY GAME

DOMINATED BY THEIR LANDLORD



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Away Game

Dominated By Their Landlord

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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All characters are over the age of eighteen.

AWAY GAME

A LANDLORD NOVEL

46,000 words

First Edition. Aug 11, 2018.

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I

Lawyers And Shopping

Chapter One

On a rainy Monday morning, Reza drove them to the lawyer's office, Charlie sitting in the front leather seat of Reza's Mercedes sedan, Jonny alone in the back. She looked comfortable, he thought, while sitting in the back behind Reza, but of course she would—she and Reza had been out together a few times. The fact she'd been in Reza's expensive car before—without him—turned his stomach over. He shifted in the seat, tugged at the seatbelt, then at the front of his khakis which had pulled taut over his wire chastity cage strapped around his genitals.

Another thing that was irritating him: the car's expensive stereo system thumped and boomed a dumb, repetitive rap song. Something current and popular though Jonny couldn't place it. It was irritating, with inane lyrics—something to do with going out to the club, something to do with dubs. Whatever that was. Shit some people do to rhyme.

The music was bad enough, but what was making him shift more and more in his seat was Charlie didn't seem bothered by it. Not that Jonny was against rap music, it's just that it had never appealed to Charlie before. She liked simple country songs. Not even the new country music, but older songs, like from the Grand Ole Opry, back when it was really 'ole.'

He watched her from the backseat, even nodding her little chin along with the beat. Her ginger curls shaking, her eyes glancing around and out the windows as the wipers slip-slapped across the windshield. They were in the city center, and people bustled on the sidewalks in a hazy gray blur, cowering under their black umbrellas. Traffic was at a standstill, but they were almost there. Charlie had her hair pulled back from her face, wore a nice button-down collared shirt, a navy blazer, a wool skirt, and leggings with loafers. Reza wore a typical black suit with a black V-neck underneath. All Jonny had were his khaki pants, a button-down shirt, and a wool sweater that had begun pilling.

Reza hired his lawyer to handle Jonny's company's more thorough incorporation—he'd done it by himself online a few years ago—and notarize Reza's small percentage ownership. The lawyer was on the 35th floor of the Empire Crest building. Solomon, Woolworth & Sickler were high-powered lawyers with offices that looked out east, with a grand view of the water.

Reza parked the car in the underground and they got out together without saying anything. The Mercedes chirped and flashed its lights as Reza set the alarm with his key fob while Jonny stood hidden behind the car shaking out one pant leg and trying to relieve a tight pinching against his scrotum. Reza and Charlie walked away together, and he trotted to catch up with them, hobbling along with one straight leg to stop the pinch from getting worse. He caught up with them at the doors of the glass and metal vestibule that led to the elevators.

The cage that sealed his genitals took some getting used to. At first it had been a breeze. Charlie locked the stainless cage on him and he felt the burden alleviated—all he could think about now was work. And that really was all he should be thinking about. Work should be his sole thought until he'd finished his game, made money, paid off Reza, and got his wife back.

It wasn't so simple.

Reza got home later that night and climbed into bed with Charlie who was already sleeping. Jonny was working away at his workstation but watched in the cosmetic mirror on his desk what happened behind. Reza spooned behind Charlie, his hands caressing her under the sheets, and like a good and dutiful wife Charlie turned to face him, let him kiss at her neck and collar. When he was hard, he retrieved a condom from the side table, Charlie's hand stroking his cock under the sheets.

It was too much.

Blood pumped between his legs, but instead of pleasure and excitement all he felt was discomfort. Intense discomfort. His cock hardened, pushed against his cage, swelling and shoving down on the ring that held it in place. It felt like his balls were going to pop off. He'd had to leave. Get out

of the room. The urgency of his discomfort was paralleled by the angst of leaving Charlie and Reza alone together.

In the bathroom, he'd examined his confinement, standing by the vanity with his pants around his ankles. His penis had swelled against the wires, been indented by them, the whole cage pushed downward by his arousal but the ring that circled the base of his penis and scrotum had pulled his testicles tightly against the skin, making it gleam in the bathroom light. It was awful. He'd had to sit on the edge of the tub with his head down, elbows on knees, hands clamped over his ears so he wouldn't hear any of Charlie's sex sounds.



The paperwork was easier than he'd anticipated. They'd arrived at the law offices that served Reza, were given coffee by a polite young woman in a tight shirt and skirt. Didn't even have time to finish it before they were ushered into the office of a pretty slick looking young guy named Solomon. He seemed to know Reza pretty well, and they clasped hands, shared a couple of knowing looks that made Jonny worried this lawyer knew of the 'home' arrangement. Knew that this guy in the shitty sweater's wife spread her legs for Reza. Knew that this paperwork today was just one more cinch of the noose around Jonny's neck. Did they laugh behind his back? Did Reza tell this young lawyer what a good lay this cute little redhead chick was?

Whatever. It didn't matter. There was no way around this anymore, so he finished off his coffee, gave Charlie's wrist a little squeeze and sat down in a low but very heavy wooden chair padded with leather that sat across from the lawyer's desk. Solomon sat down as well, the expanse of the city out his wide window. Rain came down in sheets against the glass, and in between capricious gusts Jonny saw the gritty gray architecture revealed; in and out like the pulse of a heartbeat.

The paperwork was presented to him with a brief instruction, but mostly it was all laid out in colored tabs and he just had to follow along and fill his name in. Sheets upon sheets he glanced over to make sure he wasn't signing over his firstborn somehow. You couldn't trust Reza.

The language was pretty clear, and it didn't take long before each of the little colored tabs sticking out the sides were completed. Signatures delivered on all the documents necessary. And that was it. Now whatever Jonny Keen's video game company made, 5% of it would go into his landlord's pocket. A few months ago that would really have stuck him hard. Right now he didn't care. He might've talked tough over the 5% ownership when he was negotiating with Reza but the truth was he would do just about anything for this to be over. The drive he had inside, the things he knew how to do ... he would never stop until he was successful. It was just a matter of time before he could pay Reza back. The sooner the better. So 5% of his company to Reza was really a bargain because it brought him closer to the time when Charlie's heart would be his alone again. More accurately, her pussy—they always had each other's hearts, it was her pussy he was currently denied.

Leaving the offices, nodding politely to the secretary who was back behind her desk, they then walked concrete halls to the elevator bank and he thought back to the evenings when life was good, before all this began. How his pretty wife would come home from her job at the library, he would be hard at work developing his game—this was of course back before he had defrauded the Chinese investors. But despite the badness he knew was at the core of his business back then those sure were wonderful times. If he could only get that back ...

In the elevator the three of them stood together again. He shifted uncomfortably, his hand fumbled around at his thigh looking for Charlie's. He found her warm little hand under the cuff of her jacket and he held her fingers and rubbed his thumb around her wedding ring.

He gave her a little smile and saw a gentle smile returned on her face, and he knew that signing those papers today was the right thing. Fuck pride. Fuck everything. He'd be nothing if he didn't have this beautiful girl.

Reza leaned forward, big blunt finger pressing ‘C’ for Concourse.

Jonny bristled. Charlie sensed it, too. Something was up. She asked Reza, “Where are we going?”

“It’s a surprise,” Reza grumbled.

Charlie’s hand tensed on his, he felt her thumb squeeze against his knuckles.



On the concourse level they wandered the marble halls of a shopping mall. It was a late Monday morning and the early commute was over, but still it was packed. Below the Empire Crest building was a three-level shopping complex connected to four other sky-rises and two different subway stations. Reza led them to the first set of escalators and they headed deeper down together, him ahead of them as they lingered behind, and Jonny held Charlie’s hand protectively.

Charlie gave his hand a polite and gentle double-squeeze and he looked at her. She whispered, “What do you think the surprise is?”

“Beats me,” he said.

Charlie looked a little worried, and while she still held his hand he felt a certain clamminess in her grip now. She bounced a little on her toes, and he saw that she was chewing on her lower lip; her bright white canine gnawed the curled corner of her plump vermilion. Her head tracked from left to right, oscillating back-and-forth, eyes going up and down as she took in the mall. A little frown creased her brow. Her tenseness brought a frown of his own.

Everything with Reza was difficult. There was no way this surprise was going to be something fun. Sure, the man would present it that way, lower them into it slowly, then the ax would fall and reality would chop his head off. Hopefully not Charlie's as well.

Charlie leaned close again, and she asked him, "You don't think there's a store here that would sell those cages?" She made a curt, surreptitious nod between his legs but he already knew what she meant.

"I don't think so," he told her. "A store like that wouldn't be in this upscale place."

His suspicious wife murmured, "You never know ...". She shared some of her mother's disdain for the big city.

"You think he got my cage here?" Jonny asked, wondering why she would care.

Eyes still glancing around, she leaned her head close to him, and whispered, "No. I'm worried he's going to try to get you a smaller one or something."

That gave him a little tap in the stomach. The cage he wore was already too small. How did she think he could wear a smaller one? He said, "Smaller one? I barely fit into this one."

Now her lips pursed, and he saw she was thinking something.

"What is it?" he said to her.

"Nothing."

He leaned close now, too, gave her hand a squeeze. "Tell me what it is."

Charlie sighed, stalling. She began to speak then stopped. She started again: "I don't know, it can't be true ...". She pulled away, like she didn't want to say any more. Then she returned. "He told me that that little cage you're wearing will shrink your penis."

He startled at the thought. He said, "That's impossible."

“I know, right? It sounded crazy. I thought he was just being a jerk. Teasing me ...”

“He told you wearing a cage would shrink my penis?”

“Yeah. He said that denying you sex and making you wear a tight little cage will make your penis shrink.”

“That’s impossible, Charlie,” he said, frowning.

Now it started to work around in his head, wondering if it wasn’t impossible that could happen. Could Reza shrink his penis if he kept introducing smaller and smaller cages? He shook his head, squinted his eyes—got those thoughts right out of his head.

He squeezed Charlie’s hand again, got close and said, “Don’t worry, Charlie. That’s just crazy talk. He’s teasing you.” But the fear was in him now that this trip to the shopping concourse would end up at some sort of weird BDSM store, and Charlie and Reza would pick out an even smaller cage to stuff his genitals inside.



Instead of some bondage shop, Reza stopped outside an upscale boutique at the far end of the concourse Jonny thought would be somewhere underneath the old Romeo-McMillan building. Instead of mannequins in leather corsets and circled whips on their hips, male ones with chastity cages, this elegant-looking shop had halogen lights spotlighting alabaster models wearing caftans, swimsuits, bikinis, and light summer dresses. Pretty hopeful given the grim weather outside this morning.

Jonny led Charlie to stand next to Reza while the other shoppers filed around them on either side. Reza gestured with his hand for them to enter, and Charlie asked him, “What are we doing here?”

Reza said, “Would you please just go in?—we’re standing in the way out here.”

Charlie said, “Why are you so mad?”

Reza shook his head, pinched the bridge of his nose. He said, “You’re so timid. You need to come out of your shell. I brought you to the shop, would you please just go in?”

“Fine,” she sighed and let Jonny’s hand go, straightened her jacket and walked ahead of them—stopped short, almost tumbling over a woman’s stroller. She apologized, avoided looking back at them, waited for the woman to pass, then walked into the store.

It was Jonny and Reza alone now, and Jonny asked him, “What are you doing now?”

“Your wife needs better clothes.”

“Sure. She probably does. You’ve been buying her nicer things already. Why here? Why now?”

“I’m taking her away for the weekend, Jonny. I want her dressed up just right.”

Chapter Two

When he walked in the store, Charlie saw his expression and knew something was wrong. He shook his head and tried to clear his face because he hadn't wanted to show her how bothered he was.

"What's wrong?" she said.

"Ask Reza."

The three of them were standing now in the quiet foyer by a low, round oak table centered inside the entrance. Nicely folded shirts, tops, and skirts ran around it, another alabaster manikin in the center wearing a wide straw hat. Not unlike what Charlie should wear if she were going somewhere warm. That alabaster skin wasn't far off his wife's complexion, either. Just add some freckles.

Deeper in the store there were side tables with flowers, clothing, displays with more manikins, shelves and shelves of clothes and racks with neatly lined hangers. A woman waited near the back of the shop smiling at them with her hands clasped at her waist.

Charlie's mouth swished around as she studied him, and she bit that lower lip again and looked to Reza. "Why is Jonny mad? What is it now?"

"I don't know why he would be" Reza said, his palms out to the side and closing his eyes. There was a smirk there pulling up that villain mustache of his to one side. Like he knew exactly why Jonny would be mad. It was maddening, and Jonny would like to be nowhere else than at home right now banging out code and lining up more help to get this game done and shove the contract back in this arrogant son of a bitch's face. Put an end to this.

Reza continued, “I have business in the Caribbean. I’m not gonna go alone, now am I? Not when I have the prettiest girl in the world, I want her on my arm. I’m taking you to the Bahamas this weekend.”

Jonny watched her expression. Was waiting to see how she would react. It wasn’t great. It hurt him. He saw the initial shock, then a brief, bubbling burst of joy, then saw that snuffed out as his wife realized she was being watched. That happiness had a wet blanket thrown over it, but he knew it was just a performance. He saw that she was excited when she heard she might be going away.

Charlie said, “How? Will I have to miss work?”

“We leave on Friday night,” he said, “and I’ll have you back on Sunday night. It’s business, but we’ll have lots of pleasure. We’ll have to pack it all in to two days. You can take Monday off if you want, you might want to call and let them know. I imagine you’ll be pretty exhausted.”

Jonny wiggled his toes and grabbed at the insoles of his shoes. He would give anything to get away with kicking Reza in the stomach right now. Sometimes he looked at him with pure hate. And every time he did, Reza sighed and gave back to Jonny an expression that showed he didn’t give a shit. Jonny was nothing to him.



Charlie asked Reza, “Can Jonny come?” Her mouth slimmed to a pursed line while she waited for an answer.

Reza scoffed. “No, Charlie, I’m not buying him a seat, hang around my neck when I got shit to do down there. Jonny’s got a lot on his plate right now and he better start taking big bites. Why you want to make it harder on him?”

“I’m not,” she said sheepishly

“Give me your hand,” Reza said more kindly.

“What?” Charlie said petulantly, not liking being scolded. Her lips had pouted and her brow lowered; she held up her thin graceful hand so he could take it.

Reza held her hand with the slender digits hooked over his index finger, his thumb caressing around her wedding ring. “Let your husband do what he’s got to do. You know he’s busy, you just watched him sign away part of his company. Give him peace to work, Charlie.”

“I’m fine, Charlie,” Jonny told her, his thin voice tight and strained.

“I have to go with him, Jonny,” she said, her little mouth twisted to one side.

“I know, baby, I’m a big boy,” he lied. “Go. Don’t worry about me.”

“She won’t,” Reza said absently, his attention on the waiting saleswoman as he waved her over.

The saleswoman approached them with a smile and her two hands gathered behind her back. As she drew near, she asked Reza, “Is there anything I can help you with, sir?”

Reza stepped aside so the woman could look at Charlie, and he told her, “We’re going away for the weekend to the Caribbean. Work-casual for her, plus some swimwear. I want sedate for the hotel pool, then she wants something more racy for when we go to the beach.”

“No, I don’t,” Charlie whined, her face twisting up fearfully.

It made the saleswoman smile wider, and she said, “I think we can accommodate that. Don’t worry, dear, nothing too salacious.”

Reza added, “And a couple outfits for going out at night. Dinner, a club, dancing.”

The woman nodded knowingly, letting Reza know they were in good hands. She was a kindly woman, smartly dressed, of course, and thin and proper. “Come with me ...” She held out a hand, paused to hear the name.

Charlie flattered, said, “Oh, sorry, I’m Charlie.” She stepped forward, smiling out of politeness and extending a hand to shake.

“Well, come with me, I think we can find some outfits that will please your handsome husband.”

Charlie said, “That man’s not my husband. Jonny’s my husband.”



Jonny and Reza sat side by side in separate leather arm chairs waiting for Charlie in the dressing room. They were in a small and intimate circular waiting room lined with framed floor-to-ceiling mirrors and high-legged tables stacked with fresh-cut flowers. The lighting was warm and ambient and they’d been offered espressos which sat now on an elegant table between them. Reza sat with one leg crossed over the other, his hands clasped together under his chin, watching the archway dead ahead of them, looking for Charlie to appear.

Jonny was uncomfortable. The steel restraint around his penis was digging into him, the ring that circled his balls tugged on them painfully and he couldn’t shake it no matter how he shifted in his seat. It was also uncomfortable having your marriage dynamic challenged in public. Charlie had told the saleswoman that Reza wasn’t her husband. It might have been easier if they’d just pretended he was. This woman didn’t need to know. Not only that, once it was determined that Reza was a man with money and was looking to spend, they were assigned a second sales staff. The second woman was younger, Charlie and Jonny’s age, and that seemed more difficult, too. Like, maybe the older woman would think, Huh, kids these

days, but the younger woman would just think, What a loser, getting dominated like this by another man. It was humiliating.

All it was, was Charlie wanting the woman to know Jonny was her husband. It was a fucking compliment, you know? She wanted it to be known her husband was the nice young man with promise, not the swarthy, arrogant master who was all swagger and meanness.

He'd even started to wonder if the younger woman knew he had a cage around his penis. She was more likely to be savvy to this sort of thing, and she did side-eye him a lot, catching him shifting and tugging at his pant leg. What would she think of this? A man and his wife here with a third man, this one rich and intimidating; a man very familiar with the wife, but shouldn't be; very forward, very presumptuous, putting his hands on the woman that wasn't his wife, doing it right in front of the husband and the husband didn't say shit. The more he thought about it, the more he came to realize at the very least the young woman knew Reza was fucking Charlie. Maybe the older one, too. He took the espresso cup, wished it was bigger as he held it protectively in front of his face, hiding himself from the two attendants.

Then Charlie was there, standing at the edge of the archway, partially obscured, afraid to step out and let them see her fully. So far, she'd appeared in a nighttime maxi dress in a pale blue and bright yellow flower pattern, coming out wearing heels; a more formal suit jacket, also in a grayish blue, worn with the sleeves rolled up and matching short-shorts, again with heels; a floor length navy skirt patterned with thin white slashes, worn with a white undershirt and obviously no bra, a straw fedora, and canvas sneakers; a baggy silk top in orange that had ties on the sleeves and a scoop neck with plunging V, peg-leg Capri pants in vibrant teal, also worn with heels, this time a sandal style with narrow leather straps and a jute rope platform. Now she had dressed in a bikini and was reluctant to appear.

"Come on out, Charlie," Reza said.

"You can come out, Charlie," Jonny urged her.

Her expression showed timid worry, her pouting lips pursed. She wore another straw fedora, and the brim shaded her eyes but Jonny could see they were wide and anxious. Her hands were gathered at her crotch and her fingers wrung together nervously.

“Charlie, please ...” Reza prodded more impatiently now, extending a hand and rolling it in a winding circle, drawing her out into the light.

One bare and tentative foot in front of the other, Charlie emerged from the relative dim of the dressing room hall and into the light of the viewing room and its many mirrors.

Reza said, “That’s it, Charlie, show us what you’ve got on.”

She couldn’t bear to look at them, instead her face was turned up to the ceiling as she had four sets of eyes on her. She had one arm folded over her tummy, hand cupping the opposite elbow. When she stopped in the center of the parquet circle, she put one foot over top of the other.

She wore a wide brimmed raffia fedora with a thick black band, pewter bangles and rings, and a tiny lace-knit two piece bikini in turquoise yarn.

The younger sales woman clasped her hands together as if in prayer and brought them up to touch the tip of her nose. She smiled broadly, pleased with her handiwork. She’d done Charlie well, the color was perfect against her pale but creamy, freckled skin, and tumbling apricot mane.

Jonny exhaled heavily; enamored at the sight of how beautiful his wife was and crushed knowing she was going away with another man looking like this. She would appear on another man’s arm. And at night she would go to bed with him. His knees came together till they touched, his cock straining against the metal confine of his small cage.

Reza was speechless, managing only to groan her name admiringly.

Charlie’s eyes came down and her gaze met Jonny’s. She mouthed something to him but he missed it. He mouthed back: What?

She whispered, “I’m too skinny.” Her hands came together over her belly button and began to wring together again.

“Charlie, come here,” Reza said, low and with serious tone.

She didn’t ask him to repeat it, instead complying right away and walking barefoot to stand before him.

“Turn around,” he said now.

She shook her head no, childishly and energetically, her long hair making scratching noises over the bare parts of her skin. The knit on her bikini was loose, and up close Jonny could see the brown of her nipples in the holes of the crochet. Down below as well, open gaps in the lacy knit showed bare skin just above her mound, and if she didn’t shave down there her pubic hair would be poking through. His cock stiffened further, and he had to straighten his legs out a little in the arm chair.

“Turn around,” Reza repeated in a voice that said you won’t want to hear his request a third time.

Charlie slumped and her head cocked. She made a little grunt in her throat. But she turned around.

As she did, her hands came down, and she covered her ass with her hands. The back of the bikini bottom was just a small knitted triangle that swooped very high over the top curve of her rump and left the lower curve completely bare. Her hands blocked their view.

Jonny groaned, his cock wanting to grow but finding steely restraint. He straightened his legs further and dug an elbow into the chair’s padded arm.

“Charlie,” Reza chastised. “Move your hands away, please.”

Charlie looked to protest, he could see her mouth open, but ultimately, just as he knew, there was no point in resisting. Before moving her hands away—as if stalling for time—she ran her fingers back-and-forth over the bikini bottom’s trim as if to make sure that while it provided little coverage it at

least was covering all that it could. She withdrew her hands and gathered them over her chest while facing away from Jonny and Reza. The attendants still watched, their faces betraying a growing concern.

Reza touched Charlie on the inside of her knee, his hand cupping her there. He said, “You don’t hear it when I say how beautiful you are?”

“Guys just say those things,” Charlie whispered over her shoulder, “well, they say those things because they want something.”

Reza said, “That what your mama told you?”

“Yes.”

“Your mama is not wrong, Charlie, but do you really think I need to say nice things to you so I can get you in my bed?”

Charlie’s lips sucked inward and her cheeks blushed, ashamed the saleswomen might have heard that. “No,” she said.

“Right. And you don’t think you’re beautiful?” His hand slipped upward and rested now mid-thigh. Charlie’s legs began to tremble. When she didn’t respond, he said, “Too skinny?—why, because you have a thigh gap?” His hand slipped higher until his thumb touched the crotch of her bikini bottoms.

“Shit,” Jonny sighed and clutched his thighs together tightly, his cock feeling like it was being crushed as it pushed outward against the wire of his chastity cage. The ring that circled his scrotum pulled his balls tight against the skin of his sack.

Charlie went on her tiptoes, and she looked to the saleswomen. They were watching but averted their eyes when they saw Charlie’s head turn. Charlie whimpered, “Maybe.”

“Every girl wants this, Charlie,” Reza said, manipulating his hand between her thighs, the knuckle of his thumb caressing her pussy through the woolly knit. “Every girl wants a body like yours, Charlie, and you don’t even know

what you got. I know you like to play shy and maybe I thought for a while you were just polite, 'cause you grew up on a farm or some shit—you know, like the Lord hates vanity. Now I'm starting to think you really don't know how beautiful you are, don't know how much better you could do than Jonny."

"Hey, Reza, come on," Jonny groaned, angry, hurt, and erect all at the same time.

"Turn around and face me, Charlie," Reza said and slowly withdrew his hand from between her thighs, his rough skin making a whisking sound against her soft, smooth skin.

She turned around, tiny seashell discs clacking where they hung in decoration on the ties that crossed her hip. She stared down her pale, flat tum at Reza who sat looking up at her, face level with her crotch.

He said, "How tall are you?"

"I don't know."

"Five-nine?"

"I think maybe."

"Charlie, that perfect face, that pale smooth skin and those beautiful eyes ... you can have the world."

"No, I couldn't," she whispered in disbelief.

Reza's hands came up and the pads of his thumbs traced the lower trim of her bikini bottom, inches from her mound.

"Hoo," she squeaked, and her knees dipped a little. "What are you doing?" she asked him in a soft, excited whisper.

His thumbs pushed upward against the bikini bottom, and it tightened between her legs. Jonny could see the younger saleswoman's eyebrows begin to rise.

“And this hungry little mouth down here could make any man do whatever it asked. You’re too much woman to follow Jonny around hoping he’s going to make it.”

Charlie’s thighs flexed and quivered, her hands came down to rest over Reza’s, not stopping him but maybe in an effort to block the ladies’ view of what he did. Reza’s thumbs pushed even higher, pulling the material outward a little. It narrowed and fell into the split of Charlie’s sex, the soft shaved curves of her vulva visible now.

“No,” Charlie whispered, not stopping him but almost encouraging him at the same time to tell her more.

“Oh yes,” Reza said. “Someone rich, powerful, handsome. A man who would show you things about your body you wouldn’t think possible.”

It was Charlie’s eyebrows rising now, right up to the brim of her straw fedora. Her pouting lips parted. The crotch of her panties had narrowed to a cord and Reza had wedged it higher, the wrinkled gray-pink of her labia folding and curling around the yarn. He flossed it gently forward and backward and smiled.

Jonny saw beyond them, the older saleswoman now take a step forward, considering how she could interrupt this without an overwhelming embarrassment of her own. She took another step, her hand extended and outstretched as if to say stop, but that hand curled to a loose fist and returned to rest at her thigh. She took a step back, but her brow was lowered and creased.

Reza looked up into Charlie’s eyes now, still using the crotch of her bikini to tease her pussy. He could see from the corner of his eye the woman approaching, and without looking, still gazing at Charlie, he said, “Don’t worry. We’re taking it. We’re taking it all. Everything she tried on today.”

Chapter Three

After Charlie adjusted her bikini bottom so it fit her straighter between her legs, she returned across the parquet floor on the balls of her feet and disappeared around the archway. The two saleswomen followed as well, headed to the dressing room with her.

Jonny brought his hands together and twiddled his thumbs. His skin was dampened with sweat. Reza shifted uncomfortably in his seat, slouching down a little, straightening one leg, sitting upright again. His hand disappeared inside the lapel of his jacket. He pulled out his wallet, a slim alligator billfold and withdrew his American Express card. He extended it to Jonny, held between first and middle finger. "Take this," he said.

Jonny leaned to the side, reached over the espressos and took the card. Reza said, "In a minute, those saleswomen are going to come out with all those clothes, bundled up, some of them on hangers, take them to the counter." Now he stood up and buttoned his jacket closed. Jonny stood as well, tucked the silver card in his pocket. Reza said, "Follow them over to the counter, pay for all the shit."

"Me go and pay for it? Where are you going?"

"Put out your hand."

Jonny should've seen it coming but didn't. He held out his hand, palm up. Reza took his wrist and brought it low between his legs, pushing his hand to the crotch of his pants. Jonny's hand closed around Reza's erection.

The guy had grown aroused watching Charlie try on all those clothes. Aroused by teasing her, flossing her bikini bottom through her sex. Jonny held it, his fingers semi-closed below the glans, his extra-large cock extended up high over his hip, the tip of it pressing out a knot above the belt

line. It was as thick as an iPhone and felt just as rigid. He pulled his hand away and wiped it on his chinos. “Here?” he hissed, unable to hold back a snarl.

“Just keep them busy. I can’t walk around the mall with this thing.”

On cue the two women emerged into the bright of the room, their heels clicking on the glossy wood floor, all smiles, clothing bundled at the younger woman’s waist, the older woman pushing a chrome dress rack on rubber wheels, the items Charlie had tried on gently swaying with her movements.

Reza said to the younger one: “Jonny’s got my card, he’s going to settle up.”

She just nodded and gave a breathless Yes, sir.

Jonny got in step behind them, and as the sound of the rubber on wood went silent as the rack crossed onto a section of carpet, Jonny glanced over his shoulder to see Reza walking under the archway that led to the dressing rooms with his hands in his pockets, his arousal bowing out even his suit jacket.



The older woman rang the items up on the cash register and the total came to \$4,817.27. Pretty much the cost of the actual vacation if Jonny was paying—and that was back when things were better. Reza just spent five grand on Charlie’s vacation clothes, for a trip that wouldn’t even be forty-eight hours long.

He grumbled at the expense spent on his wife by another man but kept a smile for the ladies. He went through a time-wasting rigmarole, patting all his pockets as if he couldn’t remember where he’d put Reza’s credit card.

Another man's credit card—to make purchases for Jonny's wife.

It ate at his guts. What would these two women think of him? What theories would be giggled once he and Charlie and Reza were gone, gossiping together and probably laughing at his expense? And, come on, ladies—aren't you wondering where Reza is, given that Jonny was the one standing at the cash register to pay? Wouldn't it have occurred to one of them Reza and Charlie were alone? And given the dynamic they'd witnessed, wasn't it obvious what might transpire in the dressing room?

It wasn't impossible that maybe they would allow it as Reza was such a big spender. Let him get away with indecent behavior because they wanted his money so bad. Jonny could relate. Just the same—as Charlie often lamented—Reza came like a fire hose, and he hoped that whatever transpired between his wife and Reza in the fitting room, it was left spattered like a Jackson Pollock painting all in white, and these smug and gossipy women had to roll up their sleeves and don rubber dishwashing gloves, get out the bleach and scrub the room down with hard bristle brushes.

He continued with his misdirection now, opening the paper shoppers they'd already packed and pretending he wanted to account for all the items again. With the time it took to bring everything out here, make idle and uncomfortable chit-chat, and for the women to bundle away all the purchases folded in tissue paper and place them in bags he did some mental math and figured Reza and Charlie would have had just under ten minutes alone in the fitting room. How much time did they need? It would depend on what activity they were up to, he supposed. It would depend on the whims of their landlord and whatever level of humiliation he'd like to inflict on both of them today. Boy, there was a game for the game-minded, if you were so inclined; an algorithm for a cuckold player to solve.

There wasn't much more he could do to stall, so he handed over the card and let them ring it through. It was accepted, of course, Jonny punching in the security code for the card he'd been given to use before. Nothing more humiliating than a man lending you his credit card to make purchases you can't afford, meanwhile the guy is giving it to your wife on the regular with his monstrous cock.

There were footsteps behind him, clopping on parquet, silent for a moment on carpet, then clopping again as they crossed over to the hard maple that surrounded the circular cash desk. Charlie was at his side then, coming to stand sheepishly next to him but not close enough to touch. Glancing over the other shoulder, he saw Reza on the other side. He was straightening his shirt cuffs. Now Jonny looked back to Charlie. She'd redressed in the clothes she wore when they arrived; her dark suit and her crisp shirt. There was a small, wet pearl on her lapel. His first instinct was to brush it away before the women witnessed it, but he didn't want his fingers to touch it. His eyes drifted higher, searching for Charlie's, but saw that she couldn't meet his gaze.

She hadn't been wearing much makeup, only a little lip gloss. It was gone now, her lips dry, a little wet smeared on her cheek. Her lips were their normal pouting shape, but they looked swollen and puffy. It was quite obvious, at least to Jonny, what had happened in the dressing room. It might even be quite obvious to the two women watching. He turned back to face them. It was quiet, no one had said a thing.

The women looked at them silently, and Jonny could see in their eyes they knew what had happened. He didn't think he was imagining things. He opened his mouth as if to say something but no sound came out. Next to him, Reza asked the women: "Everything settled here?"

It broke the spell, and the ladies moved again, nodding now, their vacant expressions blossoming with smiles, each of them taking up the twine handles of some of the paper shoppers and passing them across. "Oh yes, oh yes, everything's fine. Everything is put together in these bags ..."

Jonny look back to Charlie. Her eyes were still cast downward, her hands folded in front of her. He asked her: "You okay?"

She nodded, a mild but rapid motion of her chin. She whispered something, but he missed it.

"What was that?" he asked her. The women were silent again. She looked up to him, and said, "Reza wants me to kiss you."

He stared at her for a moment, watching her tremulous lips. Watched as her teeth came together and closed over the plumpness of the bottom curl. There was symbolism in this. A humiliating submission. He took a long intake of breath, cleared his throat, and said quietly, but low enough for everyone to hear: "Okay."

Charlie studied his face for a moment as if gauging whether he was truthful. For the first time since maybe they were only dating, he felt awkward with her. He put out his hands at his hips, fumbling for hers. She looked down, confused, then took his hands with hers. He stepped closer, clearing his throat again. He craned his neck forward, but hesitated.

"Go on and kiss your wife, Jonny," Reza said behind him. The women watched. Between his legs, there was a tightening again. The tightening, while uncomfortable, was becoming a form of excitement in its own way. The restriction was a measurement of his arousal and a measurement of his humiliation. Now he got a little closer and let the metal bulb of the cage's end poke into his wife.

They were a breath away and Charlie gasped, "Okay?"

As an answer he closed his mouth over hers. She submitted herself to him, sucking on his lips as he sucked on hers. He even gave her his tongue, and she took it, let him search for hers. He swirled it over her pink slick shape and breathed her in. His cock swelled harder against its confines.

If Reza thought that he would humiliate him like this, Jonny would show him no shame. You want me to kiss my wife? I'll show you how I kiss my wife. And I'm going to pretend that I don't taste salt on her tongue and I'm going to pretend I don't smell that janitorial smell in her breath. Because what I do know is that I love her more than anything.

He kissed her longer than he'd even intended and Charlie felt the passion, too. Her hands even gripped around his waist. Then they came part with a soft wet smack, and his eyes remained on hers. His wife's eyes were wide in wonderment. They darted over his. He couldn't be sure but he thought there might even be a small measurement of pride in him. Unabashedly showing his love for her when challenged. Her mouth moved around now,

too, producing no sound like he just had. He turned the tables on her, showed her his commitment. Charlie never doubted him, and no matter how bad things got he would show her they were in this together

Next to them, paper bags were slid to the edge of the counter. While the women may have enjoyed this up to a certain point, they were indicating it was time to leave. There was a moment in everyone's life when they felt like their involvement in something had gone too far—a moment when they realized while they may only be spectators they were somehow complicit. Next to the shoppers, butted up against the cash register, was a crystal bowl with small cellophane wrapped candies.

To the younger saleswoman, Charlie asked, "Are these for everyone?"

The young woman smiled, nodded. She said, "Take as many as you want."

Polite Charlie extended her long, graceful hand, plucked one single mint from the bowl and unwrapped it. She tucked the crinkling wrapper in the pocket of her suit jacket and put the mint in her mouth. She took one of the bags in her left hand and hooked her other arm under Jonny's. "Let's go," she said.

II

When Charlie's Away...

Chapter Four

Jonny talked to Shulamit via Skype. She was a coder that he hired freelance and paid daily through PayPal without access to her full personal information. She looked and talked Israeli, maybe, actually quite beautiful though she dressed like somebody who sat in front of their computer all day wearing a grubby-looking sweatshirt, and she had her hair tied back from her face. Said she lived in Rome, but who could tell, she could be in this same building for all he knew. For clarification, he asked her, “And you got all the in-lines done, too?”

She nodded without responding.

He said “And the OOP and the data structure elements?”

She sighed, leaned back in her expensive looking leather chair and said, “Yes, all of them.” Now she laced her fingers together behind her head.

“All those style sheets I gave you? ...”

“All of them.”

“And—”

Her chair squeaked as she leaned forward abruptly, her face almost filling the screen of his monitor. She said, “Jonny, everything. All the things on the list are done. We don’t need to go through each one.”

“Okay, okay. I just ... That’s really great, Shulamit. I mean ...” He let it hang as his eyes drifted up and down the sheet of milestones he had for her. Everything was done? I mean, holy shit. She might be as good as him. If this were the case, if he had another version of himself, though as abrupt as she may be, this might actually happen ahead of schedule. There was a chance, right?

He confided: “Listen, I just ... I think that’s great, I don’t know what else to say, I just ... I guess I want you to know that really means a lot ... there’s no way for me to explain to you how much that means. Just let me say: it might change my life.”

Shulamit looked uninterested. She had that work-was-work sort of attitude that he appreciated, but there was so much emotion building up behind the development of this game, he really did wish he had someone to share it with. Wished there was a way for him to explain what was on the line here. But, she wouldn’t respect that, anyway. Now he breathed deep to settle himself, bashed the stack of papers on his desk to line them up properly and laid them flat.

“Okay. Good. You did good. Let’s see if you can do it again. You get my email?”

“Of course,” she said.

“And the milestones? You’re good with the timeline?”

She shrugged and nodded her head, fluttered her eyelids. It gave him the impression that he could’ve tightened up the timeline even. He didn’t think anybody was as good as him. At this rate they might be into a vertical slice in four weeks.

On his right, Charlie tumbled from the bathroom, feet moving quickly. She’d only got home from work about half an hour ago, and though she’d done much of the packing for the trip last night there were last-minute adjustments. She flitted around in the space between the bed and the closet, her suitcase open on the unmade bed. The one where he would be sleeping alone without her for the next two nights. Least it was a step up from the couch. The decision whether or not to change the sheets was an interesting dilemma. Did he want clean and fresh sheets? Sure—that made sense. Or how about sheets that Charlie had slept on? ...

He hadn’t been with Charlie in eight days now. Hardly worth mentioning, really, but his abstinence was at the forefront of his thoughts the entire time. That was what brought the challenge. He’d probably gone eight days

without having sex with her before, but not because he was prevented. Even considering it right now brought a tension as his penis swelled out against its restraint.

It was the cage that made the decision to sleep on her dirty sheets. Sure, it came with a Reza bonus, but it would be worth it.

“Jonny—the milestones? ...” Shulamit prompted him, breaking his momentary reverie.

“Yeah, the milestones,” he mumbled, bringing his gaze back to the monitor.

Shulamit said, “Right, the milestones—I told you I was good ...”

“Okay,” he said.

Charlie said, “Jonny, is SPF 30 enough?”

He stared at Shulamit, made a low grumble and told her to hold on a moment. Charlie stood at the side of the bed, one hand on her hip, the other holding a squeezable tube of sunscreen. She wore light pajama short-shorts and an undershirt, thick mane pulled back and held up behind her head by a big, plastic butterfly hair clip.

He said, “What?”

She said, “SPF 30—is that enough for me?—for my skin ...” She showed him the sunscreen and wiggled it around, clenched in her fingertips. “What did we have in Dominican Republic? Do they make SPF 50? Am I making that up? Can you Google it?”

He told her, “They make SPF 50.”

“Then why do I have this? Where did it come from?” she said, more to herself than to him.

“I don’t know. It’s probably mine.”

Body slumped in exaggerated exasperation, she made a growling sound of irritation, like this day couldn't get any worse.

Looking back at Shulamit on his monitor now, he said to her, "Sorry. My wife is going away."

"That's nice. Are you going to be reachable?"

"Am I? Oh, yeah. My wife's going without me."

"You're letting her go away without you?"

"She's not alone."

"Going with her friends." Shulamit said it as a statement rather than a question, and Jonny was glad that she didn't want to delve further.

Charlie had gone into the bathroom again but she was out now, walking lightly on the balls of her feet and showing Jonny a big smile, wagging the SPF 50 sunscreen she'd found in the bathroom. She mouthed, Got it.

Jonny continued with Shulamit, showing Charlie a thumbs-up and the best smile he could muster given the circumstances.

As they went over the milestones on the sheet, Shulamit asking pointed questions he was glad to hear, Charlie took most of the items back out of her suitcase and aligned them on the bed, standing there and surmising them with a frown. The suitcase was also purchased by Reza, he brought it home midweek. Louis Vuitton, one of the white ones with multicolored logos. Probably cost as much as the vacation, too.

He talked with Shulamit, giving her more detail, and watched Charlie from the corner of his eye. Watched her as she went through the items and repacked them, leaving out nothing. What was the point in taking them out? He saw all the pretty things she would be wearing when she was away. Watched as she packed the tiny crochet bikini in bright turquoise, the whole thing bundled together barely more than two handfuls. His wife was going to be walking around showing it all, and he wouldn't be there to see it.

Another man would. And that man would do more than see it. That man would put his hands all over it. And not just his hands.

The front door of the apartment clicked open, and two booming male voices came in, mid-laugh. Without turning around, Jonny knew it was Reza and Tate. Tate would probably be driving them to the airport. They trotted noisily down the stairs laughing and talking and Jonny told Shulamit to hold on for a moment again. She looked perturbed, and he didn't know if he liked that or hated that. She was kind of his employee, and she should do whatever he says, but she kind of wasn't his employee, and he appreciated her resistance to nonsense. So he added, "Sorry," a tiny sign of respect that seemed to brighten her face. She sat back again, folding her arms over her chest and waiting.

Reza clapped his hands once and said, "Where is my Charlie?"

Charlie emerged from the bathroom again, her face happy but still timid. She said, "I wanted to pack again."

Reza said to Tate, "Women," and it made Tate smile.

Jonny noted Tate's eyes going up and down appreciatively over Charlie's milky skin. Jonny blurted, "Is he going, too?"

Tate shook his head, as if he'd been momentarily hypnotized by Charlie's body and said, "Who? Me?"

Reza said, "No. Just me and Charlie. He's taking us to the airport."

Jonny said, "I figured."

Now Reza and Tate looked at him with quizzical expressions that said: Then why did you ask?

Now to Charlie, Reza said, "You repacked? You have everything?"

"Yes, I have everything."

"Are you ready to get going?" Tate asked.

Charlie smiled to Tate and said, “I’m ready to go. I just need to put some clothes on for the plane.”

Reza rolled his eyes, and said to Jonny, “So she’s not ready to go.” He kept his voice low and it gave Jonny a funny flinching stomach. It was the kind of thing a guy would say to another guy about his girlfriend. But Charlie was Jonny’s wife.

While Charlie went into her closet, reaching for a high shelf, Reza stood behind Jonny’s chair, letting his hand curl over the top. He eyeballed the screen, and said, “This some kind of WebCam? You two jerking off with each other?”

Shulamit said, “Who’s this guy?”

Reza tapped on his shoulder and said, “Who’s your beautiful girlfriend? You two-timing Charlie?”

Charlie emerged from the closet now, her face no longer timid. He saw worry there, concern, and a good dose of mad, too. Her mouth was firmly set. She said, “What are you talking about?”

Reza said, “Jonny’s new girlfriend. He’s talking to her on the computer.”

Tate chuckled.

As Charlie stomped over, Reza said, “You didn’t know about this, Charlie? She’s very beautiful.”

Shulamit said, “We’ll talk later.”

She leaned forward to shut her connection down and Jonny said, “No, no, wait. We’re almost done.” Why would he do that? Just call her back when they were gone. But now Shulamit was pausing, leaning forward so her face filled the screen, and folding her arms on her table in front of her keyboard.

Charlie was there now, keeping herself out of the camera’s view and poking her head around to take a look at the monitor. She saw Shulamit and how pretty she was. She made a hurt face to Jonny and met his gaze. Jonny said

to her, “She’s saving my bacon, Charlie. She’s my coder and she’s really fucking good.”

Her bottom lip buttoned up like she’d wanted to say something but knew she shouldn’t. There was another irritated sound in her throat and she turned on her heel, went into the closet and grabbed some things together and hustled them into the bathroom and closed the door.

Shulamit said, “Your wife’s going with this guy?”

Reza leaned closer, resting an elbow on the top of Jonny’s chair and lowering his gaze, making sure he was fully in the frame that he saw in the corner. He said, “Play your cards right, I might take you somewhere, too.”

“No, thanks,” Shulamit said and sat back again, resting in her chair.

Jonny said to Reza, “She’s Israeli.”

Reza made a Pfff sound, waved his hand as if dismissing everyone, and walked toward the bed. He said to Tate, “Grab her suitcase.” Then to Jonny, “Tell her we’re down in the car.”

“I will.” When he turned back to his monitor, Shulamit had disconnected.

Chapter Five

Charlie came out of the bathroom wearing the clothes she would travel in. A bright blue blouse and white shorts. Thankfully, the shorts weren't too short. She had canvas sneakers on, and she'd adorned herself with a lot of the pewter bangles she bought when they were in the store under the Romeo-McMillan. She had three necklaces on, bohemian sort of things, made from shells and bits of bone, or something. But the pendants were clearly gemstones, and he imagined they were probably quite expensive. He didn't remember those amongst the items they bought under the McMillan, and he wondered if sometime during the week Reza took her shopping again. It was possible, maybe they'd even purchased that fancy suitcase together. Somewhere hidden amongst those pendants would be the most valuable of pendants: a key to the lock on his genitals' cage.

She was leaving now, and it wasn't the time to provoke bad feelings, so instead he extended his hand for her to come. Without hesitation she stepped into his space and his arms encircled her. He said, "Are you mad?"

"No. That would be silly."

"It would be silly. Charlie, believe me when I tell you, this girl can code. She's almost as good as me. I mean it. I gave her a list of things ... Seriously, she did them all and did them right."

"I'm glad," she said, a little too coldly.

"What do you want me to do?"

"Nothing. Seriously, nothing. I'll be okay. I just need to grow up."

"Don't be hard on yourself, Charlie. Don't let Reza get in your head. She's a coder. You're my wife. And I don't think there's any way you could doubt how much I love you."

“And how much do I love you?”

He said, “You show me every day, Charlie. What you’re doing is amazing. You’re saving us.”

He could sense her beginning to brighten, and she said now, “You’re the one that’s going to save us, Jonny. And I might be away this weekend, but believe me, I’m not going to have fun. I put on a brave face for Reza, but you’re my husband. Okay? The best thing about me going away is all the free time you’re going to have. Nobody coming in and out of here, just you and your computer. I want you to get so much done. You hear me? Wow me.”

“I’ll wow you, Charlie. I can feel it beginning to come together. I don’t want to say too much, but believe me when I say: things are falling into place.”

“I don’t doubt it for a second, mister,” she said, and now she widened the distance between them, drawing back so she could look at his face.

He saw those bright green emeralds looking into his eyes, saw her sweet spattering of freckles across her cheeks and that wide and beautiful smile. This was the face that provoked him. This was the woman who made his heart beat. He wouldn’t make this difficult for her, so he said now, “You better get going. It’s okay if you have fun.”

“I’m not going to,” she said, her face turning a little surly. “I wish you were coming.”

“I’m telling you right now, Charlie. A year from now we’ll go. I swear it. And it will be just you and me. We’ll go wherever you want.”

“Don’t I know it, mister.” She gave him a firm and curt nod. A soldier heading out on a mission. She darted a kiss on his cheek, but there was no way that would be enough. He snapped her forward so her body squeezed against him. With his arms wrapped around her lower back he lifted her so she was almost up off the floor and he took her mouth. She kissed him, but felt her teeth close around his lip. He let her down. She made a funny little

grimace, and said, “Ouch. Your cage poked me in my girl parts. Did you do that on purpose?”

“No. I kinda forgot I was wearing it right now. Saying goodbye to you right now is about love.”

That got her good. She veritably slumped before him, and shot a hip out and gave him the warmest, kindest expression he could imagine. This was the way he wanted to remember her.

“Get going. Don’t keep him waiting. The longer you’re standing here the longer you’re keeping me from my work.” He could barely stop from laughing as he finished the phrase.

“I better not keep the genius away from his laboratory,” she said and rolled her eyes. She darted him another kiss, said, “I love you so much, Jonny. See you on Sunday night.”

He pecked her cheek and ran his hands up her slim sides. “I’ll see you Sunday night,” he echoed.

He stood in the center of their apartment, and watched as she grabbed her purse and trotted lightly up the steps and out of the apartment, her long gingery mane swinging behind her. The door closed, and he watched the blank space where she’d been for a moment. He tugged at his cage, felt a sudden surge as he thought of all the things that might happen when she was away. Then he pushed it all away, drew in the deepest breath he could muster. Right now he had more important things to consider. Right now he had to get Shulamit on Skype again and patch things up, get her fingers moving as fast as his would be.



Later, almost near midnight, Charlie had face-timed Jonny to let him know she'd arrived safely. She talked to him for a little bit and told him all about the flight, barely mentioned Reza at all. And Reza didn't loom in the background, or even press his cheek to hers and menace him through the phone like Jonny had anticipated he would. No, it was just Jonny and his wife, and she told him all about the travel. Told him about the hotel, and told him about the beautiful weather. As she talked, he could hear an ocean breeze rustling palm leaves behind her. It was nighttime there, too, and though her face was lit up by the light of her camera, the background behind her was the faded color of a ripe eggplant. He couldn't help wondering where Reza was. Could imagine him maybe in the shower, Charlie taking a moment to sneak some contact with her husband, say some things to him out of earshot of their landlord. He'd probably come out, not even put a towel around his waist, walking around what was assuredly an expensive and luxurious hotel suite with his dong swinging around between his legs.

This weekend was hard, because this was distance. It was one thing when these things happened in the apartment before his eyes. It was worse still when it was done elsewhere in the city while he was stuck at home. But this was distance with a capital D. She was what?—thirteen-hundred miles away? He couldn't just say enough is enough and slam everything down and stomp out of the apartment, find her at some nightclub and yank her out of Reza's arms. Not that he physically could take her from Reza anyway. But at least there was always that option of confrontation. There was nothing he could do when they were so far away.

His mind had begun to wander as Charlie babbled more. He loved hearing her sweet voice, but didn't really care about the details of the hotel.

Maybe he could get Shulamit to hire some ex-Mossad guys to go down and take care of Reza in the Caribbean. Gosh, Jonny wasn't even connected. Detective, I had nothing to do with it, I was thousands of miles away.

“What are you smiling about, mister?” she'd asked him and he felt stupid.

He couldn't do that. He wouldn't. One, he would get caught. Two, he wasn't a murderer. Three, what if there was a mixup? It wasn't impossible

to think that somehow things could go wrong and Charlie could be the one who got hurt. Or even that Charlie would witness it. Most importantly: he didn't want Reza dead, he wanted him beaten. How could you rub your success in someone's face when they were dead? Reza was a necessary villain. Murder was just dumb fantasy.

So they'd kissed each other through their phones, both of them actually touching lips to screens, and he said good night. Then he practically jumped into the bed that she'd been sleeping in with the Reza. Sure, he should stay up late and get more work done but right now after having spoken to her, and the stress of the week, the best thing he could imagine was getting a good night sleep. Been on the couch for a while now. On the couch and listening to his wife with another man. So he practically went spreadeagled, staying on the side that Charlie used. In the morning, while he woke refreshed, he did have a hair in his mouth. He might like to think it was one of Charlie's, but it was short and coarse and almost porcine, and he knew whose it was.

As well as the hair in his mouth, he'd also woken on the farther side of the bed. The smell was different there. A combo of musk, and man sweat and stale cologne. It lessened as he scurried back to the sweet Charlie side.

Morning had been great. It was bright and sunny and he didn't think about much about what Charlie might be doing in the Bahamas without him. It seemed too hopeful out there for her to be doing bad things, or for bad things to be performed on her.

He blasted through a veritable shit ton of work. Skipped breakfast, and his fingers bashed code straight out for hours on end until the tips of his fingers tingled when he stopped. Indian was ordered in for lunch, a real spicy vindaloo and he ate it at his desk. Mid-afternoon Shulamit posted completed tasks and he laughed and shook his head at her proficiency.

A luxury he added, something that might even have been missing recently: music. Music brought him happiness and he put it up pretty loud; not enough for distraction, just enough to get his head nodding and his feet tapping while his fingers beat out scads and scads of code.

The vindaloo did something mean to his tummy at around three in the afternoon and he lost almost twenty minutes in the can. But even sitting on the toilet he used his tablet to test run scripts. And despite the afternoon's surprise and spicy porcelain devotions he was hungry in the evening. Perhaps because of it.

He ordered a burger, fries, and a milkshake for delivery in the hopes that avoiding the international might be gentler on his stomach. While he waited for the delivery of his meal he called Javed, the second coder he'd hired. Guy was also good; young and local and living in the same city. They'd gone through the stage development stuff. It was on time and error-free but he wasn't an extra mile kind of player like Shulamit was.

So here he was, sitting still in his office chair, the sun gone down now but the night bright and he hadn't even thought bad things about Charlie once. He had wrapped up work-talk with Javed, just shooting the shit with him now—he was much easier to relate with than Shulamit—waiting for his food to arrive and not wanting to engage new work until it did.

He was laughing because Javed was talking about this guy they both happened to know called Craig Jefferson. Still in high school, Jonny'd done freelance for the guy, a project manager at OutHouse, working on individual assets he needed. But Craig was now doing project management at the big-time Lancer Games. Javed worked briefly on a project at Lancer and they were both regaling what a dick Craig was, and how he didn't know his ass from his elbow but acted like he did. Stupid old fuck. His phone binged while he was still laughing and he checked it.

That was how his evening of torture began; Reza sending the first picture of what would be many.

Chapter Six

The first picture of the night had been simple enough, and nothing to provoke great fear—but he wasn't stupid and he knew there would be more. The thought curdled his stomach enough that he broke off his fun conversation with Javed and told him he had to get going.

The picture Reza had sent was of Charlie and she didn't know she was being photographed. She wore that crochet bikini. The one so tiny and sparse if she didn't shave her pubic hair you could've seen it through the gaps in the knit. At least she wore the white undershirt over top. But you could still see the turquoise material under the thin white cotton. She wore her Fedora and all the pewter jewelry. Wherever she was it was sunny, and it was daytime. The sun was going down, though, and the photo, actually quite a nice one, was a very warm color tone. Charlie looked beautiful. It was from mid-thigh up, and she was holding something in her hands. It looked like it might be her iPhone. Her head was turned down to watch it. Fuck you, Reza, he thought, she's probably trying to text me. Though no text came.

Sure, a pretty nice photo, but still he knew they now had an umbilical attached between him and Reza. One he wouldn't ignore. One he wouldn't be able to ignore. His hands began to sweat.

The food arrived, and he went up to the kitchen and didn't say a word to the young guy who delivered the food. He took the bag from gave him twenty dollars and closed the door. Wasn't even sure if that was the right amount. He might have tipped the guy five dollars or he might've shafted the guy five dollars. It didn't matter. His mouth was going dry. He fumbled for the wax cardboard milkshake cup and put both hands around it. He drew deep on the straw and felt ice crystals flood his mind. That was perfect. Freeze the dread.

Another photo came. He pushed the food away. He was hungry but his appetite had completely disappeared. He checked the screen. Charlie now, without the undershirt, walking on the beach in her bikini. How sweet.

In the picture it was clear there was a good-looking young tanned guy watching her from a nearby beach towel. Watching this tall, thin, ginger-haired supermodel strut around in barely a thing. The shot was from behind, Charlie again not knowing she was being photographed. Probably not knowing that Reza was taunting her husband at home with images of her scantily dressed.

The scoops of her almost-bare ass were perfectly visible and beautiful. She shone brightly, her skin so pale and perfect in that bright Caribbean sun. He hoped she wore her SPF 50.

He let the food sit on the counter and stumbled mindlessly down into the apartment again and lay on the couch with his phone on his chest. No more images came for a while and he watched the city sky go from pale blue to a deep, burnt orange. Then the nighttime came, and the sky was a deep black-tinged indigo. The lights of the city began to come alive and Jonny still stared wide-eyed at nothing.

Four hours later was when the next picture came. He'd been laying on the couch the whole time. His dinner was cold, his workstation had gone dark, shutting itself off three and a half hours ago. The image was at nighttime, of course, Charlie now, and she was out at dinner. She wore a slinky flower-printed dress. She looked fantastic in it and he wished he was there. Wished he could whisper in her ear how beautiful she looked. No, right now, the man whispering in her ear would be Reza.

The place where they ate looked expensive. Exotic tropical flowers blossoming in the middle of tables, well-dressed patrons, well-dressed waitstaff bustling between tables in black pants and crisp white shirts. He could imagine the clinking of glass and the sound of knives on expensive china plates. He could imagine the chatter of rich people as Charlie waited for her meal.

It wasn't long after that until he sent another gift. This one not a picture at all. This one a little video. Short, maybe only seven seconds. Reza shot it while sitting across the table from Charlie. This time she knew she was being recorded, and she smiled for the camera. She cocked her head and set down a wineglass. She licked her lips before she said, "Hi, Jonny. Hope you're working ..."

She lifted her hand and gave the camera a little wave. It broke his heart. He wasn't working. He knew he should be, but his attention was wrapt by this little message-machine in his hands. He wouldn't be able to put it down until they stopped coming. Until he knew she was safe.

An hour went by, and he drifted off to sleep. The phone dinging on his chest woke him up. Of course, another message from Reza. Another video clip, this time the camera whipped around a little too harshly and his head swayed on the pillow while he watched. The camera finally found focus. Tinny music banged in the little speakers. They were at a loud nightclub. There were a lot of people, and the crowd was jostling. When Reza finally found his subject with his phone's camera, Jonny saw Charlie walking away, and she was doing a little dance. She had her pale white fingers pointed in the air, jabbing mildly as she shook her booty and strutted. She was being beckoned to the dance floor by a man he didn't know. A handsome guy, slick and glossy black hair combed back from his face, young, with an unshaven dimpled chin and black eyes. Tommy's heart seized up.

The handsome guy held out a hand and Charlie took it, and the other dancers on the dance floor swallowed them up. Just when he thought that video was over, he could hear Reza chuckling and breathing through his nose.

It looked like he was sitting at a VIP table because Jonny could see now that Charlie had passed through a section cordoned off with velvet ropes. The camera panned down to the table where she'd probably been sitting with Reza. It was glass, more flowers on the center, there was an empty wineglass, two bottles of vodka on the table. He had the impression there were more people sitting on the left-hand side of Reza. Of most importance were three white, powdery lines where Charlie would have been sitting.

There were three more dusty sweeps where it would be surmised that three more lines had previously existed. Had those three lines been snorted up Charlie's nose?

"Fuck, Charlie," he groaned. He took the rubbery edge of his phone's cover and poked his brow just above the bridge of his nose, trying to grind out his mind's eye, wishing these pictures weren't being sent to him. Was Charlie snorting cocaine?

Twenty minutes later another video arrived. He was wide alert as if he'd snorted his own three lines of cocaine. The video started at a cleaner table, suggesting to the viewer, Jonny, that the cocaine he'd seen earlier was now gone. Also up his wife's nose?

Now the camera scanned the crowd until it found that bright apricot hair tousling around in the flashing lights of the nightclub. Charlie out there on the dance floor. She had both long, pale arms up over her head and two men danced with her. One her handsome suitor with his brushed back hair, the other one a tall and large black man. He was well-dressed and a good dancer; he kept his legs wide apart and Charlie danced her body up against him. She must be able to feel the man's package against her stomach. Jonny wanted to throw up. He sat upright and hung his head between his knees for a moment, pretty sure that Indian food he thought he'd exorcised was going to make a return visit. He burped.

Half an hour later another taunting video came. This time it was Charlie talking to him again. Charlie had too much to drink. She was slurring, she was glassy-eyed, sitting at the table with her hands clasped together and her cheek braced against her combined hands. Her body swayed from side to side. She said, "Hi, Jonny," and she giggled. A deep voice from off-camera, not Reza's, said something to her Jonny couldn't decipher, and she looked to the left of the camera and laughed. Then she narrowed her eyes like she was mad at this person and she gave that man a wagging finger like he was going to be in trouble. The camera shook with Reza's laughter, too. She blew the camera a kiss and said, "I miss you, Jonny."

That one was nice. But it was so filled with suggestive menace he hated it. Hated to see his wife like that. Hated to see her act that way even though

she might think she was being fun. She was being taken advantage of. She was being used as a pawn in a game against Jonny.

Only twenty minutes later another picture arrived. This one shot underneath the nightclub table. It punched him in the chest. An up-skirt shot, and Charlie clearly not wearing any panties. Her pussy almost visible, the undulating scoop of her soft vulva swells, commissure pressed down on the underside of her skirt as she sat with her pretty labia mashed underneath her. That was bad enough, but her white legs shone brightly, lit up and over-exposed in the camera's flash, and curled over the inside of her thigh was a huge, black hand. Jet black, the camera unable to distinguish between the two wildly different skin tones and blowing them both out. Jonny coughed bile, made a crying groan. The man had his hand on the inside of her thigh. Slipping up another six inches he could touch her bare pussy. What the fuck was happening down there?

Half an hour later Reza sent him another short video. Charlie back on the dance floor. She danced with three men this time. Not the black one from before and not the handsome guy with the tan. Three new guys. All of them Jonny would guess were Latin. Well-dressed and well-groomed, big smiles, tight clothing that showed off their muscle. Expensive looking things, too, garish, Gianni Versace and Gucci for men. He fucking hated these guys. And these guys he fucking hated were putting their hands all over Charlie's body and Charlie did nothing to stop them. No, quite the contrary, Charlie was loving it. On the dance floor with all these other people, all of them behaving like fucking assholes, Charlie shimmied and shook with her hands up over her head, her beautiful hair thrashing around, her hips shooting left and right. Men gyrated against her, fake-fucked her from behind through their clothes, dry-humping like goddamn teenagers. And Charlie loved it. Rubbing her ass up against the guy who was grinding his dick into her bottom. The other two watched and laughed, touched her, put their hands on her stomach and danced with her. She was passed around, enjoyed by all of them. The video went dark again.

He sat up and cocked his arm back. He could end this right now. Just wing this fucking phone right across the apartment and smash it against the far wall. Fuck you, Reza, if you can't get to me you can't hurt me. This

connection between them could be severed. But he knew he wouldn't. He knew he would sit here and watch everything that his tormentor sent to him. So he suffered, looking at the ceiling and waiting for the next image.

Reza sent another, just as bad as the previous ones, and of course, also incrementally worse. She was inebriated in this video. Evidenced by her babbling and laughing. They were still at the club, but somewhere quieter, maybe in a private lounge, or even leaving, crossing through a lobby. She could barely stand. The men were holding her up, trying to get her to walk, but she would stumble on her heels and fall into another man. They laughed and talked in Spanish. When they would help her to stand again, their hands would caress her and touch her in places they shouldn't. Charlie laughed, too, thinking this was all fun. All Jonny saw was danger. This wasn't fun, this was scary.

He frantically texted:

Jonny: okay don't seriously its enuff

Reza didn't respond.

One of the Latin guys grabbed his bulge while Charlie's back was turned. Adjusting himself, obviously getting hard. Did he think he was going to fuck Charlie? Was he going to fuck Charlie? Jonny stood now, wanting to rip out of his skin. This was too much. This was way too much and now he wished he had smashed his phone.

Jonny: please Reza take care of her

Reza didn't respond, and now Jonny dialed Charlie but her phone went straight to automated voicemail.

Waiting for the next call almost killed him. All he could hear was the pounding of his heart in his eardrums. Thump, thump, thump, thump. Faster than it should be, harder than it should be. He felt wild and electric and angry and so incredibly frightened. He jumped when his phone dinged again, a video sent by Reza.

Charlie was so drunk she could barely talk. She was laughing, and the guys were making fun of her as she walked down a hotel hallway ahead of them. She was going from the left to the right, seesawing as she walked, unable to maintain a straight line, putting a hand out to brace herself on the wall. The men laughed and joked in foreign languages. When she looked like she would stumble, the black man was there again, putting out his huge hand across the small of her back the other one dipping around to the front. Probably touching her chest. She thanked him in slurred speech, and he looked back at the rest of them and smiled. The video ended.

Jonny could feel himself dry-sobbing. While his jaw trembled he texted.

Jonny: Reza I will give u anything if u keep her safe

Reza didn't respond to his text.

He only had to wait five more minutes for the next video. It was Charlie getting into bed. Not under the covers but just collapsing on top of a big king-size bed that looked like it was in the expensive suite where Charlie had called him from last night. For a moment he thought she would be safe, but he could hear other men's voices in the room. Reza called out to one of them and said, "Yeah, help yourself. There's more in the fridge." Something banged, two men were talking near the camera, one more distant, perhaps in another room, laughed. Charlie climbed up on the bed and collapsed face down.

The camera bumped and bobbed for a while, Reza crossing the room, the sound of the mattress as he sat down on it. Then the camera swooped

around again and Charlie was seen on her side, laying in the center of the bed, her knees drawn up, her tight skirt pulled a little high. Reza's big hand appeared in the frame, touching at her knee and then slipping upward. A man laughed nearby, a deep and scary sound. A pop can opened. Maybe a beer. Jonny's heart pounded.

Reza's hand slipped under Charlie's skirt, and he began to pry it upward. She wasn't wearing any panties and she mumbled some kind of complaint and tried to move away but gave up. He pulled the skirt right up to show her bare bottom. Another guy came and sat on the bed, too. The new guy's tanned hand with a gold pinky ring slapped her bare ass cheek and Charlie mumbled No, and she tried to slap his hand away but missed. She was so drunk her arm folded up behind her back, her wrist bent behind her awkwardly, and stayed there. The other guy reached over, his hand coming back into the frame and caressing her elbow.

"Don't," she said thickly,

Reza laughed and he dug his thumb into her ass cheek and spread her wide. The camera moved a little closer, Reza pushing his phone nearer Charlie's body. He jabbed his thumb near her vulva and he pulled her labia wide. Her sex was completely bare, and he tugged like he was trying to make a puppet talk, making her labia wiggle like it said something. There was a slick crackling sound. Reza said, "Hi, Jonny," like it was Charlie's vagina talking, "I'm so hungry."

Someone else in the room laughed loud and loon-like. Reza was stroking her pussy with his thumb. Someone in the room belched, another man gave a throaty chuckle. Reza shut the camera down.

Jonny waited, sitting there with the greatest most enormous rage he'd ever felt in his entire life. He looked through the blank phone like it was a window and the other world was just on the other side of the glass. He waited for it to light up again and let him glimpse what was happening in this other reality. This other reality that he created in his mind but existed so far away. That was it: she was so far away and he could do nothing.

Tears began to stream down his cheeks. But he wasn't sad. He wasn't sad at all. He was murderous. He was brimming bright red rage. He was also hard as a rock. His cuckold cage crimped around his meager erection, choking and crushing it, metal tines digging into his sexual flesh.

He waited like that, the most intense emotional experience of his life, sizzling with electric hate and fear, waiting and waiting to find out what happened to his wife. No more calls came.

Chapter Seven

The baseball bat was aluminum, and it had been a long time since he felt one in his grip. Little League. That would be the last time. He held it now in both hands, the rubberized tape squeaking under his fingers as his hands rotated to firm his clutch. It was eight-thirty now. The plane from the Bahamas landed at seven-fifteen. He checked online to see that it was on time and saw that it had arrived five minutes early. Now he stood to the right side at the bottom of the steps from the kitchen, his back in the corner, the tall lamp and its broad shade in front of him.

The bat was purchased today after lunch. The morning had been a write-off. He didn't even try to work. Shulamit had contacted him and he ignored her message. Javed called and he let it go unanswered. He stewed. Then when he knew what he would do, he left the apartment, walked the city until he found a sporting goods store.

The only sound in the apartment was his deep and heavy breathing, the sound of his teeth clicking and grinding were in his ears. A soft ding emanated from the silence down the hall. The elevator sound. It had been half an hour since the last time he heard it, and he was almost certain this time it was Charlie and Reza coming home. He prepared himself for what he must do. The last time had been a false alarm, this time he was sure it was Charlie and Reza. And indeed, as he sat and gripped the baseball bat even tighter, he heard footsteps coming down the hall. No one talking—but what was there to say between them? Reza had taken her to the Caribbean, got her drunk and coked up, laid her on a bed and let maybe a half-dozen guys fuck her. What was there to talk about?

This was over, it couldn't go on anymore. It would end today with a grand and bloody finality that would change his life forever but it had to be done.

He heard a suitcase set down in the hall just beyond the apartment door; heard the jingling of keys, a cat's-head key-chain tapping underneath the doorknob as the lock was whisked open. The door was kicked, and it knocked against the wall next to the fridge and made a picture frame rattle. A grunt sounded, then a growl of irritation. The door slammed closed.

He sat there waiting, looking for his opportunity.

There was a moment of silence, the sound of clothing rustling, and then Charlie jumped into view, her high heels stomping down the steps—and there she was, two feet away from him.

He pushed his back into the wall, clenched his teeth tighter and waited.

Reza didn't come.

Charlie stomped across the apartment to the bed, and with two hands, heaved the suitcase like she was giving a child an airplane ride. It landed on the bed, bounced and toppled right off to the other side and clattered on the floor in front of the closet. She made another growling sound, and Jonny continued to watch her.

All he wanted to do right now was rush to her and take her in his arms. Unfortunately, he had a very important job to do.

She kicked her shoes off, purposely flicking them toward the closet, one hurtling and tapping against the bathroom door. Now she stomped and stood at Jonny's workstation. She looked at it. It was dim and shut down, and she slapped her hands on her thighs and made an animated What the fuck? gesture. She ran her hand through her hair and growled again. She stomped into the bathroom and slammed the door closed.

Fuck. It was obvious Reza wasn't here. He waited another half a minute, his grip on the baseball bat slackening then he stepped forward, peered around the corner and up into the kitchen, saw no one. He heard Charlie flush the toilet, and he walked to one of the red IKEA chairs and lay the bat on the floor, tapping it with his toes until it rolled, hidden underneath.

He walked to the center of the apartment feeling so unsure of himself. He was bewildered with indecision. The bathroom door clicked open and Charlie emerged with the hissing sound of the toilet remaining behind her. She saw him there, and both of them locked gaze but said nothing. Her jaw was firmly set, and her brow was furrowed, but he saw a happiness gleam in her eyes.

He hurtled toward her, and she said, “Where were you? I was—” and then she grunted a huffing sound as he hugged the life out of her. Her hands went over him, but she pushed him away.

He said, “Are you okay?”

“I’m fine.”

He held her shoulders and pushed her back but gripped her so she couldn’t get away. “Are you?”

“I told you I’m fine.” Her tone was certain.

“Where is he? Where is Reza?”

“He went out with friends.” A haughty disdain in her voice.

“He came back on the plane with you? He’s in the city?”

“Yeah, he is. I told you he went out with friends.”

“When is he coming back?”

“Were you working?”

“I was.”

“Did you get a lot done?” There was a demanding in her voice.

“I got a lot done,” he said, now feeling a certain irritation in himself as well. He said, “What’s going on?”

“What’s going on? I go away for two days and I come home expecting to see you passed out on the bed from overwork. I come in and everything’s blank. Every thing is black.”

“Charlie, why are you so mad?” Visions of her waking up in the morning with her sore and tattered vagina hanging open, laying on a bed spattered with semen, fulfilled his question for him. She’d been violated. That was why she was mad.

She made as if she was considering an answer and instead he tugged at her shoulders and her head snapped back. He circled his arms around her again and squeezed her tight, his hands making hard fists over her slender back. He said, “I’m going to fucking kill him.”

“Kill him? Kill who?—Reza?”

“I’m going to get him back. Don’t you worry, Charlie. He won’t get away with it.”

“Get away with what?” she said.

“What he did to you. It’s a fucking crime, Charlie. I don’t care if he did it in the Caribbean, I don’t care what their laws are. I know what the punishment is.”

“What did he do?”

“He sent me videos, Charlie.”

“What?” she said and pushed herself away from him.

He said, “Of what he did to you.”

She looked puzzled and said, “What did he do to me?”

“He gave you to all those men.”

She stared at him her mouth fallen open with her brow lowered in puzzlement. She shook her head and struggled with what to say. Finally she

said, “What are you talking about?”

“He let all those men have their way with you.”

“What men?” There was a certain irritation in her voice again.

“All the men from the club. They got you naked on the bed ...”

She rolled her eyes and crossed her arms over her chest. She said, “Yeah?”

Red boiling rage swept over him and he blurted with contempt: “You let them fuck you?”

The muscles of her jaw flexed and her arms uncrossed. It looked like she might slap him. She had a hand back, her palm laid out flat. She said, “Nobody had sex with me.”

“You don’t know they did. You were passed out, and they put you on the bed ...”

“Nobody had sex with me, Jonny.” She was positive.

“Charlie, you were so drunk—”

She scoffed and rolled her eyes, turned her body away from him by a degree. Mad but also slightly embarrassed.

“You were, Charlie. He lifted your skirt and showed everybody ... you know ...”

“He did not, Jonny.”

“He did, Charlie. I saw it myself.”

She was skeptical, shaking her head at him. “I know I didn’t have sex with anyone. Do you think six men would have sex with me and I didn’t know about it? Do you think I could have a little too much to drink and even one man would have sex with me and I would wake up and not know about it? I know the next morning even with you.”

That hurt, and he was frozen, not knowing what to say. He didn't know how to explain it to her, tell her what he'd seen, let her know what had been done to her.

She said, "Jonny. I did not have sex with anyone." Each word was carefully enunciated.

He stood there frozen, his hands outstretched, his palms turned up. He knew what he'd seen, he knew what had been done to her. Parts of him wanted to fall at her feet and believe what she said. Parts of him wanted to take her up in his arms and together they would cry at the enormous relief that he was mistaken. A bigger part of him wished he could communicate to her what he knew. What had been shown to him.

She said, "Did he send you video of them having sex with me?"

"No."

"Jonny. I am telling you. I was not in bed with six men. I wasn't even in bed with one man. Except to sleep."

He shook his head in puzzlement. "He sent me video ...". His voice was so sad, a tickle working up his back, doubt weaving its way through his thoughts finally. He'd been duped. He was so stupid. He'd lost a day of work for no reason. He said, "You didn't have sex with anyone?"

Arms crossed over her chest again, she still glowered. "No one."

"No, Charlie, I can't believe it," he babbled with relief but still struggling with doubt. He was going to be her savior, he was ready to do the ultimate thing, he was ready to vindicate her, to bring her the justice she deserved. For nothing.

He hugged her again, and she uncrossed her arms. She said, "That's why you weren't working?"

"I did work. I did, Charlie. I got a lot done. Yesterday I got so much done."

"And today?"

“Well, why didn’t you call me today? Why didn’t you send me a text?”

“I lost my phone,” she said, moving away from him, her arms uncrossing and hanging down at her sides. She looked down and they both comprehended. She hadn’t lost her phone, someone had hidden it on her just for this reason. Quietly, she said, “Reza said he texted you this morning.”

“He didn’t.”

She sighed, still afraid to meet his gaze, and she threw up her arms. She wore the same thing she had traveled in on Friday evening, and now she left their circle and headed to the closet. She opened the door and pulled out her PJs.

He said, “Why are you so mad?”

She took off her top, folded her arms behind her and began to unclasp her bra. She said, “I’m not. I’m not mad.”

“Then why are you stomping around?”

“I’m not.” She took the bra off and tossed it on the bed, stood there bare-chested, unfolded her white undershirt then pushed her arms through it and pulled it over her head.

“Yes, you were. You came in here upset.”

“You weren’t at your desk.”

“You were mad when you came in. I saw you looking at my workstation, seeing I wasn’t there, you were already mad.”

She shook her head at him like she was angry again. She said, “Where were you? Hiding? Are you spying on me?”

“No. I was standing in plain view and you walked past me.”

Now she slumped; didn't have an explanation for that one and she felt a little bad that she might've walked right past him and missed him. Take that. She softened a little, unzipped her skirt and let it fall to the floor. She pulled her panties down, too, and turned her back to him and he saw her pert white buns. He said, "You didn't get any sun?"

She kicked her skirt into the closet, turned around and put her pajama shorts on. She said, "A little. I wasn't out in the sun much."

He returned to it. "And why are you mad?"

"I'm not mad, Jonny. I'm not. I'm just, I don't know ... It was a lot this weekend. It was a lot, and ... look, there's no way I'm mad at you. Although it would've been nice to see you at your workstation when I got home, I'm not mad at you."

"You're mad at Reza?"

"Can we just not talk about it?"

"Did he do something?"

"Jonny, I told you. I told you he did nothing. And I mean nothing."

Chapter Eight

Jonny helped Charlie move her suitcase back onto the bed, heaving it to lay on top. When he stood again, the two of them silent and looking at each other for a moment, he wiggled his right leg to adjust the cage inside his pants.

She said, “How is that thing?”

“Uncomfortable.”

“Do you think I should take a look at it?”

It was an exciting thought but the profound enormity of the moment squashed some of its sexuality. “Yeah. Maybe you should.”

She said, “I’ll get some ointment.”

Charlie went into the bathroom and flicked the light on and he undid his belt buckle, unbuttoned and unzipped his pants and let them fall to his ankles. He held up the front of his shirt as she returned.

She came back to him, her eyes lowered to the small metal cage bundled between his legs. There was concern there. She held ointment in one hand, stepping lightly and looking so pretty in just her shorts and undershirt. Her hair hung around her chest and shoulders, an unkempt but beautiful mess. She squatted down in front of him and he smelled cigarettes.

She said, “Sit down, Jonny. Sit down on the edge of the bed and open your legs for me.”

“Okay.”

He set himself down and let his knees go wide, his heels touching. She got on her knees and wormed herself close to take a look. Her mouth switched from side to side as she regarded his genitals through narrowed eyes. She said, “It doesn’t look bad. It’s a little red, I guess. It’s itchy?”

“Yeah. It rubs sometimes.”

“I’ll bet,” she said.

“Are you going to rub ointment on it?”

“I think I should,” she said.

Now his heart did start to pound, and he felt a sexual surge where there shouldn’t be one. Five minutes ago he was ready to go to jail. He was ready to sacrifice everything he had to vindicate the woman he loved. He was ready to restore her sanctity through violence. Now it was all gone. All washed away. All his anger and pain of the last twenty hours completely purposeless. But he hadn’t known that. He’d been ready to do it, and now it didn’t matter. Just when he didn’t think things could get any crazier ...

Charlie unscrewed the top of the ointment, set it down on his thigh and it made him flinch.

He said, “That’s cold.”

She said, “Sorry,” and it at least provoked a little smile from her. Now she squeezed out a rolling pearl onto the middle finger of her right hand, her eyes still on his constrained manhood. This was medical, it was sad and tragic, it was awful—and yet he could feel himself growing aroused. The ring that circled his scrotum began to tighten and tug downward. But he wouldn’t stop her.

“You ready?” she asked him. “It’s going to be cold.”

“Go ahead,” he said and leaned back a little, put his hands out behind him and watched between his legs. What he had wasn’t much, it was enough, but it was very small compared to what Reza had. Bundled with steel wires

into a tight ball between his legs it looked even tinier now. Next to Charlie's hand, which he could use in comparison to the man who had sex with her frequently, he could see the size difference in stark contrast in his mind's eye. Was it possible that his penis was shrinking inside this cage?

Charlie touched him and his legs bounced a little, the lid tumbling off his thigh patting quietly onto the floor. Charlie giggled.

"Cold?"

He said, "It's okay."

Charlie swiped her fingers in slippery circles where the contact against his skin was tightest. That was the steel ring that went around the base of his penis and around underneath his scrotum. Every touch got his tummy fluttering, and she watched it as her finger went around and around.

She worked the ointment in and he could feel its soothing medicinal properties already at work. She lingered, like she knew that he was enjoying it and didn't want it to end. Around her neck there was a thin chain, and it dipped between her breasts, hidden behind the undershirt. But he knew what was most likely at the end of that necklace. Very quietly, he asked her, "Do you think you could unlock it?"

They knew the rules, and he saw her posture slump a little. He continued: "Just to put the ointment on." Like this wasn't just for the sake of the skin irritation.

"I shouldn't."

"You don't have to. But I'd really appreciate it."

"Jonny, don't ..." she sighed.

He let it go. Her fingers continued anyway, knowing he was getting more from this than he should, but she didn't seem to care. His heart beat low and hard, and strangely deep in his chest like it had sunken. He asked her, "What did you do on your trip?"

“It wasn’t much.”

“Did you have fun?”

“You told me to.”

“Yeah, no, I know I told you. Did you?”

“Sometimes.”

“The pictures Reza sent me, it looks like you’re having fun. At night? Was it at a club?”

“Yeah.”

“You went out for dinner, you went to a night club ...?”

“We did,” she said with a soft sigh, her head cocked to one side as she used her first two fingers to stroke at the sensitive bit underneath his scrotum.

He tightened his stomach muscles making the tight metal globe of his genitals tilt upward so it sat upright between his legs, bundled up smaller than a tennis ball. Charlie knew what she did felt good to him and still she did it. He could feel all the badness, hurt, and fear he suffered over the last twenty-four hours begin to seep from him, toxicants exiting through his pores like a poisonous sweat. His heart began to pump those feelings of love for her.

She said, “I don’t know what to tell you, Jonny. You want to hear all the boring details?—”

“No. Well, y—”

“—because there wasn’t much that was exciting. Reza did a bunch of work all day on Saturday. We got in late on Friday and went to bed. We didn’t even... you know... do anything. That was okay. Then when I woke up on Saturday morning, he was gone already. Didn’t even leave me a note. So I went down to the beach and just walked around a little.”

“Did you wear that bikini?”

“No. I felt foolish.”

“Then what happened?”

“He came back after lunch and didn’t even eat with me.”

“Was he mean to you?”

“Not mean. Just didn’t care that I was there.”

“At all?”

“Not until the late, late, late afternoon. Then he came home and made me go down to the beach with him.”

“What was the weather like?”

“I told you. It was hot and sunny.”

“He made you wear that bikini?”

She was quiet for a moment then softly said, “Yeah.”

“He paraded you around?”

She said, “Is this too much for you?”

He shook his head, said, “What do you mean?”

She withdrew her fingers and her eyes went to his then back down between his legs. He saw that he had hardened within the cage. It was pulling upward on his balls. He’d been so caught up in the angst of hearing about her with another man so far away from home his mind had suppressed the discomfort between his legs.

He said, “You can tell me.”

“I don’t think I should. We’re not supposed to do this.” She sat back down on her heels, and he watched as her hand swept around the floor until it found the ointment lid. She screwed the cap back on it and stood up, said, “You should put your pants back on.”

He watched her walk away and into the bathroom to put the ointment away and when she came back out he asked, “Are you mad at me?”

She walked to the side of the bed and unzipped her suitcase. She said, “I told you I’m not mad at you, Jonny. I’m not.”

He stood and hiked his pants up, did the buckle. Now his genitals were uncomfortable. He was throbbing between his legs but there was nowhere for his penis to grow—it tightened against the steel but the ointment made it slick and it felt like everything was slipping around down there. Except his testicles. Those felt like they were being squeezed hard. He sat back down.

“Charlie, just tell me what happened at night. Please? I just want to know you’re okay.”

Charlie began to unpack. She said, “You can see that I’m okay, Jonny. He sent you pictures?”

“Yeah. Those guys had their hands all over you. He sent me videos of you dancing with them. I saw that you weren’t wearing any panties.”

That stopped her. She stood with her back to him, a bundle of clothes folded up and held at her waist. He could see her head go forward. She said, “He told me not to wear them.”

“And you do everything he says.”

Talking to the wall, she said, “You know I do.”

He hung his own head, put his hands together in his lap and looked at them. “I do. I know that,” he said.

Charlie went in the closet and began putting things away. He turned and set a hand out, sitting on his hip now. He said, “Did you do cocaine?”

She didn't answer him. Just tidied up her clothes and put them away. That was an answer. He didn't need to ask her again. He watched her a little longer, and she didn't want to offer up anything more. Something was bothering her, she was annoyed. It was probably Reza. He didn't feel like it was him. She would probably tell him. So he'd let her brood and unpack her clothes.

Before she was done the throbbing between his legs had subsided and he stood up and dropped himself into his workstation and fired up his computer. He said, "I better get back to work."



Reza didn't come home on the Sunday night. Just the same, Jonny slept on the couch, anticipating his arrival.

Reza never showed, and in the morning he had great regret that he hadn't slipped into bed with Charlie. And when she woke in the morning, she was mad Reza hadn't come home, too. Something had happened between them and he was having trouble sussing it out. He'd asked her a few times, and she told him she didn't want to discuss it. He'd even pleaded, just a little, and she told him 'later.' He left it alone, but wow had it bothered him.

He was of two thoughts: the first, of course, that there was something that had transpired, something dirty, probably with those other men, and she'd been offended. Given the video he'd seen, his mind locked on this fact, but as time passed and he watched his wife around the house, he began to form another opinion: the second, that Charlie had been ignored in the Caribbean and she was mad at Reza for that. There were associated thoughts that danced around this line of thinking. They were hard to take. Like, maybe Reza was flirtatious with some other women and it made Charlie jealous. But the worst, so bad he was afraid to poke around it too much: Charlie wanted to have sex with Reza but he had been too busy. Well, wasn't that a fucking killer? She'd said to him quite pointedly: I did not have sex with

anyone, Jonny. There was irritation in her voice. Was that because she wanted to and didn't get it? He didn't like that one bit. Was it possible he'd be happier to know she'd been violated in some way? Was it possible that would be a less hurtful outcome for him? It was, but he'd suffer ahead of Charlie any time you asked him, so he'd actually prefer to hear the worst news. The thoughts of her being violated had him buying a baseball bat and preparing to do the ultimate deed.

The idea that he would feel pain over hers had a nobility that eased some of his discomfort. There was a security in knowing you were righteous. Even if the truth of that meant that as much as your wife hated having sex with the landlord and his disgusting monster penis, she'd grown to want it.

Reza came home again, Monday after work, late in the evening near bedtime.

Chapter Nine

Charlie had been home from the library for an hour before she made dinner for just the two of them. It was like she had been waiting to see if Reza would arrive.

He didn't, and Jonny sensed her exasperation as she banged pots and pans around in the kitchen, using some of the expensive items in the fridge to make them a pretty good salad with chicken in it. But they didn't eat together at the kitchen table, instead she plunked it down on his workstation and then sat on the couch by herself. That was a message. Keep working.

He was, too, she didn't have to worry. But it wasn't like Charlie to be so irritated all the time. So he said nothing, kept on typing with a big bowl of salad in his lap, picking away at it as he worked. Next to him, on his left side, the TV flicked to life but instead of watching *The Twilight Zone*, Charlie watched dumb game shows. They were together in the room but he felt strangely apart. She would get over it soon, whatever it was. He knew she would. He'd never seen her like this before, though.

When he was done his dinner he gathered up his bowl, went to the coffee table and collected hers sitting empty in front of her bare feet curled over the table's lip. He thanked her for dinner and he gave her a smile, not too earnest as to be pleading, but enough to show her how much he cared for her and respected whatever she was going through. That worked. She gave a funny little head shake like she knew she was being difficult, and she smiled for him, too.

He went in the kitchen and washed the dishes and then he washed the pan where she cooked the chicken. He put it all away, then sat with her on the couch. They didn't say anything, but he could tell Charlie liked having him sitting next to her. They didn't hold hands, and they didn't look at each other, they just watched TV together. After fifteen minutes, he said "I better

get back to work,” and as he sat up, he patted the top of her foot. It made him feel better. Having her in a bad mood like this gripped at his heart and made its beat seem strained. But that meager contact seemed to repair it a little, and he felt physically lighter as he returned to his workstation.

Code was plucked away for hours and he got a lot done. Charlie watched TV and when he checked on her one time he found her sleeping. Laying there on the couch with her feet on the coffee table, her head back on the couch’s head rest and tilted to the side. Her lips had parted, but she made no sounds of snoring. She looked peaceful.

Reza got home finally at around nine o’clock. Jonny hadn’t seen him since Friday. Charlie woke, looked bewildered for a moment, then glanced up to the kitchen to see Reza up there hanging up his keys. She rolled her eyes, brought her feet onto the couch and hugged her knees, the remote still clutched in one hand. She turned the volume up.

Reza came to the stairs, stepped down onto one and stood there over everyone else, watching them. He said, “How’s everyone doing?”

Without looking, Charlie thumped her chin between her two knees and muttered, “Fine.”

“How about you, Jonny?”

Jonny had just been watching and forgot he was involved with all of this. He shook his head briefly, said, “I’m fine. Where were you?”

“I had things to do. I don’t answer to you.”

“I don’t care where you go. I’m just making small talk.” Jonny fixed him with a gaze. Something had changed between them. He figured it came when he made the decision that he could do what he had to do. Sure, it hadn’t played out the way he’d anticipated. But when the time came, he could do the grandest gesture of them all. For the sake of Charlie, he could confront Reza. Some of the fear had been diminished. It didn’t change the parameters of this awful relationship in any way, but some of the pressure had been released.

Charlie tossed the remote control onto the coffee table with a clatter and she rose. To no one, she said, "I have to go to the bathroom." She walked across the apartment, her heel strikes coming a little heavy, then she closed herself in the bathroom.

It left Jonny and Reza alone, looking at each other.

"What's with her?" Reza said.

"I think you know."

"Do I?"

"What did you do to her?"

"What makes you think I did anything?"

"She's mad."

Reza shrugged. "And you think she's mad at me?"

Jonny stood up now, walked halfway across the room and put his hands in his pockets. Reza stepped down one step and stood evenly with him half a dozen feet away.

Jonny said, "I don't think she had a good time in the Caribbean."

"That's on her, Jonny." Reza said confidently. "Have a seat." He gestured towards the couch.

Something tightened in him, a tense anticipation coming unexpectedly. "Why?"

"You want to talk. Let's talk."

Jonny took a seat on the couch and with the point of his shoe, Reza pushed and angled one of the red IKEA chairs to face him. He sat down across and looked at him.

Jonny said, "I didn't appreciate those pictures and videos you sent me."

Reza chuckled, threaded his fingers together and leaned forward with his forearms on his knees. He said, "I think you did. I think you really liked them."

"Why would I like them?"

"We're gonna dance around this all the time? Just face it, Jonny. You like your wife being a slut. I sent those pictures as a favor to you."

"You sent them to taunt me."

"You love it."

"You wanted me to believe you let all those guys fuck her."

"She tell you they didn't?"

"She told me they didn't. I believe her."

Jonny watched Reza's mouth underneath the thick mustache of his beard as it slowly tilted to one side and then he smiled. He said, "We didn't fuck her. Nobody fucked her."

"I would kill you if you did that."

Reza disregarded him, didn't even acknowledge his remark as a threat. Instead he smiled. "I wouldn't if she were passed out, Jonny. But they were there to fuck her. She asked them to come along. If she was awake, I bet you she would have fucked every single one of them."

"No, she wouldn't."

"I think I know your Charlie a little better than you do."

"What? No, you don't."

"In that way I do."

“Sex? No, you don’t.”

“Please, Jonny,” he chided. “You should have seen her on the dance floor grinding her long, hard body on them. She wanted them.”

“You’re such an asshole.”

Reza laughed. “You don’t know her like I know her. She’s a slut, and she’s looking to blossom. Those pink little petals want to open up.” Jonny watched as Reza held his two hands together in closed fists and he gradually extended his fingers, imitating Charlie’s vagina opening up for other men. The baseball bat was under the chair, only a dozen feet away and his mind leapt to it, flashed him a picture of itself, its steely weight resting on the hardwood.

“I fucking hate you,” he said.

“You should, Jonny, you should. Even if, miracle of all miracles, you get your wife back from me, I will have changed her.”

“No.”

“Oh yes, Jonny. If you can manage to win her back, you’re going to have a woman you will never, ever, ever manage to please. You’ll never fulfill her like I fulfill her. Even with ten million in the bank, little Jonny, you won’t have what it takes to scratch Charlie’s deepest itch. It’s me giving her that tickle, Jonny. It’s me putting that desire in her that you could never meet.”

“You’re wrong.”

“You can act confident, Jonny, but I can see through it. I know in your heart you see the truth.” Now he leaned forward and gripped Jonny’s knee. “Your little wife took some blow, but I think she smoked weed all day when I was in business meetings. Now that’s a depressed wife, smoking rope all day, all alone. She’s got stuff she wants to escape. I think she was so baked the coke didn’t work on her. Once those men started feeding her whisky and wine she got sloppy. We had to carry her back to the hotel room and Jonny she wanted us but it just wasn’t right. We’re not animals. It was sad really, her

laying on the bed begging us to come and join her. I didn't have the heart to send that to you. Begging for our big dicks, tsk tsk," he shook his head and clucked his tongue as if recalling a tragic scene.

"Bull. Shit."

"It's true. It's a boner killer when a girl gets like that. Pathetic. Too hungry, Jonny. It's a turn off."

"You're such a liar."

"Am I?" he said with a sneer. In a soft and breathy Charlie imitation, Reza panted, "Who wants to fuck me first?" He even made his eyes go glassy and drunk-looking.

"Fuck you. If she did that you would send me the video."

"I couldn't film it, Jonny. I put the camera down. I don't like you, but I care about Charlie. I wouldn't film her like that. I felt bad. She must be going through a lot. You know. Inside her brain. Wondering how she fucked up so bad, getting into this situation. But then, like, knowing it's actually your fault. Wondering, beginning to doubt the faith she has in you. She had a lot of fun with me and those guys, you know, before she passed out. That's what her life could be like if she wasn't weighed down by the bricks you tied to her."

Jonny rolled his eyes in irritation and disbelief but couldn't deny the dozen quick and short knife wounds Reza had just stabbed him up with.

Reza said, "You think something is wrong with Charlie? You think it's me?" He stood up now, took off his suit jacket and laid it over the back of the chair. He began to unbutton his shirt cuffs. "Charlie's mad at herself, Jonny. She had a chance at a gang bang with a half dozen of the hottest rich young dudes in the Bahamas and she blew it. She got too drunk. She wanted it, Jonny. Believe it or not, I don't give a fuck. I know Charlie and I know she's mad because she missed out on something she really wanted. Wanted bad."

There was no sense in arguing. Offering up resistance to Reza just fed his arrogance. So Jonny fixed his eyes on his and showed him his words meant nothing to him. Deep inside, they would begin to twist at him and create anfractuous hurt that he would be dealing with probably forever. But he wouldn't give Reza the satisfaction of showing him that.

“Go easy on her, Jonny. She didn't have a good Sunday. Man, you should have seen her. She asked me if we could stay longer and I told her What was the point? Those guys had gone home already. When she sobered up she asked me to call them, Jonny, can you believe it?—she was trying to get me to put it together again. Bring all those guys back so we could get naked and roll around in bed with her. Charlie loves big cock, Jonny. She took a feel of all those guys to make sure they measured up.”

There was no way that was true. So Jonny continued to stare and keep his face as expressionless as a stone.

Reza watched him, said no more, his twinkling eyes taking him in. He smiled the whole time, taking his shirt off now. He got undressed while Jonny watched, stood completely naked, Charlie still in the bathroom, then got into bed, turned out the light on the night table and turned away.

Jonny went back to work at his workstation and maybe twenty minutes later, Charlie emerged. She looked toward the bed and saw Reza sleeping, looked toward Jonny. Her face was pinched in a scowl.

Slowly her meanness softened but didn't disappear. She looked at his computer for a moment, her eyes finally meeting his gaze. She said, “Good night.”

“Good night,” he said to her, his heart pounding in his chest. He had images of her cupping her hand between the legs of all those guys that danced with her. Their bodies humping up against her and Charlie squeezing their dicks and balls through their pants while she writhed against them, loving their size in her hand. It couldn't be true.

She got undressed as well, and he angled his clever mirror toward the bed. He watched her there in the reflection, saw her in her short-short pajamas

and undershirt climbing into bed. She looked at Reza and Reza was already sleeping. She watched him a little longer, and irritated then, bounced around a little and turned her back to him. Jonny tried to work, but he was fixated by her face as she grew sleepy, closed her eyes, and eventually fell asleep.

Chapter Ten

Charlie had been in a bad mood since she got home from work. A bad mood for Charlie wasn't really that bad, it just hurt to see her not her usual kind self. The absence of her kindness was pronounced. Jonny had a girlfriend just after high school who had bad moods that were frightening. Banging things around and shouting and it came with a tension from the threat of potential catastrophic explosion. She did, too, a couple times, explode on him over nothing. But that girl was a nothing to him. Charlie was everything, so the fact that she wasn't her happy self was hurting him rather than frightening him. He wanted her to be happy again.

It was Wednesday now, and they hadn't seen much of Reza. He'd come home Monday night to sleep. Same thing last night, too, getting in very late and getting into bed with hardly time for a mean word to Jonny before he was snoring. When he got up this morning he was out the door without a word, headed to the gym to train and then shower there.

After work, Charlie had made him dinner again. Another nice salad, and they ate together on the couch but she didn't want to talk so he didn't make her. He'd thought of rubbing her feet for her, at least making the offer, but didn't for fear of what that would do between his legs. The cage was an omnipresent concern.

Progress on the game was stellar. Shulamit was hungry for work and she knew if she beat the milestones she would get new assignments. That meant she disregarded what his schedule said and just hammered away, sending him two milestones at the same time today. Showing off a little maybe. Fucking great. She could show off all she wanted if it meant they could get this thing up and running and completely presentable sooner than he even wished.

Work came in from Javed and before he cracked it open, he went up to the kitchen for a Coke. Charlie sat on the couch reading a book with her legs drawn up and to the side, *Wuthering Heights* braced on her thigh. Up in the kitchen he grabbed himself his pop, but coming down the steps again he beelined to the couch, feeling in a good mood tonight even if she wasn't. He plopped himself down right next to her. She jostled with his movements but said nothing, just continued reading. He watched her.

She turned a page slowly, concentrating on her book, but now her head turned to look at him expressionlessly.

He said, "Hi."

Her head turned back, and she traced her finger along the first line of the next page as if trying to steady her focus on reading again. She said, "What are you doing?"

"Sitting with you."

"I'm trying to read."

"I like watching you read."

"I can't read if you're watching me."

"I used to watch you and you didn't know it, remember? When I would come into the library at your school and work ..."

The book she held slumped a little against her thighs and she rolled her eyes—but he could see the slightest hint of a smile there. She said, "I knew you were watching me."

"I thought I was getting away with it."

"You weren't."

Now he edged himself a little closer and his thigh almost touched her haunch. "But you liked it?"

That smile stayed the same small shape but now it lifted to one side and a dimple dented her cheek. Her pretty eyes stayed lowered to the page, but she ran a lock of her hair behind an ear so he could see her perfect face.

He answered for her: “Yeah, you liked it.”

“I did not,” she whispered but now her smile grew a little wider.

He touched the bare heel of her foot with the back of his hand, let it rest there. “I hope you come out of it soon.”

“Out of what?” She faced him now, her eyebrows pinched quizzically.

“Whatever it is that’s got you tense.”

“I’ll be fine,” she said and closed her book, then hugged it to her chest with both arms. Her gaze drifted off to the far side of the room, watching his empty workstation. He joined her and they both looked at the empty place where he should be sitting.

He said, “You’d tell me if Reza did anything to hurt you? Or anything you didn’t want.”

“I don’t want any of those—”

“You know what I mean.”

She regarded him blankly. “I would.”

“Nothing happened in the Bahamas?”

She solemnly shook her head no.

“Did you want it to?”

Her brow lowered, went to a straight and even line over top of her fierce green eyes. “What does that mean?”

“Did you want to have sex with those guys from the club?”

“Jonny, I told you I didn’t.”

“I know, but ... would you tell me if you did?”

“I didn’t,” she said coldly.

He looked down at his hands gathered in his lap. “Reza told me you wanted them but you ... fell asleep.”

She made a coarse sighing sound, and he knew she was mad again. “I told you I didn’t. Reza tells you I did. You believe Reza. You believe him over me.”

“It’s not that I don’t believe you.”

She said, “I think you want me to sometimes.”

“Want you to what?”

“Do that,” she gestured and made her eyes go wide as she put her index finger into the OK sign of her other hand like a penis going in a vagina. “With other men.”

He didn’t answer, just stared at her. He said, “Reza tell you that?”

She shrugged.

“He says that. You believe him sometimes just as much as I do. We’re both guilty of that. He’s trying to get between us and you fall for his bullshit just like I do.”

She exhaled and stared away. “Would you just ... just go to work, please? Let me read my book.”

She wouldn’t look at him but he watched her, saw her blinking eyes, her pursed but pouting pale pink lips, the spray of freckles across her smooth cheeks. Her hair tumbled forward as she shook her head and loosened it from where it tucked behind an ear. He smiled and stood up, kissed the top of her head and went back to his workstation. She wasn’t cheered up yet,

but he could see progress. And just that sliver of sun coming through the clouds lifted his spirit, and he felt spiritually lighter as he returned to his keyboard and resumed his coding, checking Javed's work while he did.



The code streamed from his fingertips in an endless clatter of keys. He was in the zone, and as the ideas emerged from his brain they were communicated immediately through his lightning fast fingers. Line after line scrolling across the screen bringing him closer to the end of this.

There was a distraction in his vision but it didn't slow him down. In fact, it might be why he was going so quickly now.

It was Charlie.

Sleep was obviously eluding her because he could see in the small circular cosmetic mirror he kept on his desktop that she tossed and turned. She would lay facing away for a moment then she would be batting at the pillow with a fist, jumping and turning around with a low and mean looking brow. Then she would bundle the pillow up under her head and he would watch as she lay facing him now with her eyes purposely shut—like they didn't want to close and she forced them. It wasn't long, however, before they would inch up again and he would see her staring at nothing, the reflection of his monitors lighting up the wet of her big green eyes. Then her feet were kicking, the sheets were shooting up in the air and she was tossing over to the other side again.

It was never like this before between them, and soon it would never be like this again. With Shulamit and Javed in his corner things were looking good. Things were looking really good. Sure, it was terrible to be in debt to Reza like this but that debt came with the promise of final freedom. So he let the code stream through him, even smiling a little despite his wife's chagrin.

It was almost midnight when Reza came home again. The door to the apartment opened and Jonny didn't even stop typing. His head just slightly cocked, his ear facing toward the door and noting the sound. When you were in the zone, shit like this didn't matter.

At least Reza was alone. He came into the kitchen by himself, no one here to gang up on Jonny and aggravate him while he tried to work. No hunky but dismissive Tate, no somehow friendly yet simultaneously menacing Demetrius. Just like the previous nights, he hoped Reza would come in, take his clothes off, go to bed and sleep. As annoying as it might seem, Jonny even managed these nights to work right through his buzz-saw snoring. So, good, come in, take your shoes off, climb into bed with my wife and saw some logs. You asshole.

That line had got him smirking, and now while he typed his eyes drifted to the mirror and saw Reza coming down the steps from the kitchen and into the living room. The lights of the monitors lit him up and he saw that the landlord wore a business suit tonight. His face was grim and mean, as usual, and he stopped in the middle of the room, eyeballed the annoyed lump in the bed then over to the workstation. That thick mustache of his tilted to one side as he smiled. He sure liked his handiwork.

Yes, Reza had crafted a real webwork of hurt and filth and jealousy. He'd interjected himself into the lives of two happily married people and offered them gifts aplenty. And everything that was given to them came with an enormous price.

He darted his eyes back to the screen and chose to ignore his landlord. His fingers flew faster. Only now it was Charlie who had something to say to Reza, and she wasn't going to bite her tongue. Jonny saw a flash of white in his mirror. It was Charlie whipping the sheets away. She was mad. She bolted up wearing her little undershirt and her short shorts and brought her knee up. She confronted Reza, saying, "You think you can come home at midnight?"

Reza smiled and began to un-knot his tie. He said, "You know I've been busy. You know that I was up to some pretty great things while I was in the Bahamas. This is an intense time for me."

“So what? I have to work in the morning.”

“Poor, Charlie,” Reza sang, unthreading his tie from around his neck and tossing it to the nightstand. As he unbuttoned his shirt, he said, “You sure got it bad, don’t you?”

“Why are you such a jerk these days?” she asked him.

“I don’t think I am.”

“It’s midnight, Reza,” she stated again. “It’s midnight and I’m trying to sleep.” She thrust both hands towards Jonny and said, “And I got this guy with his monitors all over the place shooting lights all around the apartment and then I got you walking in and slamming doors, walking through the apartment with your shoes on. Does anybody care? Doesn’t anybody care?” She huffed with exasperation and tilted her chin up to look at the ceiling and shake her head.

Reza chuckled. He unbuttoned his shirt and let it hang open. The muscles of his chest and abdomen were visible in the gap, his cascading trail of thick body hair pointing a line to his belt buckle and what lay below it.

He undid his cufflinks and smiled while regarding her.

“What?” she asked, irritated by his lack of concern over her troubles.

“I told you I was busy. I told you I had work to do. All these nice things you’ve been enjoying, they don’t come out of thin air.”

“I don’t think they do,” she said defensively.

“Successful people don’t work nine-to-five, Charlie. That’s for chumps. I’m twenty-four-seven. You’re going to have to get used to it.”

“It wasn’t like that before.” There was a tone in her voice, a meanness and a haughtiness that Jonny hadn’t heard from her before.

Reza said, “Money ebbs and flows, young pretty Charlie.” He moved his hands like waves and said, “There’s times of rest and there’s times of

turmoil and I find opportunity in both. It's been a busy week, I don't need shit when I get home."

Charlie folded her arms over her chest now, not liking being talked to this way. She said, "Still, a little decency ..."

"Fuck's sake," Reza said, but he was smiling, "what do you want from me? I just walked in the door and you're latched on me like a tiger."

"It's been like this all week and I'm sick of it."

Reza pulled off his suit coat and shirt, stood there with his bare muscular body lit by Jonny's monitors. His chest flexed and jumped, his shoulders twitched as he tossed the clothing aside. He smiled at Charlie now and said, "Tell me what you want, Charlie."

"I want to sleep," she said after a long moment.

"So sleep."

"How can I with all this light and doors opening and closing?"

"What do you need to sleep?"

She growled with irritation.

After a brief stare-down: "Quiet," she whispered hoarsely.

"You want some earplugs? You want one of those nighttime masks? I'll send Tate for you tomorrow. Get you one with diamonds all around the edges. The best earplugs and night masks they make. Charlie likes her nice things, doesn't she?" He put a knee on the bed and leaned toward her, put his hand out to brush her cheek. She slapped his hand away.

"No, I don't."

"I think you do, Charlie."

"I don't."

“I know you like your big bed.”

She didn't answer. Her face was pinched and her lips pouted. She looked away.

“See? Don't tell me you don't like nice things. I'm not stupid. I know you like your shoes. Tell me you don't like your shoes, Charlie.”

She folded her arms tighter and stared away from him, her face scowling.

“Charlie.” Reza was serious now. Charlie knew, and she looked toward him. He smiled again, said, “Tell me you like your shoes.”

Her stiff posture softened, and she agreed. “I like my shoes.”

“I know you do. See, this is a good starting point. There's a lot of things you like. I don't know why you've been so grumpy these days but we can figure it out.”

Her posture further slackened, and she unfolded her arms and put them around her knees and hugged them. She put her chin between the points.

Reza said, “There, you're listening now. Well, I'm listening too, Charlie. Tell me what you want. Anything under the sun and I'll give it to you.”

“I don't want anything,” she said solemnly.

“Oh, I don't think that's true at all. Just tell me. You want a car? You want me to buy you a Mercedes? What color?”

“I don't like driving,” she said.

“What, then? What is it, Charlie?” he asked, feigning some sort of curious care. He got on both knees on the bed. “Tell me what you want.”

Charlie's head rolled around, and Jonny caught her peeping at him from her behind her locks. He stopped typing now. He suspected what it might be.

She said to Reza, “I don't know.”

Reza said, “Use your words, Charlie. That’s what you went to school for. Library science. You know all about words, don’t tell me you don’t know how to use them.”

Charlie looked back toward the workstation and Jonny saw her peeking at him again. He turned around to face her. Reza sneered over her shoulder at him.

He said, “What?”

Charlie softly said, “Can you put your headphones on?”

Chapter Eleven

“Why?”

“Would you please put your headphones on?”

Reza snapped his fingers, said, “Jonny. Listen to your wife.”

He showed them a solemn face and tried to hide the rage that had burst up within him. But under that rage, under that sickly swell, was an ocean of curiosity. So he showed them that he didn’t want to put his headphones on but he did. Because he wanted to.

With the headphones over his head now, big earmuffs style, he glowered at them. Charlie made a little gentle helicopter motion with her finger indicating for him to turn around. She didn’t smile for him, but there was a certain warmth of concern in her eyes.

As soon as he swiveled his chair around he tapped a few keys and activated the microphone. Instantly, his headphones were filled with the sound of the room.

His fingers began to type. Only it wasn’t code coming from his fingers right now. It was complete gobbledygook. Nonsense. His mind was focused on one thing and that was what Charlie wanted to ask from Reza.

Charlie watched him, he saw her face in the mirror turned toward him. Reza scratched his shoulder and waited. Charlie shouted “Jonny!” Loud and sharp. He made no movement.

She watched him further. Shouted again: “Jonny!”

Still he typed. Streams of useless characters.

He listened.

Charlie turned to face Reza again, and Reza asked her: “Well? What is it you want from me?”

Mean Charlie had simmered. Barely there now. What had emerged? Childish Charlie. Little Girl Charlie who wanted something. An ache developed in his belly. Hard and swirling and imminent. Right in the space between his bellybutton and that steel cage that locked his dick away.

“I don’t know,” Charlie said in a soft singsong.

Reza smiled wider. “Yes you do. Tell me.”

“Why didn’t you pay any attention to me in the Bahamas?” she asked him now, changing the subject and trying to control things.

Reza said, “You knew I was busy. You knew that was a work trip. We went out on Saturday, we had a good time.”

“I know. But you hardly even paid any attention to me.”

“Sure, I did.”

“We didn’t do ... anything.”

“We did lots of things.”

Charlie acted petulant, sighing briskly and cocking her head at him. She said, “You know what I mean.”

“Maybe I do,” he said acting stupid. Then: “Tell me.”

Charlie continued needling him. “So we come back, and then all week you’re hardly even around here.”

“So?”

“So?” She shrugged. She realized she couldn’t say what she wanted.

Reza prompted her “Tell me what you want and I’ll give it to you.”

Charlie’s head rolled around on her shoulders as she was confronted with the thing she didn’t want to face. It was a long while that she said nothing, just chewing her lips and looking around the room. Reza stayed on his knees on the bed with his big masculine torso completely bared. Finally, Charlie looked over her shoulder again, and Jonny watched from the corner of his eye as she regarded him. He kept typing.

When his eyes went back to the mirror, he saw Charlie’s foot stroking at Reza’s thigh. Little toes gripped at the fabric of his pant leg and tugged downward as if she wanted his pants off.

Reza watched her foot as it tugged. His hands came together at his waist and he undid his belt buckle, then slipped the clasp at the top of his pants and drew down his zipper. He put his hands on his hips. Charlie tugged a little harder and Reza’s pants lowered until shaggy, black pubic hair sprung from the V of his open fly. But with his knees spread the way he was kneeling, she couldn’t pull his pants any lower and reveal the large, shaved object she wanted.

Reza looked to her face now and said, “Is that what you want?”

Charlie didn’t answer. She let her foot come down, and she hugged her knees again. She rested her forehead on her thighs and hid her face from him. Her apricot mane tumbled around her legs.

Reza stood up by the side of the bed, let his pants fall to his ankles and stepped out of them. That huge cock danced between his thighs as he got himself back on the bed. Charlie looked at it. Reza said, “This is what you want, isn’t it?”

Charlie thumped her chin on her knees and stared at his penis.

“Don’t be embarrassed. Don’t be embarrassed at all, Charlie. Go ahead. I’m not judging you.”

Charlie peered over her shoulder again and Jonny whipped his eyes back to the screen. When they returned, he saw Charlie easing up to sit on her heels. She put a hand out and rested it on Reza's chest. She ran her nails over the muscle and watched his thick chest fur wriggle between her fingers. Reza put a hand over top of hers and they looked in each other's eyes for a moment. Reza smiled, took her hand in a straight line down between his legs and Charlie took his heavy dangling penis in her gentle grip.

Their faces were close together as her hand gripped and cuddled his cock. She milked it downward, lifted it while it flopped around. With thumb and forefinger she pulled the foreskin back and rubbed the cushion of her thumb over his urethra. Reza kissed her. Charlie took his kiss and held it. She stroked his cock with one hand while they made out. The sounds of their mouths were wet, and it made bright clicking sounds in the microphone's reception. It made Jonny wince.

The cage between his legs began to push downward, and he felt that tension in his scrotum again. It felt like a foot was stepping on his testicles. It ached down his thighs and into his knees. And that sickness still swirled just above the cage, somewhere in his center. He typed with one hand and clutched at his stomach.

Reza guided Charlie backward until she lay her back on the bed with her knees stuck up awkwardly. He rested his hands on them and widened them. He said, "What do you want me to do with it? Show me where you want it."

Charlie lay on her back and watched him. Then her hand moved, going down her body over her undershirt across her stomach. She touched herself between her legs.

"There? That's where you want it?"

She nodded.

"That's where I want it, too."

Charlie whispered, "I want it there."

“Tell me. Tell me you want.”

His hand went down and grabbed his cock. He began to pump it. The big, heavy thing wound around in lazy, floppy circles, slowly beginning to stiffen.

Charlie’s head tilted up and back to face the workstation upside down. Jonny’s eyes darted away again. He heard her say then, “I want you.”

“Want me what?”

Charlie made a tsk-ing sound and said, “I want you to do that.”

“Do what?”

Jonny’s eyes drifted back to see Charlie sit upward on her elbows. Her pert breasts poked out the front of her shirt and Jonny could see the points of her nipples tenting out the fabric. It was like pulling teeth, but Reza got her to say it: “I want you to fuck me.”

Reza smiled now, said, “That’s what I want to hear.”

“Please,” she added.

“I thought you had to work tomorrow?”

Charlie sighed again. She ran a hand through her mane and tugged at her hair. “Please, Reza. Don’t be mean.”

“You really want it?”

“I do.”

“Take those shorts off. Show me your pussy.”

Charlie did. She drew her knees up to her chest, dug her thumbs into the waistband of her shorts, swept them up her thighs. Reza took them at her knees and pulled them away from her feet. She let her legs fall again, and when her thighs drifted apart, she covered her sex with both hands.

“Show me,” Reza said.

Charlie let her hands come away and Reza smiled wider when he saw her pussy revealed. He batted at it with the back of his hand and Jonny could hear wet, sticky sounds in the microphone. He groaned and flexed his stomach. It felt like his cock was in a vice.

The groan attracted attention, so he darted his eyes away again. He knew they were watching him. He began typing faster, hitting enter angrily, stabbing at the keys with his fingers.

When his eyes went back to the mirror, he saw Reza over top of her. Charlie’s knees were up on either side of his waist. She scratched her nails over his back while they kissed. He could hear soft moaning sounds from Charlie’s throat.

Reza said, “You really need it?”

Charlie whispered, “I need it.”

“Beg for it.”

“No.”

Reza took his cock with one hand and tapped it on her tummy. Charlie squirmed and made a hungry sort of sound. She squeezed his hips with her knees.

“Beg.”

She whispered, “Fuck me. Please, please.”

“You want it?”

“I want it so bad,” she said.

“You need it?”

She ran her nails on his neck and said, “I need it.” The word need came with elaborate desperation.

“That’s my Charlie,” he whispered. His hips drew back, his round muscular rump raising up as the tip of that huge cock slid over her mound. When the head of it touched between her legs, Charlie mewled.

He prodded at her with it, and she gasped, “Oh wow ...”

“You miss it?”

“I missed it,” she agreed. “I missed it.”

“It’s all yours,” he said. “You want to take it?”

“I want to take it,” she whispered. “I want to take it all the way.” Her head had tilted back while Reza bit at her neck. Her eyes were closed and her mouth hung open. Her little pink tongue licked the ring of her lips. She said, “I need it so bad. Please fuck me.”

Jonny watched as Reza’s hips pumped forward slowly. He drove that monstrously thick tool inside Charlie and she hooked her ankles around his rump. She let out a long whining sound and Jonny squirmed in his chair. Both her arms hooped around Reza’s neck and she hugged herself to him. Her face was turned up and as their landlord inched everything he had inside her, Jonny got to watch the range of emotions that a big penis could deliver to his wife. It was tragic. It bounced from happiness, hunger, pain; regret, too. She bit her lips, she clenched her teeth, she gasped and coughed. One hand grabbed the bunched up muscles around Reza’s neck and dragged downward as he got deep. Red nail lines dragged across his skin, disappearing in the lion tattoo on his neck and shoulder.

“Yes, yes, that’s it,” Charlie gasped. “Fuck, mm, it’s so big, it’s so good ...”

Chapter Twelve

Reza was gentle at first, his hands caressing at her shoulders as he kissed and bit at her neck and collar. His hips did all the work. Dipping upward and backward, pushing and pulling, his huge cock making slick sounds between Charlie's legs. Charlie loved it. He had her practically wailing. Pleading yes sounds, an oh no, an oh yes-yes; she panted soft syllables and grunted. Her hands stroked all over his thick muscle. Her toes wiggled and clutched. She moaned and cried, and Jonny thought he might fold in two.

It felt like a hand as strong as Reza's had clutched his penis and testicles and squeezed. Squeezed hard. But his eyes wouldn't draw away from his wife on the bed.

Then Reza had her upright, his hands sliding up her ribs, his fingers curling underneath her arms, he sat her up with her legs draped over his hips. His knees were spread out on the bed and his cock was inside her still. Jonny could see his heavy testicles dangling underneath Charlie's spread legs.

Charlie kissed him and clutched at him. She was higher than him sitting on him like this, and she held his thick, muscular neck while they kissed. She panted and made soft crying sounds.

Reza leaned backward, putting his head on the pillow and watching her the whole while. He lay on his back and she sat atop him now. Their disgusting biological connection was fully revealed to Jonny, lit up by the glare of his monitors. Reza's wide, dark, and shaved cock stretched Charlie's labia into a thin pink ring.

Reza began to pump himself in and out of her again and it got Charlie whimpering. Jonny watched as those big testicles bounced and tumbled between his legs, flipping up and tapping Charlie's white butt cheeks and making them quiver.

Charlie worked with him as well. Not letting herself get fucked, she was active now. She had her feet planted on the bed, her knees up in her armpits. Reza held her waist and Charlie's legs flexed as she made herself bounce on his huge cock. It got Reza excited that was for sure. He was growling and grunting now, too.

This was an intense session that he hadn't seen between them before. A connection. Normally Charlie was a passenger in his vehicle. A woman who hated having to do what she had to do. Opening her legs and accepting his inhuman penis. Hating that it made her come. But right now, his wife was actively fucking Reza. There was no reluctance. There was no shame. Charlie wanted something, and she knew how to get it. She was trying to make herself come.

"Oh Fuck," Jonny whispered, and this time the two people on the bed were so engaged they weren't distracted by his outburst.

He punched a fist between his legs and it jabbed the metal cage into his pubic bone. The pain was sharp and bright overtop the grinding ache that was encompassing him.

Reza's hand swooped the flat of Charlie's back, turned downward and Jonny watched through squinted eyes as he ran his big middle finger along her spread crack, hooked it and slid it inside her anus. Charlie howled. A huge, joyous crying sound that propelled a stream of excitement into his pants. His hands stopped typing, and he clutched them both in fists. She was coming. Charlie was coming.

The howl turned to a long cry then diminished to a gravelly croak. She bounced and swiveled her hips frantically, her body shaking. Her hands had turned to fists as well, and she beat them on the heavy muscle of Reza's chest. Plaintive warbling vowels moaned from her mouth and she turned her chin up to the ceiling. Reza drove his cock in and out still, Charlie's slickness spilling copious fluid that drooled in lines over and around his scrotum. He wiggled his finger where it was inserted and Charlie collapsed on top of him. She hugged her cheek to his chest as he continued to work himself in and out. Her orgasm droned on, slick, sick, and lubricious. She

bit at her lips and drool spilled from her mouth and mingled with the hair on Reza's chest.

"That's it, Charlie, get that. You get it," Reza commanded.

Charlie's eyelashes fluttered, and Reza stroked her back.

Reza said, "That what you want? That what you need?"

Charlie didn't answer, just moaned.

"You come to Daddy to get what you need, don't you?"

Reza slipped himself from inside her, took his cock and beat it against each of her butt cheeks. He toppled her off of him, got on his knees. Charlie lay on her front, looking lifeless. He grabbed her hips and pulled her to her knees, her face dragging on the mattress. He took his cock, pulled back the foreskin, the huge bulb of his cock head gleamed in the monitor light. Jonny watched as it was slurped up by his wife's opening.

She moaned and kicked her feet, her toes curling up. Reza spanked her, pushed himself deep, and Charlie cried out.

"That's it," he growled. He gripped her tightly by the waist and pounded her hard. The bed began to shake and rattle. Jonny could see her face twisted up, as if in pain, but lips parting and panting as if she loved that pain. "You miss this cock? You miss this?"

"Yes," she gasped, and a spike punched in Jonny's chest. He hitched a breath, one hand clutching his stomach the other his heart right now.

"You love this cock?" Reza growled.

"I love it," she cried. She was out of her mind.

He pounded her harder, pushing her face down on the mattress until she was laying flat on her stomach. Charlie was spread eagle on her front, her skinny white legs skewed past Reza's hairy, muscular thighs. He could see

nothing but Reza's round ass as it pumped in and out, that huge thing going in and out of his wife.

Charlie gathered up fistfuls of sheet and pulled it up to her face. She came again, crying out loud into bundled up fabric.

Jonny kicked his legs outright and tried to suspend his body like a board leaning against his workstation chair. It did nothing to alleviate the pain. It stretched his stomach which eased the stabbing hurt, but couldn't stop the intense grip that seemed to clutch at his penis and balls. He turned sideways and dug the thumb knuckle of a fist into his kidney. "Oh God," he groaned, "Aw, fuck."

Reza hoisted one of Charlie's knees up to her chin and exposed her fully. He spread his legs wide as he fucked her. Jonny watched his balls bang around against Charlie's buttocks and thigh, tapping against her pink but reddened pussy.

It went on like that for far too long. Ten minutes? Fifteen minutes? Reza gave Charlie what she needed.

She came two more times. Undeniable cries of ecstasy ripped from her as an orgasm found her again and again. And when it was Reza's turn finally, he had Charlie on her back, curled up with her knees at her shoulders. Her feet bounced over his back, flexed and curled. She cried and cried, pain and pleasure. Reza pounded. Charlie's nails ran circles on his back.

"Here it comes," Reza warned her.

"Yeah," Charlie gasped.

"You want it?"

"Yeah," she gasped again.

Jonny was dripping sweat. From his brow, down around behind his ears, wet ran in ticklish rivulets. He needed this to be over. The pain between his

legs was excruciating. Despite it, there was no way he would miss this either.

Reza pounded and held it in her deep. His body shook and trembled. Charlie cried and hugged herself to him. He pulled out and shoved in again. His balls lifted and fell, lifted and sagged heavily. He growled like a lion, then roared. He pulled out, shoved in one more time and the headboard rattled against the wall under the kitchen pass-through. Charlie bucked underneath him, kicking her legs. She cried out one more Yes! Then they were still for a while, both of them heaving breath.

Reza's body glistened with sweat. Charlie's hands began to move over his skin. Reza kissed at her neck and made a low chuckling sound. Charlie was done though. She squirmed out from underneath him, and Jonny saw the shame there in her expression. She wiped at her face with both hands and dug her fingertips along the ridge of her brow. Reza watched, laughing quietly the whole time. He lightly slapped at her haunch then squeezed her knee. He said, "Don't worry, Charlie. It's our secret."

Charlie said nothing, and he grabbed her by the tummy and pulled her back against his chest. His hands explored her body, finding places where she was ticklish. She squirmed in his grip. Now she was laughing and smiling, too. "Stop," she told him, but his hands kept moving, even running a finger between her butt cheeks. She kicked her legs and jumped away from him. "Stop," she said again, and she hit his muscular arm with the heel of her fist. He laughed, and she did, too.

They stared at each other for a moment, Reza smiling and Charlie trying not to. At last he said, "Feel better?"

She rolled her eyes and shook her head. She sat forward now, gathered up her undershirt. "No," she said firmly.

Reza knew he was right, and he grinned, put his hands together behind his head and lay back on the pillow to watch her. She held the bundled undershirt between her legs and dabbed at herself. Then she wiped vigorously and seemed to try to pull out the sticky semen from her slit. She

flexed her tummy a little, wiped again, and threw the undershirt toward the closet where her dirty laundry basket was.

Reza watched her back, Charlie looking toward Jonny. He'd assumed some semblance of a working position, fingers moving slowly, tapping away nonsense still, his insides ripped apart, his cock squashed and ruined in its metal cage. He'd spilled what felt like a quarter-gallon of pre-come into his pants. Sweat ran down his face and he licked at his lips, his eyes watching Charlie in the mirror. He saw that she was smiling now and it at least lifted his spirits. He didn't know how this ache would ever leave him and he regretted ever making the decision to have his penis locked in a cage. Was it worth it? Was any of this worth it? It was too late, anyway. It was way too late. All he could do now was code, finish his game, win. Get his life back. But the thing Reza had said stuck in his mind. Even when you do, you'll never be able to give her what I do. No matter how successful your game is, she's grown to want something that you can't ever provide. And he knew it was true now. Saw it with his own eyes. He could make \$100 million off a video game and Charlie would never beg him for his cock. She would never grow grumpy from his cock's absence. He would never give her orgasms like she got from the landlord. He sighed, held back a choking sob that jumped up from his heart.

Charlie got off the bed, and she tiptoed around behind him. He watched her come toward him in the mirror. Then she was there, her hands lifting the muffs of his headphones. She kissed his ear. He swiveled around in his chair, hoping the shadows of the table would hide the stain he was sure was between his legs. She's looked at him warmly, then she kissed his cheek.

"What was that for?" he asked her.

She said, "I'm sorry."

"Sorry for what?"

"Sorry I've been so grumpy. I've been a real jerk. I took it out on you, and that was mean. I really am sorry." She cupped her hands around his neck, put a knee on the seat of his chair and hovered over top of him. He took her mouth in a kiss, sought her tongue. He found it, pulled it into his mouth,

and his tongue danced around her slippery shape. His cock surged again, pushed out against the tight confines of his cage. He didn't care anymore. He had to have her. He had to have her in his life. His time would come. It would be next week. The cage would come off and he would have his time with his wife. He just had to hold on a little longer. Take advantage of this time to do the work that needed to be done. Do the work that would end the nightmare.

He let her kiss go, and he looked in her eyes. She made a giggle, shook her head. She was naked. His hand went up her waist and cupped her breast. She laughed, put her hand over top of his. She whispered near his ear, "One more week, Jonny. One more week."

"I know," he said. She kissed his forehead then, jumped away from him before he wanted to touch her more. He went to grab for her bottom, but she skipped away laughing. Her hands came down to cover her ass from his view and he laughed watching her trot into the bathroom and close the door. He looked at the bathroom door for a moment, smiling. He flicked the mirror away in case he would get an errant view of his arrogant landlord watching from the bed.

Turned back to his monitor, he closed down the window of text-nonsense, opened up the window he had been working on and began coding again. The metal's bite on his genitals slowly faded as his mind grew obsessed again with winning her back.

III

The Cage Comes Off

Chapter Thirteen

On the morning of the 14th of the month, Jonny's 'Day of Release,' Charlie promised him she would be right home after work. She'd even withdrawn the necklace from around her neck and dangled it before his eyes, the key to his cage's lock swinging back and forth like a hypnotist's pendant. She even mimicked the old style talk of a circus performer, taking on the creepy tone she picked up while watching *The Twilight Zone*: "You're getting sleepy, Jonny, you're getting sleepy and when you awake, I'm going to be kissing you ... and poof! your cage will be gone ..." She wiggled her fingers like she performed a magic trick. They'd both laughed and then stopped abruptly as Reza came out of the bathroom. She'd tucked the key back in her shirt and they both looked at each other with held back smiles.

Sure, technically, at least according to him, it was the 'day of' and that meant if he wanted to, he could have thrown Charlie down on the bed and get the deed done right away, but it would be nice if Reza wasn't there, and it would be nice if it was just the two of them alone.

So now he shifted his weight from foot to foot, standing sometimes, pacing other times. It was early evening. Charlie was late coming home. Fifteen minutes past due. He didn't know if he could wait any longer.

It'd been another productive day of work. He'd skyped with Shulamit, and damn it, that woman impressed him again. Javed was up-to-date as well. He passed out new speculations for them and felt a promising enthusiasm from both of them. They liked his game. This was going to work. And today he would be with his wife. But the last fifteen minutes of expectation were killing him.

At last he heard footsteps approaching. He bent each leg, flexing as if he were about to begin a 5K run. He winced from the pain between his legs, then ended up limping into the kitchen. His cock wasn't hard, but it wasn't

shrunken and small right now. It was alive with anticipation. Pumping with possibilities.

He could hear now her keys jingling on the other side of the apartment door. He snatched it open before she could put her key in the lock. He took her in his arms, and she yelped. He surprised her snatching the door open like that, but she fell into his arms and she kissed him back. When they broke their kiss, he took her hand and led her into the apartment, mule kicking the door closed behind them. He said, “Come on. Let’s get into bed.”

“Hold on, Jonny. Hold on.”

“What?”

She had something to tell him that she didn’t want to. Her face made a pained expression as she thought the best way to break it to him.

“What is it?” he demanded.

She said, “Jonny, Reza came by work today.”

“Oh no, it’s my day, Charlie. It’s my day. There’s no way around it.”

“No, I know. He said it’s your day. That’s not it.”

“Then what is it?”

Her eyes darted around the room, stalling for time as she was reluctant to tell him the bad news he knew she had. “He took the key, Jonny.”

“He took the key to my cage?”

“He took it. He said he had to be here when it was done.”

“For Christ sake, Charlie.”

“What am I supposed to do?” she asked, thrusting her hands out.

He said, "It's not you. I'm not mad at you. Jesus Christ." He thumped his fist on his hip and it jolted his penis inside its cage. He hissed and made a pained face

She said, "Are you okay?"

"No, I'm not okay. Jesus, Charlie, I've been working like crazy all day. I couldn't wait for you to get home. I've been going out of my mind. You're fifteen minutes late and I thought I was going to explode ..."

"I'm so sorry."

"Don't be sorry, it's not you, it's fucking Reza. God, I can hardly walk," he said, and he turned his back to her and went down into the apartment putting his hands on his hips and exaggerating the limp he walked with. There was a shooting pain traveling on the right side of his groin that went up under his rib cage like a wire pulled taut. His testicles ached. His penis was so sore. The skin itched. The cage had a hole he could pee through, and he did his best to keep the thing clean, but it had been two weeks now. This wasn't right.

Charlie was behind him then, and she put her hands on his back and rubbed him.

He said, "Why did you let him take the key?"

"I tried to stop him. But he just ..."

"Charlie, you know how much agony I am in?"

"It's not easy, Jonny. He came in at work and people were there and he started talking and I didn't know what to say. He told me I was supposed to give him the key, and I didn't know if I was or not. In the end, he just took it from me ..."

"Did you try to stop him?"

"No," she said sheepishly.

He shook his head. Then he walked away, out of her grasp. She followed him. He sat himself down on the corner of the bed very carefully.

She said, “Is it sore?”

“Is it sore? Of course it’s sore. Charlie, I have a tiny cage wrapped around my dick. I’ve been wearing it for two weeks. I can’t get hard, but you’re around me every day.”

She smiled a little, liking to hear that her husband was aroused by her. Neither of them wanted to address the fact that it was her activities with another man that had been driving him crazy.

She said, “Is it really itchy?”

“Would you look at it?”

“Okay,” she said, and he sensed she wanted to add something. He knew what it was. A reminder that she couldn’t do anything until Reza was here.

“Please, Charlie.”

“Yeah, I’ll take a look at it. We need to make sure it’s okay.”

He unbuckled his pants and did down the zipper, pushed his underwear and pants down his hips and sat back to show her his locked up penis and balls. He said, “It’s so tight. Maybe you could put some more ointment on it.”

She said, “I could. I can’t do ... anything, you know?”

“I’m not asking you to. It really hurts and I want you to put some ointment on it.”

“Okay,” she said, and she got close to him, putting her hands on his thighs and looking at his small bundle. She looked it over, and he could admit that it didn’t look like there was anything going on that needed medical attention. She said, “I guess I could put some ointment on it.”

“Please.”

She made a bit of a smirk, but then she left him there, went to the bathroom and came back in with the tube of ointment. She settled herself between his legs and pushed his pants upward. He said, “What are you doing?”

“He could be home any minute, Jonny. Don’t have your pants down too far.”

“I can get my pants up quick.”

“Okay,” she said, squeezing out a dab of ointment onto the tip of an index finger. “But I think he has cameras in here ...”

The truth was he didn’t need ointment. He just wanted her to touch it. It had been so long and they had got so close that his mind was getting anxious. Before she put the ointment on him, he reached down and held her hand. He said, “Come into the stairwell with me.”

“The stairwell?”

“He doesn’t have cameras there. Come into the stairwell with me ...”

“Jonny, I can’t.”

“Why not? It’s my fucking day, Charlie.”

“He’ll be here soon.”

“That fucking asshole will come here at five to midnight and you know it.”

“Please, Jonny, don’t make me do something that I’ll get in trouble for.”

“You’re my wife ...”

“Jonny, just wait a little longer, I’m sorry.”

His heart beat strongly in his chest, and he stared at her and realized he was glowering. She looked a little fearful, timid, shy. She bit at the inside of her mouth, smiled a little, then tapped his bundled up testicles with her ointment blob. She said, “Boop-boop,” as she tapped his testicles with her

finger. It made him flinch, and she giggled. She ran her finger around in circles, getting the ointment good and smeared over him. His penis grew hard quickly, pushing the cage outward and pulling his testicles up. He made a hissing sound.

She said, “See, Jonny. I shouldn’t be doing this ...”

“Keep going.”

“Jonny, it hurts you. Reza is mean, but he’ll be here. He keeps his word.”

“Maybe just grip it, stroke it a little, please, Charlie.”

“Jonny, don’t be difficult. You’re getting me all stressed out. Let’s just behave. How did you do today? Did you get lots of work done?”

The last thing he wanted to do right now was talk about work. His cock was throbbing hard, he’d been promised release, and now that was dragged a little further from his grasp. He clenched his hands and fists. He didn’t answer her. She went back to his testicles, rubbing the ointment and going in nice gentle circles to spread it into his skin. Not trying to pleasure him, but he appreciated it just the same. He said, “Maybe put it in your mouth. Lick the cage a little with your tongue.”

She tsk-ed loudly and rolled her eyes. She said, “Come on, Jonny,” and she stood up stepped back. “Pull up your pants. He can walk in the door any minute. Just a little while longer, okay?”

He groaned now and held his stomach. He felt like he just done a hundred sit-ups in two minutes. He ached all through his core. His penis was pushing hard against its confines again and his testicles were being strangled. He looked at her, all pretty and dressed for work and loving. He smelled the light smell of her soap and shampoo and he ached to be with her.

A little. While. Longer.

“Okay, okay,” he groaned, and he fell back on the bed. His hands came down and grabbed his belt and pulled his pants up by it, did up his zipper and closed away the most prominent thing in his mind. All his focus was shifted between his legs. At least he did get some work done today.

Now he told her, “Work is going really good, Charlie. I swear to God, this is good. These coders are worth it. Worth wearing this fucking thing,” he said and slapped at the cage between his legs making it jiggle.

“I’m glad,” she said. “I’m glad. Let me get undressed ... I mean changed into my after work clothes, if you know what I mean.”

“Lingerie?” he groaned.

She kicked his shin lightly with the tip of her shoe and said, “Later, silly. There’re leftovers. Want me to reheat them? Come sit with me on the couch, watch some Twilight Zone. It’ll take your mind off it.”

“Fine,” he sighed with great drama. When he sat up, he winced again.

She said “You’ll be okay. He will be here. You know he will.”

“I miss you so much,” he said.

“I miss you, too,” she said, and kissed his forehead and hugged his neck.



The dreams that came to him while he slept with Charlie in his arms on the couch were turbulent and filled with wild unnameable sexuality. Flashing lubricious images of wet sex membranes, Charlie’s glossy lips, huge engorged cock heads like soft, supple army helmets and they were free of cages and slick with pre-come and Charlie’s saliva ...

He awoke with a start and his heart was pounding and lust sizzled through every artery, vein, and capillary. It burned in him like a hunger.

Reza was home.

He startled, jumping up to a sitting position, Charlie tumbling off his chest and snorting herself awake, gasp-mumbling: “Wha—?”

Their landlord stood at the end of the couch, leaning against the wall at the foot of the stairs from the kitchen. He was smiling while he watched them sleep.

The way Jonny sat upright quickly pushed the cage sharply down on his already hurting testicles. It made him groan, double over, and he curled himself into the corner of the couch with his head thumping on the armrest. His hands went to his stomach.

Charlie said to a chuckling Reza: “Today’s the day.”

“I know it is,” Reza said.

Charlie’s warm hand stroked circles on Jonny’s back and she said, “Where were you? He’s really hurting.”

Reza said, “I bet he is.”

Jonny’s hand moved from his stomach down lower and cupped his aching testicles. Charlie’s hand slipped over the back of his and held his hand softly while he cupped himself. She said to Reza: “He’s really hurting, and his balls are way bigger than they should be.”

That made Reza chuckle again, and he said, “So they’re almost normal size now?”

Charlie ignored the insult, just whispering, “Please ...”

Reza took in a deep breath, and Jonny heard him shift his weight off the wall and approach them. He said, “A deal’s a deal. Today’s the day, Jonny. Sit up and look at me.”

Jonny did, hefting himself off the arm of the couch and putting his back against the cushion. He looked at Reza standing there with his hands in his pockets. He wore a suit again today—there'd been a lot of business meetings in Reza's schedule these days. Jonny said, "I need my cage off. I'm really hurting. I can't think straight, where's the key?"

Reza said, "I don't have it."

Charlie gasped an exasperated sound. She scolded him: "Reza, don't do it."

Reza pulled his hands out of his pockets and showed them his palms as if in surrender. He said, "It's no trick. I don't have it, but it's coming. It'll be here soon."

Charlie groaned and rubbed at her brow. She said, "Today's the day, and it's late ...? My Jonny—Reza, he isn't doing very well."

Reza said, "I know. But I'm a man of my word. The key will be here any minute now and we'll take care of Jonny's problem. He can get back to work. And then in two weeks we'll do it all over again."

"Okay," Charlie whispered. She ran her fingernails in circles over Jonny's shoulder. She said to him, "Are you okay?"

"No," he kind of laughed. Then to Reza: "Who has the key?"

"I gave it to Charlie's mother."

Jonny's thighs clapped together and his eyes shot wide. Charlie made a high, frightful squeak in her throat.

"You what?"

Reza chuckled and smiled so wide the twisted ends of his mustache lifted from his face. He said "I'm kidding. I'm kidding."

Charlie leaned her body against Jonny, and he put his arm around her. She rested her cheek on his shoulder and mumbled, "That wasn't funny."

Reza said, “I beg to differ. You should’ve seen your faces.” Then he cocked his head and both he and Charlie heard it, too: footsteps in the hall.

Reza said, “I bet this is your key coming, Jonny.” He trotted up the steps to the kitchen door and opened it. All three of them waited, eyes peering in the gap to see who would arrive. The footsteps grew closer and Jonny realized there were two people coming.

His mind flashed multitudes of possibilities. From what would be expected to the worst case. Somehow Reza commandeering Shulamit and Javed, the two of them showing up to see exactly what they got themselves into ...

But it was only a second or two of horror with his mind flashing possibilities before the frame of the open door was filled with two figures. It was Genesis, walking with her arm locked through Tate’s.

Chapter Fourteen

Charlie groaned, “What’s she doing here?”

Genesis strolled into the kitchen as Tate pulled her coat off her shoulders. She made a tsk-ing sound, sucking her teeth and lamenting: “Aren’t you as happy to see me—”

Charlie tilted her head and murmured, “It’s not that ...”

“—as I’m happy to see you?” Genesis continued.

Tate and Reza smiled.

Charlie’s manners took over. She said, “I’m happy to see you, too, Genesis.”

Reza said, “That’s better,” and now extended a gesturing hand for Genesis and Tate to step down the stairs ahead of him. He followed behind, and all three of them came to stand in front of the couch.

Jonny’s heart—already suffering from the stress of sexual frustration—now surged even more strongly. What was Reza’s plan? What did Reza have in store for him now? Why had he brought these people?

The real fear was whether or not he would be able to properly perform with an audience. Given the tension and hurt in his stomach he didn’t think it would be an issue, his biology would take complete control over his mind. And yet his mind started to say, Are you sure about that, Jonny? ... Charlie’s counting on you here and it sure would be awful if you couldn’t get your little half-penis up for her in front of these three. And once that doubt crept in ...

Charlie said, “The key, please? Which one of you has it?”

Genesis said, “What key?” She looked to Reza with a perplexed expression. She whispered to him, “I thought you said not to bring it?”

Reza said, “You didn’t bring it? I said that you should bring it.”

Tate said, “Well, where is it? Is it back at your apartment? I’m not going all the way back there ...”

Charlie said, “Why would you do this? This isn’t what we agreed to. Why do you always have to be so mean? I don’t like it.”

Genesis said, “I’m sorry, Charlie. I misunderstood ...” She came now a few steps and sat down on the couch on the other side of Charlie and put her arm around her. Charlie wriggled away but not far enough that Genesis couldn’t hold her. Charlie made a scowling face.

Jonny could smell Genesis’s perfume. A bright and sharp concoction of tropical flowers and something feminine, something that made him think of the smell of good sex. He groaned and covered his stomach with both hands. He said, “She can use her hand ... use her hand over ... over the cage. It won’t matter ...”

Genesis scoffed, and she rolled her eyes. “You guys are no fun,” she said, and she dipped her hand in the front of her black low-cut blouse that showed off her modest but upright bosom. She pulled out the pendant of a necklace and let it hang over her stomach. It was a small key.

Charlie slapped her thigh with an open hand, and said, “Reza!” her voice harsh and scolding.

Reza chuckled and said, “I guess she did bring it.”

Tate said, “I hope that’s the right one. There were so many keys ...”

Jonny’s hands slipped up and down his thighs and came to rest over his testicles again. They felt round and plump even through his pants. The tension in his stomach was excruciating. He said, “It’s not funny.”

Tate laughed, and Jonny thought it was the first time he'd ever seen that. He apparently did think it was funny.

Charlie glowered and said, "Tate. Don't laugh."

Tate wiped the smile from his face and nodded to her.

Reza said, "Give me the key, Genesis."

Charlie said, "Give me the key." She held the cup of her palm out expectantly.

Reza said, "Charlie, you know that's not how this works."

Charlie said, "This is taking forever. I told you he was hurting. Can't you see it? Look at his face."

Reza said, "All in due time. This is all part of our agreement."

Genesis hooped the necklace over her thick mane of black hair, and that smell of flowers washed across the couch again. She slung the necklace to Reza, and he caught it in one hand. He held the fist before them, the key clenched in it, the chain of the necklace dangling under his knuckles.

Charlie said, "Let me unlock it. Let me do it for him."

Reza said, "Oh no, I don't want you near Jonny's penis."

"Come on, don't. Just let me do it."

Reza said, "No. You'll touch it."

"I know. That's what we're here for."

Genesis said, "No, boo-boo." She ran her long fingernails in circles over the middle of Charlie's back. "That's what I'm here for."

Charlie's head whipped from Reza to Genesis and back again. She said, "What?"

Reza said, “Today is Jonny’s release date.”

“I know ...”

“Genesis is here to release him.”

Charlie frowned, and her face began to show the beginnings of anger. In a low, feminine, but gravelly voice, she asked: “The cage?”

“Yes. And the release.”

Charlie shot up, standing now before Jonny. She got between him and Reza. “No way. No way.” She was pointing in his face. “There’s no way, Reza. She is not having sex with him.”

Reza showed his hands and said, “That’s okay. We leave the cage on.”

Charlie slapped both her thighs with her hands and stomped her foot. She said, “Why is it like this? Why is it always like this? We do everything you want.”

Reza said, “I know. You do. You’re both very good. This is the agreement. Didn’t you read the papers you signed?”

Charlie shook her head and looked at the ceiling. She said, “There wasn’t anything about sex in those papers. There’s no way you could put that in a contract.”

Reza said to Tate, “I guess she didn’t read them.” He peered around Charlie and said, “Did you read them, Jonny?”

“I did,” he groaned, squeezing his thighs together to relieve the pressure. “There was nothing about sex and you know it.”

“Look, I don’t know what to tell you,” Reza said, “this is the way it is. I mean, maybe tomorrow I’ll call and we can get copies of the contract from Solomon. Go over them one more time and see.”

“Aw, come on,” Jonny groaned.

Reza said, “Today’s Jonny’s release date, and that’s why I have Genesis here. So are we going to do this or what?”

Charlie said, “No. We’re not going to do this. I want my Jonny.”

“You can’t have him, sweetheart,” Reza said. His voice was soft and sweet but there was menace in his eyes. Charlie was bewildered, her mouth hung open frozen with words she was unable to say.

He said, “Just tell me that we don’t need to do it. I’ll send Genesis home and we’ll see how everybody feels two weeks from now.”

Charlie said, “You expect me not to have sex with my husband for months on end?”

“I don’t expect anything. That’s all up to you. If you really need to have sex with your husband, maybe we can renegotiate.”

“What do you want?” she said solemnly.

“Right now? Nothing. I have everything I want. I don’t know what will happen in the future but at least I know there’s some room to dance.”

Charlie said, “Genesis can’t have sex with Jonny.”

Reza said, “Can she blow him?”

Charlie jumped back like somebody shoved Brussel sprouts into a kid’s mouth. She crossed her arms over her chest and said, “No, she can’t blow him.”

Reza said, “Genesis, honey, I’m sorry I brought you here. I’ll make it worth your while but you know ...”

Genesis put her hands up and said, “No, I understand. That’s all right. I was looking forward to this, but ...”

Charlie said, “Wait.”

She stood there motionless for a long moment with all of them staring at her. Her eyes darted back and forth, staring at nothing as she contemplated what she would do. When the moment grew long and tense and it seemed she would say nothing, Tate offered: “How about Genesis uses her hand?”

Reza snapped his fingers and smiled. “Great idea. How about that, Charlie? Genesis can use her hand.”

Charlie turned around with her arms folded and stared at Jonny. Her eyes trembled and looked wet. She would cry in a moment.

Jonny said, “It’s okay. I’ll figure it out. We don’t have to do anything. Genesis can go.”

Reza said, “What a brave, brave boy. Look at you.”

Tate nodded with grave admiration. Genesis said, “You sure? You look like you’re gonna die.”

Jonny breathed heavy for a moment, both hands still between his legs and massaging his testicles. He said, “I don’t want to see my Charlie cry.”

For whatever reason that got Genesis. Maybe she didn’t have a black heart like Reza. Her mouth quivered a bit, and Jonny swore he saw her eyes get teary like Charlie’s. She even cocked her head and made a soft sound.

It emboldened him. Made him feel proud. He continued, “Just go. Everybody go. I just need to lay down.” He leaned forward as if he would stand, his face twisting unexpectedly with the pain in his stomach.

Charlie said, “Wait.” She put both her hands on his shoulders. He looked at her and they stared in each other’s eyes for a dozen heartbeats. She sniffed wetly, said, “Okay.”

Jonny said, “No.”

Charlie shook her head no now and said, “Jonny. You have to.”

“I don’t.”

“Jonny, I don’t want to see you in pain.”

He said, “I don’t want to see you in pain.”

Charlie whipped around now and said, “She can use her hand. But I want to kiss him.”

Reza said no.

Genesis stood up now, agreeing with Charlie. She said, “Reza. Look how sweet she is. How can you be so cold to her? These two are in love.”

“So?”

Genesis sidled up against Reza and whispered in his ear. It was brief, but she pulled away smiling and Reza rolled his eyes. He smiled at Charlie.

Charlie smiled, said, “Okay? Can we do that?”

“Yes. Fine.”

Charlie’s head drooped with relief, her knees dipping and her hair swinging behind her as if she might pass out. She turned to face Jonny with her hand over her stomach and a big smile on her face. A tear had rolled from one eye. She said, “Okay?”

“Yes,” he said, and he couldn’t wait to feel her lips on his.



Charlie disrobed in front of them all while Jonny watched, his cock beginning to throb in its cage. Tate watched her. Reza watched her. Genesis watched her, too. But Charlie’s eyes were on him. Sucking on her lower lip and smiling, she pulled her top off over her head. She didn’t care anymore.

She'd been naked with all of them. She'd had sex with Reza, had sex with Genesis. She'd given Tate a hand job.

It didn't matter. This was all for him. Right now she was all his. It didn't matter that he wasn't going to have sex with his wife, it only mattered that they were together when he came.

Charlie stood there without her top, still smiling, slipping her hands into the waistband of her shorts. She shimmied her hips and slipped them down her thighs and let them fall to the floor. Then off her panties came, too, and now his wife was totally naked in front of them all. She hopped lightly onto the couch next to him, getting on her knees, leaning against him. Her face hovered over his and her hair fell down to cover them from the others.

"You ready?" she whispered.

"I love you," he said.

"I love you, too, Jonny," she said, and she caressed his cheek and kissed him lightly.

Reza said, "Not quite yet."

Charlie said, "Oh, come on. You're being ridiculous." She was mad again.

Reza said, "You have to wait. Wait until it's time." He motioned to Genesis, and she nodded. She came toward Jonny in her tight skirt and her tall heels, her squat, sexy, shapely body rippling with muscle underneath the tight fabric. She got on her knees and pushed his legs wider. She said, "Let's see what he's got."

Reza said, "It's not much. Don't get excited."

Genesis made a cooing sound, and she pouted at Jonny while she undid his belt buckle. "They tell me you have a little one."

Charlie leaned against him and watched, her fingernails lightly scratching at his neck. "It's perfect," Charlie said to Genesis.

“We’ll see about that,” Genesis said, and she smiled as her fingernails armored with long glossy nails began to tug at Jonny’s zipper. His thighs turned to trembling iron, and the feeling of her sexy body between his legs made his eyelids flutter. At this point he didn’t even care about being revealed. They would taunt him about his size but he would accept it.

Genesis dragged out the opening of the zipper, gently swaying and dancing between his knees as if she were excited about the revelation and wanted a buildup. With his buckle open and his zipper drawn down, she ran her fingernails over the bare skin of his belly just below his navel. Tufts of his pubic hair stuck up in the V of his open pants.

Charlie bristled next to him, not liking to see Genesis scratching her nails on her husband’s skin. Now Genesis pressed the fabric of his pants to find the cage underneath; the ridges of its wires pressed out the cotton. She traced her fingers along the shape. “Not very big at all,” she whispered.

“Please,” Jonny muttered, the plea coming from him unbidden. He needed to be touched. He needed release.

Genesis made a throaty chuckle and began to tug his pants downward. The cage holding his genitals flicked free and stuck up almost straight from his body. Genesis laughed. Reza smiled.

“Oh no,” Genesis said, looking at it. “That looks so painful.”

He’d grown erect. His cock shone red-blue where the skin bulged through the gaps in the gridwork of his chastity cage. His arousal had pushed the tube of the cage straight upward, the steel ring that circled his scrotum had yanked on his testicles so they were halfway up his shaft, huge, shining, and purple looking.

Charlie sighed, “Oh, Jonny, oh, that doesn’t look good.”

Genesis said, “It doesn’t look good. I think it’s time we got this off you.”

“Please,” he muttered again, and it was like another person in the room saying it.

Genesis put her hand up with the palm facing Reza, waiting for the key. Reza let it dangle above her palm, the key swinging in circles like a water diviner until he settled it on the flat of her hand. She took it and Reza stepped back again. With the tip of her finger she flipped the cage's lock upright and slipped the small key into it.

Charlie said, "Don't pretend it doesn't open. Take Jonny's cage off right now."

Genesis lifted her eyes to meet Charlie's gaze, and she flashed her a friendly, feline smile.

With a twist of the key, the lock was released. She hooped it out from the hasp and set it and the key on the floor. With the tips of her fingers over the bulbous end of the cage, she tugged a little, finding the cage wouldn't budge because he'd grown so hard against it. Genesis frowned, said "Uh-oh, it seems to be stuck."

Charlie said, "It'll come off."

Genesis wagged it to the left and to the right, tugging on it gently, and soon it began to slip upward. Every bit of shaft it revealed blossomed and ballooned free from its constraint. The skin showed marked red lines where it had been pressed. Jonny whimpered and groaned as Genesis continued.

"There we go," she said as she got it near the end. She pulled it free and let it make a soft metallic thunk on the floor next to her knee. Jonny's cock sprang upright, marked with hurting lines and showing a throbbing purple glow. He'd never been harder. The flared coronal rim of his glans stood out prominently.

Charlie made a soft sound seeing it, and she whispered, "Are you hard for me?"

Not even caring who overheard him, he said, "I told you. I told you I'd be fine."

She whispered, "I wish we could be together."

“We will be. Soon, we will be,” he answered.

Genesis said, “It’s not very big at all. Look how cute it is. It’s so little ...” She cocked her head from side to side and moved around so she could see it from different angles. Jonny groaned and held his stomach. A sudden spate of clear pre-come flowed from him. It pulsed strongly, then ran down his shaft and made Genesis laugh. “Oh, look at this,” she sang, “somebody’s excited.”

Jonny clutched his stomach tighter. He flexed to hold back the propulsion of his semen, but even doing that now he could see it still pulsing silvery streams in time with his heartbeat. The excitement couldn’t be held back.

Genesis made spiders with her fingers and walked them up the inside of his khaki pants clawing over the open fly, and with the tips of her two index fingers she began to stroke lightly in alternating swipes on either side of his cock. At her touch, he moaned. More pre-come jolted from his tip in a shimmering spew. Charlie made an uncomfortable sound, and she hugged his neck.

Genesis now opened her hand wide and let Jonny see it coming toward his erection, showing him her palm and then inexorably moving at a snail’s pace, fingers closing and closing until she had the slightest, featheriest grip on his erection. He thought he might come.

His head whipped back, and he thrust the crown of his head into the couch cushion. He looked at the ceiling. The feel of someone’s bare, warm skin against his aching cock was the greatest delight he could imagine. He could feel more excitement streaming from him.

When he looked again, he saw rivulets of his pre-come running over Genesis’s fingers.

She said, “It’s so tiny. It’s barely bigger than my hand.”

She stroked a half-inch upward and pre-come spurted from him almost as if he’d ejaculated. She looked to Reza and said, “This isn’t going to take too long at all.” Reza chuckled. Tate watched grimly.

Jonny said to her, “Not too fast. Don’t make me come fast.”

Charlie whined, “Jonny,” and she turned his face to look at hers, her brow lowered sternly.

Looking in her eyes he said, “So I can hold you. So I can put my hands on you. When I come, this will stop and I won’t be able to touch you.”

She kissed him. Put her lips against his and held his cheeks between her hands. He felt her knee press into the couch as she threw her other leg over top of him and straddled his hips. Now she was over top of him and he was looking up into her face. She purposely ran her hands through her hair and closed it around them so it was just the two of them. She whispered, “Fuck me. Put it in me.”

Chapter Fifteen

“Oh, Charlie,” he sighed, his brow low and troubled. He’d never heard her speak this way; it was so loving and understanding, and yet so incredibly dirty.

“Put it inside me,” she whispered again, and wiggled her hips. She was nowhere near low enough, and he looked down her body to see her bare sex hovering over his navel. He tugged on his shirt and bared his stomach. He ballooned out his tummy and felt his skin press her sex.

“Yeah,” she whispered, and she pooched her labia against his navel. “Make love to me,” she said now, and she took his mouth with another kiss.

His hands went over her, running up from her hips and over her back. They circled around her shoulders came down her ribs then quickly to the front to cup her breasts. That was when Genesis began to stroke him. He gasped into Charlie’s mouth and made a whimpering sound.

She said, “I feel you, Jonny. Do you feel me?”

He nodded and kissed her again.

Genesis squeezed his balls, and he cried out. His hips began to pump as if he were actually having sex with his wife. She swiveled and rolled with him, her hips doing a little Charlie dance over top of him as if they were connected sexually. They were. Not biologically. But mentally they were one right now.

Genesis’s hand was like warm wet velvet and she worked his cock with care. The pleasure was wild and intoxicating. He couldn’t breathe. Up and down she went, squeezing, teasing, caressing his balls. He worked with Charlie, focusing on her, wishing the moment could last forever, but it had been two weeks without ejaculating. It’d been two weeks of torture.

Watching her taking a pounding, watching her go away without him, watching her in videos sent surreptitiously that showed her with other men who put their hands all over her. Then he saw her beg for their landlord's big cock because she couldn't stand to be without it.

"Oh, oh wow," he blurted as semen exploded from him. He bucked and jumped and Genesis squeezed his cock in her grip. He heard her giggling. Stream after stream shot from him, and it just kept coming. His cock surged and flexed and propelled his pent up lust up in strong, explosive pulses.

"I feel it, Jonny, I feel you coming," Charlie whispered right into his ear and ran her thumbs over his cheekbones.

He squeezed her breasts and every muscle in his body tightened to steel. His stomach rolled in and out and he felt Charlie's damp sex make puckering suction against the flat of his stomach.

Tate muttered Gross, and Genesis laughed. Reza made no sound and he couldn't see the man—he pushed the thought of his existence away.

Charlie hugged him, kissed him, his neck, his ears, his cheeks. She stroked his face with her thumbs. She whispered, "I love you."

"I love you, too," he groaned, one last surge spewing from him. There was slick, disgusting, sopping wet sounds from Genesis's hand gripping him. The relief was enormous. A white sheet of unconsciousness fell over him like a drape and his mind somersaulted backwards. He swore he would pass out. It was heaven. The release had come. He felt enormously empty, he felt bottomlessly happy, bottomlessly relieved. His back sank into the couch cushions with a heavy but weightless depth—like a floating anvil.

"Oh my God," he cried, and he kissed Charlie's collar. "Oh my God."

The pain ebbed from his belly and balls, the tension spilled away.

Charlie smiled, kissed his cheek and looked in his eyes. She said, "I think you came all over my back."

“I think I did, too,” he sighed. He wiggled his head lower, Charlie knowing what he wanted, raising up and feeding him her nipple. He sucked it, found its shape swollen, the tip of his tongue dancing over its bumps. She giggled.

When she came back to face him, she whispered, “God, I’m so horny. When this is over Jonny, we are going to go crazy.”

“We are,” he said.

Genesis said, “Don’t you want to see?”

It made them both flinch, reminding them they weren’t alone. Charlie shook away her hair and the light of the room was revealed to him again. Over her shoulder he could see Tate watching, his nose turned up in a disgusted sneer. Reza watched with a blank expression, his hands in his suit pockets. Charlie shifted sideways and looked over her shoulder with a soft gasp. Jonny saw it, too, Genesis showing them her hand. It was covered front and back with white ropes of his semen. Jiggling webs connected all her fingers. She said, “It had been a while, huh?”

Charlie made a scoffing little sound.

She said, “What are you going to do with that?” There was a tinge of worry in her voice.

Genesis waved her sticky fingers at her, then moved her hands between her legs. Charlie jumped. Jonny looked down to see the long fingernails of Genesis’s hand stroking at Charlie’s pussy. She spread Jonny’s semen over his wife’s sex. His stomach flinched at the erotic sight of it. His balls began to ache again even though they’d just been emptied. He wanted to go again right now. He could do it right now. He was still hard. He had a feeling he’d be hard for a long, long time.

“Oh wow,” he sighed.

Charlie liked it, cooing at the feel of her husband’s semen being spread over her. Genesis worked her magical fingers until Charlie made soft whimpering sounds and her hips began to wag back and forth.

Between her legs, Jonny could see now Genesis's hands gathering up some of his semen into a sticky puddle held between her fingers. She pushed it up inside Charlie and let three fingers slip up deep inside her.

Charlie looked up to the ceiling and sighed, "Oh-ho, oh wow, oh wow, mm, I love it ..."

Jonny's stomach jumped again, and the urge to put his penis inside his wife overcame him. He slipped his hand down and pushed on the top of his erection to angle it to enter her. Genesis slapped his penis away. Then with both hands spread on Charlie's butt cheeks she pushed her forward until Charlie's chest squashed his face.

"What are you—?"

The soft wet sounds of Genesis sucking on Charlie's pussy came.

Charlie squeaked, "Oh no, oh don't do that. That's Jonny's ..."

Genesis licked what she had spread over Charlie's pussy. Charlie didn't stop her, but it was killing her. Pleasure and regret twisting his wife's heart in a knot. She cried soft moans and clutched Jonny's head to her chest. He could feel her rib cage wracking with a soft sobbing sound. Genesis continued; Jonny could feel her working between his legs, rolling her face from side to side up and down as she licked Charlie clean. The front of her dress, her bosom, mashed against his balls and his rock hard erection throbbed with his pounding pulse.

Charlie clutched his head tightly, both her arms hugging around him and her hands cupping his ears. She gasped right next to him, "Oh, this is so terrible," but she panted with ecstasy at the same time.

Charlie came. She squeezed his head so tightly his ears rang and his face must have turned purple, choked off by her clutched arms.

She groaned, "Oh no, oh no, it's coming, oh no," and then she tightened on him and it felt like his head might pop off. Her body jumped and shook over top of his. He let it happen, let her enjoy it. It was terrible but somehow it

was beautiful. Somehow he was involved in it. He rubbed her back, let his hands explore her, even stroked over the globes of her ass cheeks and let his fingers find how slippery Genesis had left her.

Genesis was gone, and his hand was free to explore. Touching her was not forbidden. It just had not been a good idea over the last two weeks. Touching her lead to complications between his legs. Painful complications. But this was fine. This was fine because he wore no cage right now. He took two fingers and slipped them up and down his wife's wet stripe, found the ruffled lips of her swollen labia and parted them. He slipped two fingers inside her and she sighed, "Oh Jonny, oh, that feels so good."

"You feel so good," he told her.

"That's your fingers?"

"That's me," he told her.

"You feel so good ..."

"Do you think you'll come?" he asked her, then his hand was pushed away.



Jonny batted the hand away, determined to enjoy his wife's slickness a few moments longer. His fingers stroked at her, moving up and down and teasing into the shallow depths of her aperture. The hand returned to push his away again, beating at his fingers lightly. He flicked it away. It persisted, prodding at his hand again. This time when he went to flick it, he realized it wasn't a hand. The tips of his fingers grazed the gummy surface of Reza's cock. He could tell it was Reza's because his fingers snagged on the man's thick foreskin and he felt it glide backward. His thumb slipped over the slick and smooth top side of Reza's enormous cock head. He didn't knock it away.

Without being prompted, without being cajoled, he knew what Reza wanted and he wanted it, too. The tips of his fingers now retracted Reza's foreskin fully, baring that plump, swollen shape. He wiggled it around against Charlie's slick membranes. It made sticky sounds, the two of them primed and ready for action, both greasy with their own sexual lubrication.

Charlie felt it now, and she made a sougling gasp past his ear. Jonny had guided another man to enter his wife. He held Reza's cock firmly in place and Reza pushed himself inside Charlie. The man's thick shaft bumped and slid past his fingers, sinking into her slowly. Charlie made a whimpering cry in Jonny's ear. Her nails dug into him.

"Oh, oh no, oh, oh wow," she grunted.

Jonny's fingers were widened as the thick base of Reza's erection slid into Charlie further. He removed his hand.

Charlie whispered in his ear so only he could hear, "You're so big, Jonny. When did you get so big?"

He breathed in sharply. His cock shot to electric steel suddenly. Reza withdrew almost fully and slipped deep inside her again.

She whined in his ear, "Oh Jonny, you're too big. Oh, you're so big you're tearing me up."

"Oh Charlie," he sighed, his loving wife doing amazing things to his heart and to his mind. Reza pulled back and plunged in harder.

"Jonny, your cock is so big it hurts. It hurts so good ..."

Out and back in again.

"Oh, Jonny, I never knew it could ... could hurt so good ..." She dragged her nails on him.

Reza gripped her waist, held her rump firmly in place and began to steadily stroke in and out of her pussy. Charlie lost her concentration for a moment,

making soft desperate whining gasps in Jonny's ear as Reza fucked her. It sounded like she was being hurt, but it sounded like she liked it, too.

The rhythm of Reza's pounding had his balls swinging. The way the three of them were sandwiched, his much larger and heavier testicles collided each time against Jonny's. It felt like heavy pool balls smashing against hollow candy-shell Easter eggs. Each strike of the man's large testicles against his flashed white over his vision and put a pulse of swirling pain in the center of the stomach. But it joined him in the action. Charlie's words, the feel of her body being rocked, the implication of the other man's testicles against his own united him in the action. His hands moved up above Reza's and gripped Charlie's breasts. Her nipples were like rubbery rocks against his palms.

"Ah, shit, Charlie," he whispered, "you feel so tight."

She made a giggling whimper, and whispered in his ear now, "Your cock is so big, Jonny, your cock is so big ..."

"Take it," he whispered.

"Jonny, I can't. It's too big. God it's hurting me ... but don't stop, please don't stop ..."

"I won't stop, Charlie," he said, "I won't stop till you come."

"Oh Jonny," she gasped, and her nipples hardened further in his hands.

His own hips began to pump, being beckoned to join in. For a moment he could imagine he had something like Reza had. Something so large and masculine that despite the discomfort it might bring, the pleasure was so much larger in scale and his wife could endure. She could put up with being stretched because it came with the brightest of orgasms. "Can you take it?" he whispered, "Can you take how big I am?"

"No, Jonny, you're way too big. You're way too big, please, you have to come, it's splitting me ..."

“You come first,” he told her.

“I’ll try, Jonny, I’ll try,” she whispered. And she actually did. He felt her body shifting, tilting to accommodate Reza’s thrusting from behind. She made muffled sounds of complaint and the strikes of Reza’s testicles against his own became more pronounced. Jonny grunted as well. But just like Charlie, the pain wasn’t too much to endure because the pleasure was so much larger.

“Jonny, ah, Jonny, you’re gonna make me come, your huge cock is going to make me come ...”

“I want you to Charlie. I need you to ...”

“Make me come, Jonny, make me come with your horse cock ...”

“You feel it ...?” he said, “Come on my cock, Charlie ...”

She couldn’t answer anymore, and her face drew back. It was twisted up like a kid who’d skinned her knee and was just on that precipice of bursting into tears. Her eyes had squinted shut and her mouth was down-turned. Her lips shone wetly, and they wriggled with the impending orgasm. She blurted, “Oh, Jonny,” and it came out in a cough. A thin strand of saliva hung from her lip.

“That’s it,” he said, “That’s it, come for me, Charlie,” he whispered and he squeezed her breasts hard.

She cried out loud, a plaintive sound of lust and sadness and pain but also enormous pleasure. And with that his own cock jolted. He looked down to see darting ropes pulsing from his tip and up onto his T-shirt. Charlie saw it, too, arching her back and tilting her breasts toward him. She looked down her body and watched him ejaculate. She let out a huge sound. More coughing, more crying. Happiness in there, too, and wild pleasure.

But now she was taken from him, Reza’s fingers dug into her hard belly and pulled her upright. Jonny could see the man’s hairy, muscular thighs spread

out on either side of his own legs, the landlord squatting low so he could thrust up into her.

Jonny watched the thick wide base of his cock slipping in and out of Charlie. His huge testicles dangling and bouncing and batting off the inside of her thighs. Charlie panted, blinked, and looked bewildered. She caught his eyes for a moment, and she smiled. She looked down his body, looked at the darkening stains up the front of his T-shirt and smiled wider. While Reza fucked her, she flashed him a peace sign. Then he realized it was the number two she flashed because she said, "That's two times, Jonny. I got you two ..."

He wanted to laugh, and he wanted to hug her. Even in the midst of this horror, he could find something so amazing. The love of this woman. His perfect, pure, and innocent girl. She would do anything for him, no matter how bad it was; if he asked she would engage. She would endure. And she was resilient. More resilient than he could ever have imagined. Here she was taking pain and pleasure for him. Sure there was pleasure, he got that. But somehow he knew that she didn't want this. She didn't want it, but it needed to be done. She was his partner. And in the midst of it all, the two of them standing in a nuclear apocalypse, naked and afraid in a wasteland of gray ash, she could give him the tiniest of gifts. Those two long graceful fingers poked up in a secret signal just for them.

So he watched her with a smile on his face that he couldn't help. He laced his own fingers together behind his head and watched the most amazing woman in his life.

Reza's hands roamed her stomach and her breasts, and he fucked her from behind, doing it way too hard. Charlie's body was slender against his muscle. Pale against his dark. Hairless against his fur. She was incredibly beautiful. Then Reza ejaculated inside her.

He stiffened and thrust, held it deep, roared. His balls lifted and fell. He withdrew and plunged deep again, making a slick gushing sound. He roared again and his fingers dug into her flesh. She made a warbling cry and frowned.

“Fuck, yeah,” he grunted. Again: “Yeah.” He thrust deep one more time. Charlie whimpered.

Jonny’s heart hammered in his chest, and it was him who was breathless now, too. Breathing heavy, the sight in front of him too much for him. His eyes lost focus, became wide and CinemaScopic, taking in the rest of the room. He could see half of Genesis, sitting in the chair with her legs crossed, her shaved and oiled legs glistening, a tattoo swirling across her shin and down into her expensive shoe. She smiled while she watched. On the right he could see Tate fully. Tate watched with awed horror. His eyes glued to the action but perhaps not liking what he was seeing. He might not like it, but his cock did. Jonny’s eyes lowered down his body and could see the athlete’s huge erection pressing out on an angle the front of his sweatpants. There was a quarter-sized stain at the tip, this man also aroused by Charlie’s sexuality had produced his own lubrication. Jonny was disheartened to see that Tate was also incredibly hung. Behind the cotton of his sweatpants it looked like the man sported something about as large as what Reza had. And Charlie had described it as good-looking. His wife had jerked that thing off. His wife had told him she liked Tate’s penis. It was as big as Reza’s but maybe not hideous.

Sickness curled up in Jonny’s belly, and he tightened up as Charlie was released from Reza’s clutch. She collapsed overtop of Jonny again, her soft feathery hair falling around his cheeks. Her chin rested in the hollow under his collarbone and he could still see the perpetrators of his horror. Genesis gently kicking that crossed over leg and enjoying the show. Sneering at him. Tate still watching, now gripping his erection overhand. And of course Reza, backing away, out of breath and momentarily sated. His wide cock bobbed between his legs, upright, the foreskin beginning to slowly close over the head now that business was done. A jiggling strand of semen swung from side to side from his tip until it swung and stuck to his scrotum.

Reza panted, “Holy shit. She is so tight. Charlie, your pussy is unbelievable.”

Charlie made no response to him, only breathed heavy in Jonny’s ear. His hands went up and down her sides and found her skin damp and clinging. “You okay?” he asked her.

She said, “That was incredible, Jonny. You fucked me ... fucked me so good ...”

“We both came,” he said grimly, the excitement of the previous moment washing away from him now. The enormous truth of it all taking its place. He didn’t have a huge cock. He didn’t make her come with it. It was all another man.

“I love you,” he whispered.

“I love you ... love you ... too,” she panted and kissed his neck.

Reza squatted to retrieve his pants from around his ankles. He pulled them up and did up the button. His massive erection still poked out, the fly bowed around his massive girth. He was still out of breath, but he stepped back one more time, and ushered with a gesturing hand for Tate to step in. He said to him, “Take your turn.”

Jonny’s heart seized up again. “No,” he gasped.

Tate took a step forward, moving tentatively. His movement was slow, and his brow lowered, eyes wide. His gaze darted left and right and Jonny got the impression he was looking for a way out of this.

When he stalled, Reza said, “Take your turn, Tate.”

Tate stopped. Charlie sensed now what was happening behind her and flicked her gaze over her shoulder. Tate stood a few steps behind her, the front of his sweatpants pushed way out by his huge erection.

Nothing was said for a long moment. Genesis was watching, enjoying this disgusting burlesque show she’d been a party to. Curious to see where it would go next and knowing whatever happened she would like it. Reza had an insistent expression on his face. Tate was still speculative. A longer moment stretched thin and Charlie whispered, “Go ahead, Tate. It’s okay ...”

She swayed her hips, wagging her opening to this man he suspected she had a crush on. Jonny held his breath.

Chapter Sixteen

Tate shook his head. He didn't look at Charlie; he didn't look at Reza. He took a step back then his chin finally lifted. He looked around the room and said, "No. I don't think so."

Charlie made a sad sound in her throat. Reza said, "Tate. Do it."

Tate said, "No, I think that's enough."

Reza said, "She wants you."

Another long moment of silence, nobody knowing what would happen next.

Charlie said, "He thinks I'm disgusting," the last word squeezing closed as it turned into a pinched cry.

It woke Tate up. He shook his head as if he'd been asleep. He said, "No, no, Charlie. Not that at all," then he came to her, taking the two steps to the front of the couch. He dropped down on one knee and put his hand on the small of her back. He looked into her face earnestly. Jonny could feel the man's leg pressing against his. Even though they were so close, it didn't seem like Tate even knew he existed.

Tate said, "Charlie, don't say that. I don't think you're disgusting at all."

"You don't?"

"Not at all, Charlie. I don't want to do it like this."

"You don't?"

"No, of course not. Not like this."

“You don’t think I’m disgusting?” her voice was hopeful, luring him to say what she wanted to hear.

Tate smiled and looked at her with patronly warmth. “Charlie, I think you’re beautiful. I think you’re amazing.”

She watched his face for a long moment to see if he would taunt her next or take it back.

“Come here,” he said now, and he guided her up off of Jonny. She couldn’t look at Jonny, nor at Tate. She turned her head away and hid her face in her hair. Her hand stretched out and snatched up her pajama shorts. She took them and clutched them between her legs to sop up the mess that had been left there. She closed her thighs against the shorts and sat down heavily next to Jonny. She put her hands together and pressed them between her knees. Tate stroked an arm and her thigh. He said, “Look at me.”

“No,” she softly said.

Jonny said, “Leave her alone.”

Tate disregarded him. He said, “Charlie, please, look at me.”

She did, tilting her chin up and showing him her big, round, sad eyes. He said, “Don’t think that. Look at me. Don’t think that.”

She looked up, her pouty mouth pressed into a slim thin line, and they held their gaze for a moment. She nodded.

Reza was smiling. He said, “Let her use her mouth.”

Jonny saw Tate’s expression take another shape of exasperation, but it was restrained and hidden away from the man’s boss. Tate made no response. Charlie whispered, “I can do that for you.”

Jonny’s heart twisted up into a knot. All the good that had just happened, and now she was offering it to another man. He exhaled slowly.

Tate looked at her expressionlessly.

She repeated, "I can do that for you."

Tate thought about it. He licked his lips, his eyes looking over Charlie, flitting about the wall behind the couch. He said nothing more, stood up, knees touching the front seat cushion on either side of Charlie's legs.

She looked up at him, pulling her hair away from her face, looking a little hopeful. She said, "Can I do that for you?"

Tate looked conflicted. His body was rigid like he didn't want to turn around. He only looked at Charlie. At last he said, "You can do that."

"I can?" she said almost hopefully.

"You can," he said simply.

"Okay," she said, and she prepared herself. She turned her face to look at Jonny and gave him a sheepish sort of expression. He was frozen. He wanted to say No, but knew he couldn't. Even if she didn't want to, she would still do it. And now if she did want to? It was futile. The enormity of Charlie's desire to please this other man was infinite. It was like he stood in that apocalyptic wasteland alone now, looking all around and he couldn't find her anymore. She'd gone off with some other survivor.

Charlie leaned forward on the couch seat, shifted herself a little, her knees slipping in between Tate's. She gripped the front of his sweatpants' waistband, the dangling string between her thumbs. One more time she looked up to him and asked: "It's okay?"

"Okay," he answered.

She pulled the front of the sweatpants down and they were loose so the waist slipped right down over his hips and underneath his buttocks. His huge hard cock sprang free and bobbed in an undulating W pattern before Charlie's face. She watched it bounce. Jonny saw what she meant. It was big. Maybe not as big as Reza but it was really close. And unlike Reza's it did have a certain aesthetic quality. It was long and thick and arrow straight. Maybe not as wide as Reza's, but definitely girthy. He had been

circumcised, and it was a good job, no scars, and a nice folded envelope of skin right behind the large flared cock head. The skin didn't shine, wasn't red, wasn't too veiny. The plump glans had flared swooping shapes; not too pointy, not too blunt. No wonder Charlie liked it. A short, fat, dangling thread of clear pre-come dangled from his tip. Charlie waited for his cock to stop swaying then she extended her shimmering pink tongue and slipped it up the underside of his shaft and collected the semen in the cup of its curl. Her mouth swallowed his glans.

Tate hissed an intake of breath. "Oh Charlie," he sighed. Now his hands came together and pulled up his T-shirt. Slowly, chiseled abs were revealed, and Jonny's black chrome jealousy wormed through him again. Every bit of his body tensed to steel, and he had a sudden instantaneous thought: Get the fuck out of here. Don't watch. Don't watch, this will kill you. Get on that fucking computer and type your fucking fingers off. Now!

Only he didn't. He sat frozen and breathless. A lifeless shell, a sculpture sitting in the corner afraid to move. His eyes were frozen open. Charlie sucked on the end of Tate's cock, one hand coming up to press against her lips and stroke her saliva down his shaft. Charlie, who really wasn't that good at blow jobs six months ago, also cupped the man's large, hanging testicles and coddled them with just the right amount of gentleness. Tate's stomach muscles twitched. He let the shirt fall down one muscular arm and it draped over Charlie's knee. She sucked Tate's cock for ten minutes. Doing it properly. Doing it lovingly. He was too large to take deep, but she took what she could. Her hand did the rest. Stroking and slipping, the other one squeezing and tugging at his testicles. Tate's muscular stomach heaved in and out. The muscles of his chest flexed and twitched. Sometimes Charlie would pull right back, push with her hands on his cock, point it downward and she could look up into his eyes. Once he told her: "You're so beautiful."

Jonny could see her practically swoon. Then she closed her eyes and began sucking again. Soon the magic moment came. Tate held both sides of her face, tilted her chin up, the end of his cock still plugged into the ring of her lips. He said to her, "Can I come in your mouth?"

Cock still in her mouth, she nodded.

He whispered, “I won’t if you don’t want.”

Charlie let her lips come free, licked them, said, “It’s okay, I don’t mind.” Her hand kept jerking his cock head.

He said, “I’m going to come.”

She put him back in her mouth, hummed an Uh-huh around his dick.

“Okay,” he said, and he held her face still.

She watched his eyes while she stroked him, her mouth bobbing slightly, her tongue stroking up and down the underside of the end of his cock. Jonny’s own erection pounded between his legs. There was no way they could get a cage on right now anyway so no one bugged him about it. It was like a steely shaft poking up between his legs still shining from the dirty things that happened to it earlier.

Jonny watched Tate’s stomach heave in and out, the muscular athlete’s breaths snorting and chugging. Tate struggled to keep his eyes on Charlie’s, struggled not to narrow them to slits. His body tightened and grew still for a brief moment while Charlie kept sucking hard. And then he came in her mouth.

Charlie jumped feeling the pulses down her throat. She hummed affirmative sounds, letting him know she felt him. Humming ahs, humming okays, and mm-hmms. The whole while she tried to watch his face.

It slowed finally, Tate stroking the sides of her face and caressing her hair. Then her mouth began to withdraw, pouting lips coming to a point on the very tip of his penis, making a slurping sound like she was taking the last drag off a straw at the end of a milkshake. Then she smiled and licked her lips.

She lay back in the couch heavily, making Jonny bounce next to her. Tate’s cock bobbed up and down, slick and shining. He made an exhausted sound and then he smiled, too.

Now it was over, and they all knew Reza's badness would resume, he reached down and pulled up his sweatpants. Under the heather cotton, his huge cock made a large sideways tube across to his hip.

Jonny's head finally turned, taking in the rest of the room now. He hadn't even seen what was going on, so mesmerized by Charlie's actions, so bewildered by them. Reza had sat down, his cock still stuck out of his pants hard as iron. His eyes were wide like he couldn't believe what he watched either. Genesis looked like she might burst out laughing. Jonny's heart was breaking.



"Well, well, well," Reza said, "that was something." He sat in the red IKEA chair with his legs apart, his elbows on the arms, his hands clasped together under his chin; his thick arousal struck up straight from his open fly. "Something indeed."

Genesis agreed. "I'll say."

Reza said to her: "Did you see that?"

Genesis said, "Wow."

Reza said to Tate, "Can you go down and get the car ready now?"

Tate rotated his head around on his neck, said, "I will."

Reza said nothing while Tate reached down and grabbed his sweatshirt. Charlie watched all the big round muscles in the guy's body work as he pulled it over his head and shrugged it down his body, his big hands pulling the hem down to cover his huge arousal. Tate nodded to Charlie and something flashed in his eyes.

Charlie whispered, “Bye.”

Tate continued past the couch, trotted up the stairs lightly for such a big guy. He went out the apartment door disappeared into the hall and closed the door behind him.

Reza continued to watch Jonny and Charlie. Genesis continued to smile.

Jonny’s heart pounded. He looked at Charlie incredulously. She sat there naked watching Reza and Genesis, her legs closed tightly together, her elbows on her thighs. She still sat with the bundled short shorts wedged over her sex. Jonny reached out to her. Though they sat side-by-side she seemed so far away. He held her wrist, and she swung her hair away so she could see him. She smiled, let his warm hand grip her and then she moved her other hand to hold his wrist. She kissed his knuckles. It healed his heart at least momentarily.

Reza sighed finally, put a hand between his legs and lightly stroked his cock. He said to Genesis, “Get the ice pack.”

“Coming right up,” she said, lifted herself gracefully from the chair and strutted in her heels up the steps and into the kitchen. Now Reza watched Charlie. He said to her, “You go get on the bed. What you just did has got me wanting a lot more.”

She sighed petulantly and her shoulders slumped. Her head cocked. A lot different from when Tate asked her to do something.

Reza said, “Get on the bed, Charlie.”

“Fine,” she said, kissed Jonny’s knuckles one more time then stood. Jonny watched her pert bare ass lift and fall as she walked across the apartment on the balls of her feet. Totally naked, totally carefree. She was becoming inured.

She climbed up onto the bed on all fours and sat cross-legged, waiting.

Reza watched the kitchen archway until Genesis appeared again. She came down the three steps, her heels clicking. In her hand was a frosty blue gel-pack she'd taken from the freezer. Something Charlie kept there in case somebody had something injured or sprained. He used it on his wrists sometimes after long days of typing.

Reza nodded to her, and Genesis didn't need to be told what to do. Jonny frowned at first, but then figured what was in store. His cock was a piece of solid iron right now (nowhere near as big as Tate or Reza, but he was sure he could go toe-to-toe with them for hardness and come out on top), and Reza wanted the cage back on and it wouldn't go until he was flaccid.

Genesis sat herself next to him on the couch on his left side, right where Charlie had been. He wished Charlie was still there. Genesis moved her eyes on him like he was prey.

"What are you going to do?" he asked her, even though he knew.

"We have to make that little thing go down," she said.

"Whatever."

Reza chuckled, stood up now. He took off his suit jacket, unbuttoned his shirt and headed toward the bed. Charlie waited for him.

Genesis took her left hand and gripped Jonny's erection. He didn't know what to think of her, sometimes he liked her and sometimes he didn't. Sometimes she frightened him. Like right now. Her strong hand gripped his erection, and she examined it. She whispered, "Charlie gets so much better now."

"Stop it."

"Oh, you sensitive?"

"Just put the ice on it and leave me alone."

Genesis sighed and stroked him a few times. Charlie watched Reza approaching the bed but saw what was happening on the couch. She told

Genesis, “Please, don’t.”

“We have to get his cage back on, sweetie.”

“I can do it.”

Reza said, “You’re staying on the bed.”

Charlie said to Reza, “Please, don’t let her do anything dirty with Jonny.”

Without looking over his shoulder, Reza said to Genesis, “Just use the ice.”

Genesis said, “I was only teasing, anyway.” She withdrew her hand from Jonny’s cock, and he missed it as much as he was relieved. He’d ejaculated twice and the absence of the pressure in his abdomen was greatly cherished—he wouldn’t mind going a third time but it was asking too much. The fact that Charlie had helped him get off a second time was a greater gift than he deserved.

Genesis took the frigid pack, and she wagged it back-and-forth, bowing and curling it into an S shape. Flakes of frost fell and melted onto Jonny’s pants. She said, “It’s going to sting.”

“I know,” he said.

Reza let his pants drop and he pulled off his shoes, climbed up onto the bed with Charlie. She’d gathered up one of the pillows and clutched it to her tummy, hiding behind it. Her eyes watched Reza now.

Genesis took the base of his penis with a thumb and forefinger and pulled it out from his body so she could slip the flat of the icepack against his pubic bone. It stung so cold it burned. He hissed, and Genesis giggled watching his testicles disappear up into his body. Then she took the open ends of the ice pack sliding it so it was a nice fit and curled them around his aching erection like she wound up a sleeping bag. She held it in place with the palm of her hand.

Jonny watched Reza get over top of Charlie. She lay on her back, and Reza took the pillow out of her hands and threw it away. His cock was still hard,

huge, dark brown, and ugly against her pale and beautiful body. She opened her legs and covered her breasts.

Genesis said, “He’s going to ruin her pussy for you.”

“I know,” Jonny said solemnly.

“You better get that game done, junior.”

“I’m doing it.”

Charlie let out a frail and hurting moan as Reza slid his cock inside her again. Her knees lifted, and then she slapped the soles of her feet on the bed and whimpered.

It was funny because a week ago she wanted this. She didn’t have it for days and days on end and she missed it. Now when she had it, she didn’t want it. She was reluctant to take it. Would she miss it again? When this was over with her and Reza, would a time come when Charlie craved him? Or would it be Tate?

Jonny said, “I can’t watch it.”

“She make you hard?—” Genesis purred, “—even when Reza fucks her with that big cock?”

“It does.”

“You got it for her bad.”

“I do.”

“Don’t look,” she told him. His cock throbbed and throbbed from the frigid cold. He couldn’t tell if he was hard or soft anymore. All he knew was frigid pain and numbness. Detachment from his organ. “For your own good,” she continued, seeing his gaze never leave the bed where another man fucked his wife.

Genesis reached and covered his eyes. She used her thumbs to close his eyelids and he let her. She pulled her head to her bosom, and he rested his ear in the cup of her collar. Pressed so closely to her chest, he could hear her heartbeat. She smelled of beautiful perfume, and it was a very matronly thing that she did. He wondered if Genesis had children, and strangely suspected if she did she was a good mother despite the terrible things she did outside the home.

He curled up against her, cuddled himself and hid away from what was happening on the bed. Genesis made a soft singsong, something in Spanish maybe, gently humming and saying a few of the words, one hand gripping the frigid ice pack over his penis, the other one gently stroking his neck. But over top of her little lullaby, Jonny could still hear Charlie whimpering, gasping, and reluctantly moaning.

Even though his face was hidden, he clenched his eyes tightly until he saw twinkling stars. He couldn't shut up the sounds. And it wasn't long before he heard the distinct vocalizations of Reza making his wife orgasm with his huge penis.

Chapter Seventeen

The cage fit snugly again. Genesis had been kind, cleaning him off with a baby wipe from her purse before slipping it back on and closing it again with the lock.

He'd had to change his clothes. He made quite a mess from his eruption. His pant legs were spotted, his T-shirt was ruined. So now he was back in sweatpants, T-shirt, and an open flannel shirt. Coffee was brewing, and he was gonna be up all night coding again. He was closing in. And the relief he felt now was hugely helpful. Charlie had been closed in the bathroom now for fifteen minutes.

They were gone. All of them. Tate had gone down to warm up the car and bring it around to the front door of the apartment building. Reza had another appointment and said he'd be out again late tonight. Genesis left with him, arm in arm. Charlie had said nothing and just watched them leave, sitting cross-legged on the bed with a towel between her legs. She'd been used pretty hard.

When the apartment door closed, she looked at him solemnly. He could say nothing either. There was a tension in his heart, pressure like a grip, soft, not squishing, but making it hard to beat. The way she'd asked Tate wouldn't leave his mind. After a long while just watching each other and breathing and saying nothing, she finally cleared her throat and said, "It's back on?"

He'd been sitting there with the pillow over his lap, his pants fallen around his ankles. He nodded. She scratched her head and looked around uncomfortably for a moment then said, "I need to clean up." Then with nothing further between them, she disappeared into the bathroom.

He could get back to work right now but he was waiting for his coffee to brew. Plus the thought of sitting down and typing right away after all that had happened seemed so harsh. Like he should perhaps take a moment for reflection here. Yes, going full throttle all the time was the recipe for getting out of this, it was the roadmap, but if he didn't step aside once in a while, pull over to the side of the road and take a look at the scenery and breathe in the air, what was the point in the trip at all?

When Charlie came out of the bathroom, she saw him sitting there in the red IKEA chair where Genesis had sat. He was waiting for her. She stopped, made a funny face then leaned on the doorjamb. She twitched her nose a little, then said, "What do you want to do tonight? I don't feel like sleeping."

"I don't know," he said solemnly. "It's almost midnight."

"I don't think Reza is coming back until tomorrow."

"I have to work."

"I know you do," she said softly. She was wearing a fresh T-shirt and a pair of new pajama shorts. Her feet were bare, and they nervously played with each other, toes grabbing at toes while she talked.

He said, "I put coffee on. Are you going to go to bed? You could read."

"I guess. You want to come to bed and lay with me?"

"I'm wearing the cage again."

"Just to snuggle."

He inhaled deeply and held it. She watched him. He let the long breath exhale from his nostrils making a hoarse and harsh sound.

"What?" she asked timidly.

"What do you think?"

“I don’t know.”

“You know something’s wrong.”

“You’re just staring.”

“Just go to bed,” he told her.

Her body wavered, swaying from side to side, deciding what to do. Wanting to stand and talk to him more but thinking it might just be easier to flop into bed. Finally she said, “Tell me what’s wrong.”

“Really?”

“I don’t want you to be mad at me.”

“Then maybe don’t be so fucking eager to suck Tate’s cock.”

“Jonny,” she said harshly. Then softening she said, “I was not.”

“That’s what I heard.”

“I wasn’t. Not like you say.”

“You should’ve seen your face light up when he said you could suck it.”

Now the sheepishness reversed to the threshold of anger. She folded her arms, her brow came down. She said, “Sorry.” It didn’t sound like she was. It sounded like she was mad. The word came out as a condemnation.

“Did you see your face?”

“Excuse me, Jonny. Do you know what it’s like? Do you know what it’s like to have to suck a cock all the time? Do you know what it’s like to open your legs and take his huge thing? To be degraded? To be used?”

“You don’t ever turn them away.”

“How can I?”

“You lit up when he said you could put his dick in your mouth.”

“Exactly, Jonny. Maybe because for once it wasn’t going to be awful. Reza does his things to me and I let him. I do it because that’s what needs to be done. So, sorry. Maybe if you made some money, it wouldn’t have to be like this.”

“Charlie ...”

“Tate is the only one who’s nice to me. Everybody else is so mean and they only want one thing. Tate is considerate. There was no way I wasn’t going to do something with him. You know that, you know what Reza’s like. Stop being a jerk. There was no way around it. Reza was going to have me do something with Tate. So excuse me if for once it wasn’t going to be terrible. I don’t even know how you can talk to me like this.” She threw her hands up, shook her head.

Mad at her for defending herself, he went after her for something different: “I heard you beg for it, you know. I’m not stupid.”

“When?”

“Last week, on the bed, you made me put on headphones so you could beg Reza for sex.”

She scoffed. “So?”

“How does that make me feel? My wife on our bed, asking the landlord to fuck her—not because she has to but because she wants to.”

“I didn’t want to ...”

“You were rubbing your legs together like a cricket, you were so horny for his huge cock you treated me like shit for three days—”

“I did not, Jonny, take that back. Are you crazy? I wanted sex, yeah. I wanted it from you, you idiot but you got your little dick locked up in a cage, didn’t you?”

“Little dick?”

“I can’t believe this, Jonny. I didn’t want Reza. You have no idea. I should just leave and get out of here, for one week why don’t you let Reza climb into bed with you and he can stick his big fingers up your butt and you can try to suck his fat cock, let him shoot his stuff all on your face for a week, I’ll come back and we’ll see what you say.”

“You going to go stay with Tate?”

In all his years with her he’d never seen this reaction: she growled at him, a feminine roar that came out of her like a freight train. She stomped her foot like a bull and both her hands clenched in shaking fists at her side. Then she turned around, hefted the table lamp off the night stand next to the bed and she hurtled it against the closet door where it burst into a hundred pieces.

“Whoa, easy, Charlie, come on ...”

“Just forget it, Jonny,” she hissed.

“Don’t be like that, Charlie, you know what I’m saying ...”

“Just forget it,” she said again and now she stomped around to the other side of the bed, careful to pussyfoot around the broken shards of lamp.

“What are you doing?”

She didn’t answer him, yanked open the closet door and snatched out her jacket. She threw her arms into it, pulled out a pair of loafers.

“Where are you going?” he asked her.

She still didn’t answer. The jacket was long, coming to her mid-thigh, and she yanked tight the belt that went round the middle. She stormed around the bed again, and he saw her face briefly. It was pinched in anger, a scowl—and she was hurt, he could see that, too.

“Charlie, don’t go ...”

Her face was beet red and her mouth turned down like she might cry, and then she was gone. Past him, trotting up the stairs, the hard soles of her loafers making clacking sounds up into the kitchen. She left. She slammed the door behind her.

Jonny slumped. He watched and waited. He watched and waited a long time. She would get to the elevators and come to her senses. She never got mad. Never like this. Sometimes she might get frustrated but he could always get her laughing again. Not when she left the apartment though. He still waited. When she didn't return he timidly followed her path, went to the apartment door, opened it and peeked down the hall. She was gone. He couldn't believe it.

"Oh, Charlie," he sighed, "I'm sorry."

He watched down the empty hall for a few minutes and when there was still no sign of her he came back in and closed the door behind him. He came down into the family room, looked at his workstation. That was where he should be right now. That's where he was supposed to be. What would he do without her? What was the point in any of this if she wasn't around? Why did he say those things? He'd given away his greatest fear by that spectacle. Go be with Tate. And that's what she had probably done. Tate was the only guy that had shown her any compassion these days, she said. He didn't know where Tate lived but maybe Charlie did. Maybe she was sitting in a bus right now on her way there. She would go to his door and he would open it, when he saw her face he would take her in his arms. He would probably hold her and make her feel better, like a man should. Later, they might get into bed together and who knows what would happen? She'd already given him a hand job, and she'd already given him a blow job. It might be nice to lay with a man and feel his strength and his warmth and his care. She would probably open her legs for a man like that. He took in a long deep sigh and heard the sound of sadness wheezing in his lungs. Fuck it. What was he to do?

He did what he should be doing. He did what Charlie would want him to do. He adjusted the cage in his pants to make it more comfortable, walked to his workstation and brought it to life. Screens on, he shook his head then cracked his knuckles. His heart was wrenched with sadness but he had duty.

There were things he had to do. It would be nice to wallow right now, lay back and think of all the horrible things that could happen to Charlie when she was off and she was mad. But that's not what Charlie's husband should be doing. So he sat and typed like a crazy motherfucker.

Chapter Eighteen

It was two-and-a-half hours before she came home again. When he heard the apartment door, he jumped. Instant bursts of happiness went off in his brain and his heart like fireworks. But then they were muffled by the wet blanket of sadness. The way they'd left things were terrible. The things he'd said to her were mean. Even though he was hurting, he had no right to go after her. His typing slowed. He could hear her moving around in the kitchen up there, could hear the fissling of a plastic bag. Where would she go shopping at three in the morning? The only things that were open were twenty-four-hour drugstores and party shops. He wouldn't blame her if she took up drinking.

The door to the pantry closet in the kitchen opened, just a small sliver of space where they kept their cleaning supplies. He heard the sound of the broom being taken from the hook off the wall, the plastic dustpan banging against the shaft.

When he heard her footsteps coming down the steps behind him, he stopped typing and swiveled in his chair. Their eyes met, and she stopped and stood to watch him. Her mouth twisted left, it twisted right. She bit at the inside of her mouth. He could tell she'd been crying. Very softly, she said, "Hi."

"Hi," he said, waiting to see what she would do.

In her right hand she held the broom and in the other hand the dustpan. Still in her light rain jacket with the belt tightened around her waist, still in her loafers. It didn't look like she'd gone to Tate's apartment. She averted her eyes then, put her head down and walked to the other side of the bed.

"Oh," she said just as quietly as she'd said Hi. He'd already cleaned up the pieces of broken lamp. Used that very same broom to sweep it into the pan

and throw it all in the trash. Even taken a shopping bag with its jagged shards down the hall and dropped it down the garbage chute.

She let the broom rest against the wall, undid the belt on her jacket then turned around and looked at him again. She had something to say, but it was taking forever. The jacket was unbuttoned and thrown on the bed. Loafers were pried off. Now she looked around the room, her mouth moving around again and her hands gathering at her waist, her fingers working together nervously.

He started first, saying, “I’m so sorry, Charlie. I shouldn’t have said any of those things.”

Her knees dipped, and her head swung loosely. She said, “No, Jonny. No, no, no, I’m sorry,” and now she came to him, stumbling and falling on her knees at the side of his chair.

“You’re sorry?”

“I’m so sorry, Jonny. I’m so sorry.”

“You don’t have to be sorry—”

“I do, I really do.” She took his right hand in between both of hers and she squeezed it. She looked up at him pleadingly, her big, expressive eyes wet with fear and sadness. He caressed the side of her face.

She said, “You were right. You were right, and I was wrong. I shouldn’t have done that. I shouldn’t have been like that with Tate. You’re so right, I didn’t see it.”

“No, you were right. I know you’re right. I know how hard it is.” And now he hated being above her and having her sit at his feet. He didn’t deserve that position. He squatted and bumped the chair with the backs of his legs so it kicked away on its wheels. He dropped on his knees before her and they looked in each other’s eyes. “I’m the one that’s sorry.”

“No, Jonny, I’m sorry.”

He pulled her into his clutch and he squeezed the life out of her. She made a little soft grunting noise and laughed a little. “We’re both sorry, we’re both sorry, Jonny ...”

“We are,” he laughed, “we are.”

“We can’t be like that, Jonny, we can’t talk to each other like that. We can’t let them get between us.”

“You’re so right. You’re so right, Charlie.”

“I shouldn’t have been so nice to Tate. That must’ve hurt you.”

“It did. It hurt me really bad because I love you so much.”

“I love you too, Jonny. What I said was true. Tate’s nice to me. That’s all. But I shouldn’t have let you see me like that. That was a terrible thing for you to see. I get it. I do.”

“It doesn’t matter Charlie, it really doesn’t.”

They held each other for a long time, both their hands clutching and grabbing and smoothing up and down. He felt tears brim his eyes. That was all the sadness from earlier pushed away and washing down his cheeks. Happiness filled up his insides now. This was what it was all about. This was why they did any of it. They would get through this.

After a long while, both of them sniffing and occasionally chuckling and hugging each other too hard, they slowly came apart. Charlie wiped at her face and so did he. They both had big smiles now. She said, “Can you get in bed with me? Reza’s not coming home.”

“I’m supposed to be working.”

“You’re always working. We never get this chance. Please, Jonny.”

“Are you sure? Every minute I spend working is a minute closer so you don’t have to do the things you do.”

“It doesn’t matter, Jonny. The things I do, they’re not important anymore. What’s important is that you get into bed with me. I’ve been thinking ...”

“Thinking about what?”

“I went to the drugstore.”

“You did?” he said and had to wipe at his cheeks again, more wet spilling over.

“Yeah, I did. I bought pancake mix. The old cheap kind. I’m gonna make you breakfast—” she glanced at her watch, “—shoot, in just a few hours. Golly, and I have to go to work, too.”

“Call in sick.”

She laughed. “I’m always calling in sick. They’re going to fire me.”

“They won’t fire you, Charlie ...”

“Just come to bed with me. I want to do something.”

“What do you want to do?”

“Get in bed and find out, mister.”

He was on his feet before he could even answer. “Okay,” he said, and he shot his mouse into the hot zone to shut his workstation to black. He made his way over to the bed, pulled back the corner of the cover and slipped under it. Charlie was on the move, dancing lightly up to the kitchen. He called out to her, “Where are you going now?”

She didn’t answer, but he heard the fissling of the bags up there. Was she going to make pancakes now?

When she returned, coming down the stairs just as lightly as she trotted up them, he saw the front of her T-shirt pushed out by something she was hiding. She bounced onto the bed on her knees, crawled over top of him to get on the other side. He asked her what she was hiding.

She shushed him. She said, “Remember—what if he has cameras ...”

“Do you care? Care what he sees?”

“I do. He makes things difficult. What he can’t see won’t hurt us.”

“What are you up to?”

She bit her lower lip while she fumbled with something under the covers. She said, “He doesn’t have cameras underneath the bed sheets now, does he?”

“No,” he said tentatively.

“Push your knees up, Jonny, take your pants down.”

“Ho, wow,” he breathed, his mind instantly alert, and suddenly his cock surged against its steel restraint. He said, “Did you get the key?”

She shook her head no, and he heard her pop the top of a plastic lid.

He said, “I’m still wearing the cage, Charlie.”

“I know. But it won’t stop us from fooling around.”

Butterflies fluttered all through his stomach, and they turned sharp and gnashing as they lashed through his system. He was overwhelmed with lust. But it was also love. His heart swelled up in his chest as he watched her happy face as she tried to get sexy with him and make the best of their situation.

“Fool around?” he whispered.

“I want to see if I can make you come even with that stupid thing on your little penis.”

“Little penis?” he said, hurt but smiling. Liking it.

She said, “Your little, pathetic pee-pee.”

“What’s gotten into you?”

She said, “I love you. That’s what’s got into me. Reza is trying to make me forget. But I won’t forget, Jonny.”

“I love you so much ...”

“Give me your hand,” she said, and she looked around the apartment as if she were trying to spot something.

He asked her, “Are you looking for cameras?”

“He always knows what’s going on. How do you think he does that?”

“I don’t know,” he said, and he bumped her stomach with his hand. She took it and squirted something warm into it.

She said, “Use it on me ...”

“Where?”

She rolled her eyes. “Where do you think, silly?”

He ran the heel of his hand down her taut stomach, found she’d slipped off her panties already. He said, “Where are your panties?”

“Who cares?”

It was a good point. He flipped his hand over and found her shaved sex. She was warm and swollen and inviting. Eager for his touch. She’d been with Reza today. She’d sucked Tate’s cock today. But it was him she loved. He could feel that was true. He teased her with his fingertips.

He said, “What is this stuff?”

She whispered, “It’s lube. It’s flavored. Cherry.”

He groaned, “My cage is killing me.”

She eyed him, smiling while she bit her lower lip, and he heard her squirt lube in her own hand now. She shimmied a little closer and rotated her shoulders toward him. They faced each other now, laying on their sides. Her hand went between his legs and she reminded him: “Keep your knees up so he couldn’t tell what we’re doing under the covers. He’ll suspect, but he can’t prove a thing.”

“Okay,” he whispered, getting into it.

When she touched him, he jolted, and they both laughed. Her fingers went all around the shape and tines of the cage. The skin of his penis pushed through the gaps and she stroked him. The tip of her finger played into the cage’s center hole that allowed him to pee and she teased his urethra. The cage tightened further, and the ring pulled up on his testicles. He grunted and groaned.

She asked him, “Does it hurt?”

He said, “It’s killing me.”

She said, “I’m going to suck your little balls.”

His heart jumped and his stomach tightened. “Holy shit, Charlie,” he sighed, and the cage pinched him harder.

She slipped herself underneath the covers before he could stop her, and he stared at the ceiling. He could feel her mouth breathing against his sensitive skin. Then her tongue began to flick at his swollen testicles. The pain of the tightening cage became excruciating, but there was so much pleasure in it as well. She kissed his testicles, she ran her tongue over their pulled-taut shape. She closed them both in her mouth and gently suckled. Her hand caressed the steel cage and he could feel the movement of her grip even over the metal. Her hand carefully stroked him.

She kept at it, her movements light, feathery, and teasing. There was so much pain and stress involved, but his heart was pounding with pleasure, too. It took ten minutes of agony and joy but he finally blurted out, “Oh my God, it’s gonna happen, oh Charlie, it’s gonna, mm, happen ...”

She continued stroking and suckling, and he could feel the snort of a soft laugh against the wet of his scrotum. She moved her hand quicker, took his balls in her mouth again. And that was it. His body bucked and shook, and he ejaculated through the end of the cage and up onto his stomach while she made happy sounds under the sheets.

He lay there feeling the movement of his beautiful wife between his legs, writhing between the pointed up triangles of his knees. She worked her tongue around him while the throbbing subsided. The pain began to release as his heart rate slowed and his hardness faded. Then she worked away a little higher and her tongue began to flick at what he'd ejected from his strangled testicles. She sucked it up off his stomach, and he reached under the sheets to cup and caress her head while she did. She used her mouth to collect it all, worked her way higher then kissed both his nipples. When she emerged from the sheets she was smiling. He kissed her forehead, and she closed her eyes. She said, "Your turn."

Epilogue

Even better than Charlie's dedication to him—shown through the loving act she performed with him—was the feeling of waking with her in his arms. After she'd used her mouth on him, sucking on his testicles while her hand stroked over his cage until he came, he'd taken his turn on her. That was something new. Wasn't something that hadn't been done between them just not a thing that Charlie had ever really looked for before. But she asked him to do it. Before all this began, his time with her in bed between the sheets was usually spent in a mainly missionary style. And while she seemed like the sweet woman she had been back then, her sexual experience had definitely expanded. She eagerly told him it was his turn. That was exciting.

She'd flopped over onto her back and opened her legs and waited for him to get under the covers and use his tongue on her. It was heaven. There were benefits to this arrangement with Reza. Even, possibly, he'd made her come. He didn't ask her if she faked it. That would be rude. It wasn't a huge orgasm. She didn't beat the sheets with her fists or anything. Didn't do the things that came out of her when Reza pounded her with that monster between his legs. But she definitely responded to the strokes of his tongue.

The best part though was being gently woken not by an alarm or the snoring of the beast that usually slept in this spot next to his wife but sunlight coming through the windows and heliographing off the tall buildings in the city out their view. The feeling of her body heat against his, the feel of her flesh and bones held in his arms. The feel of her soft cheek against his chest. The smell of her hair in his nose. She was special. There was no doubt about it.

When they were both done pleasing each other under the sheets hidden from the view of Reza's cameras hidden in the room—if there even were any—she'd snuggled up to him and it honestly felt better than when he'd ejaculated. She got real close to him and said, "That's three." He said,

“Three what?” She said, “That’s three I got you despite wearing your silly little cage,” showing him three held up fingers, closing them then into a small, gentle fist and beating it lightly over his heart. He hugged her tight. That was how he fell asleep.

Charlie moved against him now, beginning to wake as light filled the room with the dawning sun. He let his hands stroke up and down her arms, encouraging her to join him in the land of the awake.

“Good morning,” she finally whispered, and he kissed the crown of her head and breathed her hair in. It’d been a long time since they woke together and he didn’t realize how much he missed it. The feeling was profound. Their love was real, and it had been startlingly absent. Charlie had returned it to them even despite her blowup over his selfish, petulant reaction to what she did with Tate. He whispered, “I’m gonna make you pancakes this morning.”

She pushed away at him lightly and said, “Oh no, you’re not. No way. I’m making pancakes. I bought them special for you and I want to do it. You get in that chair and get back to work today.” She gave him a serious face. She was right. He kissed her forehead, used the pad of his thumb to caress the shapes and contours of her perfect face.

He said, “Okay.”

They both sighed and held each other for a moment longer. But Charlie had to go to work. And there was no denying that he had a lot to do himself. So she slipped out of bed after darting a kiss on his lips, and he watched her trot naked to the closet and throw on a robe. She closed it up, gave him a quick, honest smile then danced to the kitchen.

As she banged pots and pans around and thumped things on the counter, bringing out mixing bowls and spatulas and measuring cups, he stirred, got out from under the sheets and put his feet on the floor. It was like starting over. This was like day one. His relationship with Charlie was restored. All the horror and fear that had been working its way between them was gone. All he had to do now was finish his game and get this over with. And he was getting there. Shoot, he was practically done. It wouldn’t be long

before they had a complete beta they could pass around. If he could get it picked up ...

On the coffee table across the room he saw his phone light up with a silent incoming text and he got up and pulled on some sweatpants, being careful with his cage. Charlie lightly hummed in the kitchen and he heard the distinct sizzle of bacon hitting a hot pan. She might've been trying to imitate their meager life from before, buying cheap pancake mix, but she still liked her little, tiny luxuries. He wasn't going to complain, not about bacon that was for sure.

He grunted, seeing the text on his phone was from Reza. He flicked the screen and brought it to life.

Jonny, great news. Boy, you're not gonna believe the opportunity I have for you. Come by the gym today. Come by at 1 PM sharp. I got an amazing proposition for you. You're going to freak.

He'd marked it XX. Asshole. He thumped himself heavily down onto the couch seat. The spot where he sat last night and watched Charlie suck Tate's big, beautiful cock. The badness of last night seemed so different now in the light of dawn, but this electronic message he held in his grip right now was bad news. An opportunity?

"Bre-eakfast," Charlie called sweetly from the kitchen. He slipped his phone into the pocket of his sweatpants and joined his wife in the kitchen. She was moving gracefully in her robe, legs and feet bare, a big, happy smile on her freckled face. She arranged pancakes and bacon onto plates for them. She even fried two eggs. He sat at the kitchen table where she'd put ketchup and real maple syrup. Another luxury he wouldn't complain against. He tried to smile but couldn't. As she brought the plates to the table, she looked so innocent. She frowned when she saw him.

She asked him: "What's wrong? What's gotten into you?"

He ran his hand up her knee and across the back of her leg. “Breakfast looks amazing,” he said. “Nothing’s wrong, Charlie. Don’t you worry about a thing.”

She set the plates down and sat next to him watching him with a suspicious and tentative smile. He tried to show her his own smile. Deep down, he knew that this opportunity Reza would present would be something terrible for Jonny. It was an opportunity for Reza. It would be torture for Jonny. And it was Charlie who would suffer. He just knew it.

He reached out and put his hand over hers and they ate using only their forks and holding hands while the sun came fully up and lit the kitchen.

Afterword

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